a slight understatement

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/69230621.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationships:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Chrysos Heir Members & Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon & Stelle (Honkai: Star Rail), Cyrene & Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Stelle (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Tribbie (Honkai: Star Rail), Cyrene (Honkai: Star Rail), Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Anaxa (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher (Honkai: Star Rail), Herta (Honkai: Star Rail), Screwllum (Honkai: Star Rail), Lygus (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Chrysos Heirs as Found Family (Honkai: Star Rail), Angst and Humor, Post-Amphoreus Trailblaze Missions (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon Needs a Hug (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon is Khaslana (Honkai: Star Rail), Other Additional Tags to Be Added, Written After Version 3.5 (Honkai Stair Rail), Phainon is an Emanator of Nanook | The Destruction (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon is Not Okay (Honkai: Star Rail), Post-Amphoreus Phainon Character Study, Eventual Romance, This is going

to be long, Eventual Happy Ending, Phainon Levels of Angst, Anger, Phainon-centric (Honkai: Star Rail), Five Stages of Grief

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-08-14 Updated: 2026-07-07 Words: 82,200 Chapters: 28/?

a slight understatement

by IlluminaMint

Summary

> “You had to go through that *thirty-three* times?” Tribbie asked. Her voice wobbled with unshed tears.
>
> Phainon did the only thing possible in such a situation: He panicked.
>
> “Uh,” he said, because clearly his eloquence had abandoned him during one of the cycles, “yes?”

// OR, circumstance leads to the heirs thinking Phainon only lived through thirty-three cycles. Rather than correcting them on this, Phainon doubles down and decides this is the new narrative he'll go along with so as to avoid worrying them too much.

Notes

thank you to my friend that has listened to me talk about this au for the past month. i thought this would be funny to write. i don't know how many chapters there'll be but we're just gonna have fun with it. it's a silly au but since this is phainon there's still going to be a layer of angst involved, haha.

EDIT: no longer just a silly au, this fic's transformed into a character study of phainon and while there's a bunch of comedy and dry humour, we've also reached a point where there's a lot of serious moments and angst too. hope this doesn't throw anyone off!! but i just thought to warn y'all, bc once upon a time, i said this would just be silly.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Translation into Русский available: [Перевод] a slight understatement (незначительное преуменьшение) by McLavaschzzzz

Chapter 1

Marmoreal Palace was only standing due to a mixture of spite and golden threads.

The rest of Okhema's city centre was much the same. Gold threads bound around broken pillars and sealed the cracks of building rafters. Various floors shimmered with gold, gaps in the ground woven together into something liquid that had since dried into concrete.

Irontomb had been defeated but not without cost.

The city was as much of a ruin as the actual ruins torn asunder by the black tide. It would need to be rebuilt and *fast.* Aglaea's golden threads could keep things in place long enough for further evacuation from the more structurally unstable regions of Okhema but she couldn't rebuild a city with her powers alone.

…Phainon probably could have done it.

With millions of Mnestia's coreflames squirreled away in his chest, he probably could've done it all on his own. Was it rude of him to have not taken the initiative and strung up his own set of threads? It was difficult to know. Honestly, it was still a little difficult to *think.*

Tracking all of the damage for an entire city, identifying the structural damage and then subsequently fixing the damages in whichever way was most reliable would be far too difficult on the best of days. An hour ago, Phainon had torn himself - with much agony - free from the scepter's core. It was not exactly the best of days.

For now, he settled on what he could manage: He reinforced any trembling threads at risk of snapping with his own. When Aglaea shot a sharp look in his direction, he flashed her a tired smile and a thumbs up, as if he weren't currently dead on his feet.

He was still focusing on reinforcing her threads when the conversation began. It was a debrief of the past 24 hours as much as it was to be a meeting to discuss immediate plans for Okhema's future.

Hopefully, whatever workload got placed on *his* shoulders wouldn't be so time sensitive that he couldn't take a short nap first. Titans, there was nothing Phainon wanted more than to lie down and *sleep*. It was a statistical wonder that he was still *conscious.*

Conscious, maybe. Tracking the conversation? Not at all.

He'd need to ask for a summary from the trailblazer later. Currently she stood beside Cyrene and was explaining her part as the deliverer of this latest cycle. Phainon caught some words - something about the cycles, something about Lygus' administrative access being revoked. He even heard his own name mentioned a couple of times.

Like now. Stelle was probably explaining something about Irontomb or whatever, so of course his name was coming up a bunch of times. He took hold of fraying gold wrapped around a crumbling pillar and reinforced it with a net of finely spun strings.

…Wait. She was still saying his name. It was louder than before, his name spoken with more persistence.

Phainon's gaze flicked back to the group. A dozen pairs of eyes were all focused on him.

"Huh?"

"Are you still there with us, partner?" Stelle asked. Phainon tilted his head and blinked at her. She added, "You weren't responding when we called your name."

The smile he offered was deeply tired and overly forced. He couldn't add enough emotion into his voice for it to be anything but dull and exhausted. "Sorry. What did I miss?"

“Everyone wants to know a bit more about the cycles you lived through,” Stelle said, with a wan smile.

Phainon felt something jolt in his chest. Could’ve been the coreflames. Could’ve been grief. He said, “Uh… Right now?”

“Not too much. Just—you know…”

“We’d like to know how many times you went through them,” Aglaea interrupted. “The trailblazer has mentioned that there have been many but she has not mentioned any specific number.”

Threads slipped through his hands. He wasn’t sure whether it was his thoughts stuttering or Mnestia’s physical, tangible strings. The building wasn’t immediately crumbling apart so it was probably just his thoughts.

“Oh,” he said. There wasn’t really any reason not to tell them. Sure, they’d probably be angry that it took him millions of cycles to bring any real change to Amphoreus, but surely they wouldn’t be *too* angry if he reiterated that the idea had been to draw out the cycles for as long as possible to buy them all time for Stelle’s arrival to Amphoreus. “Uh, well. Thirty three—”

He felt the snap just in time for the pillar to come crashing into the pool. The sound of falling stone drowned out the rest of his words: *“—million, five hundred and fifty thousand, three hundred and thirty-six.”*

Phainon whipped around as the rest of the pillar fell. Oh, so he *had* let go of some of his strings after all. Aglaea’s had snapped under the sudden weight.

Stupid. He should’ve been able to do better. Shame flooded his chest, burning as hot as any coreflame. Immediately his gaze was flickering for signs of any other trembling threads.

There were only a few. It was easy enough to encase them in a protective barrier.

When he returned his attention to the meeting, they were still staring at him. Tribbie’s eyes were rapidly filling with worried tears. Hyacine held little Ica

close in her arms, hugging the pegasus for comfort.

“You had to go through that *thirty-three* times?” Tribbie asked. Her voice wobbled with unshed tears.

Ash caught in his throat. He’d definitely said *million* but the falling pillar must’ve drowned that part out.

Were thirty-three cycles really worth crying about? The number was shockingly low. Even a thousand cycles passed in a blink of an eye, compared to *millions*. Tribbie really shouldn’t be wasting tears over a number so small.

…It wasn’t just the little priestess who looked upset, though. It was all of his fellow heirs.

It was Aglaea, whose lips pressed together in a thin line, brows faintly furrowed. It was Mydei who was now glaring at the ground like it had wronged him. Castorice too, looked upset, like she wanted to hug him and never let go.

All for such a miniscule number.

And then it registered: If they reacted this way over the idea of thirty-three cycles, they were going to lose their shit when they learned the true number was far, far higher.

Phainon did the only thing possible in such a situation.

He panicked.

The first new feeling, past relief, exhaustion and rage, across millions of cycles hit him and it was pure, bone-chilling panic.

“Uh,” he said, because clearly his eloquence had abandoned him during one of the cycles, “yes?”

Behind Aglaea’s shoulder, the trailblazer stared at him. Not with shock—though her surprise was evident—but with a frown that clearly asked where

he found the *audacity* to spin such a lie.

Phainon was a big fan of digging his own grave so he ignored her frown and said, “I lived through thirty three—” - *million*- “—cycles.”

The meeting continued, except now, Stelle was staring at him as if she were minutes away from having an aneurysm. Considering the fact that *he* was the cause of this sudden breakdown, Phainon did his best to avoid looking her way. Every time she managed to catch his eye, she began mouthing things at him that his brain was too tired to decipher.

All he’d managed to decipher thus far was *‘what the fuck’*, which he could whole-heartedly understand the sentiment behind. Phainon too, wasn’t entirely sure what the fuck he’d just done. Nor could he answer *why the fuck.* Objectively, he already knew this was a disaster waiting to happen. And yet he did nothing to clear the misunderstanding.

Further conversation was had. Bits and pieces of information from the recent cycles were explained - things that the other heirs remembered. At one point, the Flame Reaver was brought up and Phainon waved the topic away by saying he’d killed him and that the reaver would no longer be a concern.

At that, Stelle let out a choked noise which had not gone ignored.

“Is something wrong, trailblazer?” Aglaea asked.

Stelle, without looking away from him, answered, “Nope. Nothing.”

Her voice was so tight that Phainon doubted anyone truly believed her. The only reason they weren’t asking was because the day had been long enough and their exhaustion had reached bone. Even Aglaea, who normally wouldn’t have given up on the question without some sort of minor interrogation, seemed happy to leave the questioning for later. The goldweaver would most likely pick the questioning back up when they’d

gotten some rest and the buildings around them were no longer in the process of physically falling apart.

Once their meeting ended, Stelle burst forward. Her hand wrapped around his wrist like a bruise, forceful and heavy as she stared up at him with what was, most probably, the fakest smile he'd ever seen.

"Hey Partner?" She said, in a tone that made him want to hide his face in his hands. "It's been a while. Let's catch up."

It was clear he was in some sort of trouble. Stelle dragged him away from the hero's baths, down the —surprisingly still functional— elevator and into one of the now abandoned public changing rooms. Through it all, her grip remained harsh, each footstep quick as she dragged him along.

Phainon did his best to keep up even if his body was beginning to feel like lead.

She did not speak again until she'd confirmed they were alone, at which point she let go of his wrist and pinched the bridge of her nose. It was an altogether odd look on her; She looked less like she was actually exasperated and more like she was mimicking Dan Heng in an attempt to let *him* know that he was an idiot.

"First off," she said, dropping her hand back to her side. "I'm *really* glad you're not dead. It was really cool watching you burst out of Irontomb like a baby chicken. Good shit. Ten out of ten."

Ah, yes, Phainon thought, he'd missed the odd way in which she spoke. Even if said oddness included being likened to a bird.

His lips quirked upwards. There was a cold satisfaction in his chest that came with helping destroy a Lord Ravager that he didn't think was going to go away anytime soon.

"It was very cathartic," Phainon said.

“I can imagine,” Stelle said, with a small smile. Then it faded back into the indignant glare from before. “But enough about all of that. *You, mister,* what the fuck was *that?”*

He didn’t have the energy to grimace. Instead, he sighed and said, “Does it matter if they think the number is lower than it truly is?”

For a moment, she simply stared at him.

Then Stelle nodded in such a jerked manner that it was a surprise she did not give herself whiplash.

“You know,” Stelle said, her words altogether dumbfounded by what Phainon could only guess was *his* audacity. “I’ve heard people say you get wiser the older you get. Considering *you’re* probably older than the literal universe multiple times over, I’d have thought you wouldn’t be so stupid.”

Alright, well, that wasn’t necessarily fair.

“Well—”

“But maybe being wise isn’t like that at all, maybe it’s just this one repeating wave and at some point you regress and fall back into being a fool. What was that word again? Ah right, yeah, it’s a bell curve of stupidity. Maybe this is a bell curve and you, Phainon, are currently in the negatives because what the actual fuck, why would you even think the number doesn’t matter at all?”

It was kind of impressive actually, how she managed to get all the words out in seemingly very few breaths. She’d only taken two breaths the entire time. Maybe she’d been given tips by Anaxa, who was typically just as effective at drawing out each breath when lecturing others.

When he didn’t say anything, Stelle put a hand on his shoulder and said, “Phainon.”

“Stelle,” Phainon said.

“I want to study your stupidity like a *bug.”*

Yeah, Phainon wasn't really sure what that meant. All he knew was that he was very tired and Stelle was displeased about his understatement. Typically when *Stelle* thought something was a stupid idea, it meant that it was *very* stupid indeed.

"I didn't set out with the intent to lie," Phainon said, slowly. "It just happened. I panicked."

"I totally get that," she said, and began nodding. "Totally. But you're definitely going to have to un-panic yourself and tell them the truth. You're not allowed to be the dog in the room that's on fire, okay? It's not fine and neither of us have enough fire extinguishers for this kind of thing."

They fell into a silence where they both simply… nodded at each other. As if to emphasise that yes, they were totally hearing one another but they didn't quite know what came next.

Probably fair - he and Stelle had never really been people that others pointed to and thought: *'Hey, they've totally got their shit together'.*

The silence began to bleed.

"...Is that… one of your meme references that I don't understand?" Phainon asked.

Stelle's hand tightened around his shoulder. Somewhat pained she said, "Yes it's one of my memes that you don't understand. I'll show you it later. Right now, you need to *fix this."*

Phainon sighed. Then, gently, he lifted Stelle's hand from his shoulder and took a small step back.

"I'll—Fine." The words were dragged from his throat, utterly reluctant. "I'll tell them the truth. Just… Let's deal with rebuilding things first, alright? Okhema comes before all of this. But I *will* tell them eventually."

Stelle narrowed her eyes at him. "You won't try to wriggle out of this if I leave you to tell them yourself?"

“I won’t,” Phainon said. He wasn’t sure whether he was being truthful or whether it was a lie.

She watched him quietly, as if trying to determine the same thing. Either he was too hard to read or she saw *something* resembling sincerity in his eyes because eventually, Stelle dropped her shoulders and let out a long sigh. “Fine. But tell them soon, okay? Keeping secrets *sucks.”*

Four days later, at the behest of the genius Herta, the Astral Express bid them a temporary goodbye, taking with them the remains of the scepter Irontomb in a set of cargo containers. Phainon joined the other heirs in waving goodbye to the express crew and did his best to avoid the warning look Stelle sent his way.

“Whoa,” Tribbie said, by his side, “little grey is really glaring at you. Did you guys fight?”

Phainon, who was in the middle of wriggling his way out of telling the truth just as Stelle had feared he would, shook his head. He said, “We didn’t. That’s not a glare—I think she’s just a little tired.”

Tribbie hummed. She said, “We all are, I think.”

Ha, yeah, that was an understatement. It’d been days and Phainon still found it difficult to put one foot in front of the other without being flooded with exhaustion. If he were being honest, he probably should’ve gone to Hyacine about it by now but… Well, what was one more secret?

Everything would be fine.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> i didn't expect such a response from people on my silly little au idea. but boi am i pleased that people enjoy this as much as i do. the next chapter will not be nearly as quick, so please don't expect super speedy updates. i am but a single mint, and i like playing with my doc of multiple aus rather than focusing on just one at a time.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once the Astral Express departed Amphoreus and the train had warped from visible sight, Phainon took to the streets with an enthusiasm that felt antithetical to the exhaustion humming through his bones. The roaming was not without purpose - his official task was to patrol the currently occupied areas of Okhema and reinforce any weak spots in Aglaea’s matrix of golden string.

Unofficially, Phainon had taken it upon himself to do much more than that. It wasn’t enough to wade through rubble and debris that he - as an unwilling part of Irontomb - had created and look for trembling threads. He had to help fix the destruction he’d wrought. He needed to do *more*.

Fixing Okhema wasn’t just part of his duty as the Chrysos Heir of Worldbearing.

It was penance.

And either way, it wasn’t like physical labour was particularly hard. Even with his body as unwilling as it was, Phainon was capable of aiding the rebuilding effort. His limbs might have moved like he were sludging through mud but that wasn’t really anything new.

His current patrol led him to Kephale Plaza. Fallen boulders had crushed the flower beds. The mural of Kephale was in so many fragments that even the Tribios Triplets did not have enough power to restore it. Water flooded

the eastern quarter of the plaza - the fountain had been smashed and now leaked like a bleeding wound.

Phainon's gaze flicked for signs of gold and found that there weren't many threads left behind. Most of the surrounding infrastructure had been demolished in the fight and thus there was minimal risk of further destruction.

Currently, the plaza was filled with citizens and chimeras alike, all working in unison to remove the worst of the debris. Chimera teams chipped away at larger pieces of fallen stone and human labourers relocated the smaller stone pieces into the awaiting carriages waiting outside the fallen gates.

They were making progress. Slow progress, but progress nonetheless.

Phainon joined them without a word. He took a large chunk of stone with ease from an older man in a fraying chiton and dropped it in a half filled carriage. When a chimera got caught at the top of a fallen pillar, trembling at the suddenly perceived height, he climbed up and brought the creature safely to the ground.

The people needed to get to the debris in the flooded area of the plaza? Phainon utilised the many coreflames of Phagousa and Georios and remoulded the earth beneath them so the flooded water had somewhere to flow.

It wasn't exactly smart to go using the millions of coreflames in his chest when they'd slowly been killing him for just as many years, but the burn in his chest wasn't hot enough to liquefy his organs. Arguably, he'd be alright with short time uses. Probably.

He continued.

His foot caught on a broken piece of mural as he returned from lugging a large crumbling of broken pillar out of the plaza's gates. Dropping into a crouch, Phainon reached for sharpened edges. The chunk wasn't overly big and yet, it was easy to place it in his mind's eye. The tip of a finger and the gold of flowing ichor.

Phainon was looking at a piece of what had once been mural Kephale's hand. Kephale, the worldbearer, Their hand stained in blood. It reminded him of a particular aeon. It reminded him of himself.

Around him, ripples of red glitched in and out of the world. The plaza emptied around him. Fire licked at his skin and the debris was stained a mixture of red and gold.

His spine stiffened. Phainon's gaze narrowed on a limp hand caught beneath stone. The fire around him had begun to fill the cracks of his skin. Phainon's jaw clenched—

"Lord Phainon—?"

—And the limp hand wasn't a hand at all. It was just a small chimera. Its fur was deep gold with splotches of red on its tail.

The voice belonged to the older man with the fraying chiton. He'd stopped beside Phainon, not quite concerned but getting there. When Phainon's gaze flicked up to meet him, he offered a small smile.

"Is everything alright, Lord Phainon?"

Phainon didn't want to look at the chimera lest it turn back into blood and ichor, so instead he offered a tired smile of his own and stood. He said, "Everything is fine."

Because it was.

It *had to be.*

"I'll be moving on now to patrol the other areas," he said. "If anything becomes too heavy for you all, leave it aside for me and I'll come back for it later. Please don't strain yourselves."

He curled his fingers around the broken piece of mural only to find that it was no longer there. Instead there was only dust and the lingering tingle of destruction against his fingers.

…Strange. He hadn’t meant to render it dust.

And yet, he was glad that it was gone. This was better, actually. Now he’d never need to look at that stupid, *fucking* mural ever again. Endless millenia and finally— *finally*— Okhema would see its plaza change. The urge to let the rest of the mural crumble between his finger tips was almost too much to resist.

He tilted his hand so the dust drifted from his hand. Then, he brushed lingering remains away on his trouser leg. All through it all, he kept circling around a singular thought: *He’d have to come back and find the other pieces later.*

“They won’t be too upset over one mural, surely,” Phainon murmured to himself, as he continued past the plaza and deeper into the city.

“There you are!” Cyrene shouted later that day, when he’d settled into helping at a residential district east of the Marmoreal Palace. Her footsteps were skittering things - clearly she’d broken into a run the second she’d caught sight of him.

The wonderful thing about finally reaching Era Nova was that Cyrene was *back.*

The terrifying thing about it was that —like the Trailblazer— she knew everything he had done.

Phainon hadn’t exactly set out to avoid her but he’d not really gone out of his way to seek her out either. Which was pretty cruel of him, probably. He’d managed to justify it in his head by saying he’d not really been seeking *anyone* out recently and that he’d get around to it eventually.

But really, that wasn’t true at all. Things were just awkward. It got pretty hard to look your best friend in the eye when you’d spent more time over the eons killing her than speaking to her. He knew how best to bury her

broken body, to set her into the ground so she could settle into peaceful slumber but he didn't really know how to talk to her. Not that he'd tried yet. He would - eventually. But well… Okhema needed rebuilding, so of course he was busy.

Pulling scraps of broken wood from a building covered in shimmering gold, Phainon glanced at Cyrene over his shoulder. She'd come to a stop beside him, hands planted on her knees and body pitched forward as if doing so would help her inhale more air.

It wouldn't but saying as such wouldn't help. She'd probably just roll her eyes.

Phainon snapped the wood into smaller pieces - it was already too corroded to be of any use past firewood - and tossed it into a pile of firewood. Then, he waited for her to catch her breath.

When her breathing had evened out, Cyrene stood as tall as she could - which wasn't very tall at all - and gave him a once over. Whatever she saw mustn't have met her self imposed standards because she grimaced and said, "Wow. You look awful."

"Thanks," Phainon said dryly.

Not that he was surprised. He'd been helping out with the cleanup of debris, what was she expecting from him? He'd been covered in a layer of soot since the entry hour passed its second quint. Grime coated his skin like a film and dust had dyed his hair grey. It wasn't a big deal - everyone else helping clean up was in a similar state.

Cyrene placed a hand on her hip and shook her head. She said, "I don't mean it in a messy sense. You're really pale. Are you feeling okay?"

He opened his mouth but she continued before he could speak.

"Bad question, I already know you're going to say you're fine." Her voice lowered into a hum as she considered how to rephrase it. Then: "When did you last take a break?"

Phainon squinted at her. That really depended on how you decided to define *‘break’*. Did sleep count? Even if it did… well. The answer still didn’t shine very favourably on him.

“I don’t exactly have a clock on me,” Phainon said, slowly. “So I couldn’t say.”

Tilting her head, Cyrene hummed. She said, “Is that supposed to make me worry less or more?”

“Ideally,” Phainon sighed, “you wouldn’t be worrying at all.”

At that, Cyrene laughed. Like he’d told some kind of joke. She was a terrible person. He’d never missed someone as much as he’d missed *her*. Even stood in front of him she felt like a ghost.

“After all those cycles,” she said, shaking her head fondly, “and you’re still the same Phainon I know and love. Which means, I know for *certain* you’ve not stopped at all today.”

The same Phainon, huh? What a joke.

Still, he couldn’t deny the fact that she’d clocked his lack of rest immediately. Since he couldn’t deny it, he fell silent and turned back to the golden ruins. Proceeded to retrieve wood and strip it to pieces.

Maybe if he didn’t acknowledge the need for a break, she’d leave him *alone.*

Yeah, that obviously wasn’t going to work.

This was Cyrene he was talking about. She was as stubborn as they came. But—was she? He couldn’t remember any instances of that stubbornness and yet that thought was so clear in his mind. When he thought of her, all he could conjure was blood and half-drawn breaths.

He drowned out her voice and cracked wood into splinters. Whenever they pierced his skin, Phainon let flame engulf them, small pieces of ash scattering across the ground in his wake.

“Hey!” A hand grabbed hold of his sleeve and yanked. When he turned, surprised, Cyrene’s eyes were wide. Her typical smile was gone, replaced with concern. Around them, the sun seemed dimmer than it had been before yet the sky was clear and there were no clouds in sight. “Don’t make me blackmail you into listening to me. I will, you know.”

“Blackmail?”

Cyrene nodded emphatically. “Maybe I’ll tell everyone that you’ve actually lived through fifty-four cycles instead of thirty-three. Or—oh, maybe I’ll tell them it was a hundred!”

“Why wouldn’t you just threaten to tell them about the full thirty-three million?” Phainon asked.

Clasping her hands behind her back, Cyrene took her time to think. Then, rather reluctantly, she admitted, “I don’t really want to tell them that our plan took that many cycles either.”

Somewhat vindicated, Phainon’s eyes widened. He would have thought that she’d have openly taken Stelle’s side in this, demanding that the truth be offered up without hesitation.

“Don’t get me wrong,” Cyrene continued, as if reading his thoughts. “The truth will come out eventually, it always does. But… I don’t know. The idea of admitting that I spent so long alone, stuck outside of the cycles… It sucks. I get why you said what you did.”

Phainon straightened. He said, “You… don’t think keeping it secret is a bad idea?”

Cyrene laughed. It was a kind of laugh that scraped at her ribs, deep and amused. She said, “It’s one hundred percent a terrible idea, Phai. I understand why you’re keeping quiet but I don’t agree with it. I just—I dunno. I’ll stay quiet until *you* tell them. If that’s what you want.”

The likelihood that he would ever tell the truth about the cycles got infinitesimally smaller the more time passed. It was probably best not to

admit that though. Cyrene was only minorly on his side in all of this - while she hadn't openly called him an idiot for it, like Stelle had, she was probably thinking it.

"I'd appreciate that," he said, slowly.

"Co-conspirators, then?" Cyrene asked. Her eyelids crinkled as she smiled. Phainon had forgotten she had dimples but there they were, tiny crescents etched into her cheeks.

"...Alright," Phainon said.

She grabbed hold of his hand as if to shake on the deal. Her fingers were so cold that Phainon flinched away from the touch. It was like a flame touching liquid nitrogen. The sensation was utterly foreign and unpleasant.

Cyrene must've felt it too, only in reverse, yet she ignored it and locked their fingers together. She said, "Perfect. Our first mission as co-conspirators is to take a break. Alright?"

…Oh.

He'd been duped.

"I'm fine," Phainon said.

"Nuh-uh," Cyrene said. She wasn't as strong as he was but she had the advantage of extra energy. When she yanked on his arm, Phainon's balance tipped out from beneath him and he was forced to stumble after her, lest he trip over his own feet. "This classes as official conspirator business. You've *got* to go along with it."

"There's too much that needs to be done," he tried, weakly.

"Excuse rejected," Cyrene said, somewhat gleefully. "I'm thinking… you need to get rid of all that grime. And either way, a bath will be relaxing. You look *way* too tense."

Absolutely not.

“I’ve got to patrol, Aglaea said—”

“*Aglaea* said that we shouldn’t overwork ourselves.” Cyrene interrupted. “That we need to take breaks so that we don’t burn out while rebuilding. Relaxation is necessary - your excuse is rejected once again.”

“You can’t just keep rejecting my excuses.”

“So you admit they’re excuses?” Cyrene grinned and playfully stuck out her tongue. Phainon was too tired to argue back against her—all he could manage was another deep sigh.

And without giving him an inch lest he take a mile, she pulled on his arm again and began marching him to the nearest bath house.

Chapter End Notes

next chapter: a break is had and a sky clinician (and her pegasus familiar) says hello.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> for my birthday, my best friend made me a phainon figurine and you guys, since i opened that present yesterday i've been looking at him like a woeful little maiden. damn. what a guy. i love him so much.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The baths outside of Marmoreal Palace were much smaller. Where the baths inside the palace had always been used socially - cycling through events and welcoming large parties from all over Amphoreus - those outside the palace existed solely for utility.

The bath house they headed to was a tiny thing. A small and empty reception area that lead to two changing rooms. On the other side of the changing rooms, there were three baths - two segregated by gender, the third unisex.

Obviously, they went with the third. It was empty considering the hour - most people were still focusing on the rebuilding effort and as such wouldn’t show themselves until the Parting hour. The water was tinged green where light reflected off viridian tiles.

Towel wrapped around his waist, Phainon met Cyrene by the water’s edge.

“If the water gets too hot—”

“It won’t,” Cyrene interrupted. Her hair had been pulled into a messy bun - only a few strands of pink fell free. Phainon’s fingers twitched with the urge to make it neater, like he used to when they’d been children in Aedes Elysiae. “If you warm it up, then I’ll cool it down.”

Could she truly do that? There was very little one could do to counteract four hundred million coreflames. The blaze was too much to fight. His was the kind of fire that you had to step back and let burn itself out.

“You’re doubting me, huh?” She asked, seeing through him to the skepticism lurking behind his eyes. “Well, let me prove it to you.”

She stepped into the pool.

The water around her ankles rippled and began to crystallise into sludging ice. The deeper she settled into the bath, the more it froze around her.

Cyrene turned back to him with a grin and said, “I don’t know if I’d call this a gift from the Remembrance, but if it’ll help us balance each other, I’ll take it. Whatever I freeze, you can melt. And if you raise the temperature too high, I’ll do what I can to bring it down.”

His fingers still felt strange from when she’d grabbed hold of his hand previously - now, at least, he knew what had caused it.

Alright then, maybe he wouldn’t worry *too much* about the water’s temperature. As long as he kept a tight control over the coreflames, Cyrene could clearly counteract the heat that managed to snake its way free. He dipped his toes into the water and flinched away from the ice.

From where she’d been watching him, Cyrene began to laugh. “It’s not *that* cold.”

He’d like to see *her* try to adjust to being frozen after millenia of burning herself on a pyre. Maybe then she’d understand how utterly jarring it was.

“You’re biased,” Phainon shot back.

Still, he didn’t have any choice but to dip his foot back into the icy bath. It was just as cold as before - perhaps even colder. If he didn’t get in now, Cyrene would probably make it even colder until the bath became a pure block of ice.

…Was he really going to let the *cold* defeat him? Of all things? Absolutely not.

He took another step into the water and resisted the shudder that ran down his spine. Another step and it became physically difficult to keep himself

from glaring at Cyrene and that little smirk on her face. To avoid it, he submerged himself into the water completely, hoping the plunge would help him acclimatise more quickly.

It didn’t. It was still really fucking cold.

Water and ice crystals dripped from his hair. His body trembled from the glacial sting. Unpleasant, yes, but also a somewhat welcomed change to the ever present burn of his body. The shock of it was enough to keep his eyes open as he sunk into the water. If the water had been any warmer, he’d have heard the siren call of sleep.

He settled opposite Cyrene on a bench carved into the bath, running his hand across the grooves in the tile. His back was like a rod, unwilling to slouch against the curve of the wall.

“Any better yet?” She asked.

He shook his head. Then, he asked, “Why exactly is Remembrance linked to ice so much?”

“Why is Destruction linked to fire—” Cyrene wrinkled her nose. “Wait, no that’s a stupid question. Fire’s pretty obvious. I’m not sure why it’s icy. Maybe it helps preserve memories better - meat keeps better in ice, why wouldn’t memory be the same?”

Yeah, alright.

“Literally freezing the memories in time, huh?” Phainon said.

“Exactly.”

“Doesn’t exactly sound inviting though, does it?” He continued. “Whether the memory fades or not, surely it’s better to feel its warmth than to look at it so… clinically.”

Cyrene let out a small laugh. She said, “Guess that’s the difference between the Paths, huh?”

Phainon hummed. They'd not really had much time to ask the express crew about the various Paths - there hadn't really been time for history lessons on the universe outside of Amphoreus that awaited them over the past few days. He'd had a small introductory explanation on the Aeons from Dan Heng during the final cycle but after everything that came next, the knowledge was difficult to remember with any clarity.

All he could remember about the Paths was that of three Aeons who had overlooked Amphoreus.

Fuli, the Remembrance, who had dragged a world into existence from simulation using the many memories that had been collected and thus was regarded with positivity. Nous, the Erudition, to whom Phainon tried to remain indifferent.

And then there was *Nanook*.

Something snarled deep in his chest at the name. Phainon had proven that an Aeon could bleed. And if They could bleed, then They could be killed too. And he'd find a way. Once Okhema was pieced back together, when he'd paid the price of all his crimes, he'd figure a way to kill a god. He'd take Dawnbreaker and—

Cyrene let out a yelp.

Phainon jerked out of his thoughts and had to look through thick steam to find her.

"H—hot," she stuttered.

Eyes wide, he couldn't help but curse. "Sorry. I didn't mean to—I just—"

"It's okay," she said, though her smile was a little more concerned than before. Lacking self-preservation, she waded through the water until she was by his side, laying a hand on his arm. Her fingers, ice and bone, looked like they were *melting.* "Just breathe. And try to cool down."

“Cyrene—” The panic from days before was rearing its head again. It caught in his throat, dry as charcoal. “Your hand.”

She shushed him. “Remembrance can reform anything good as new, right? It’s fine. We’re fine.”

Ha, were they?

“I’m sorry,” he murmured and tried his best to contain the heat inside of him.

“These things happen,” Cyrene said. “Before they left, I accidentally froze Stelle in ice when *we* were bathing together. You’re not the only one.”

Freezing people was one thing. Melting them was another. He knew that his was the worst of the two crimes.

Still, Cyrene was doing her best to give him a distraction. Phainon grasped it like a drowned man to land.

“How did she take to being an ice cube?” He croaked.

“Unsurprisingly well,” Cyrene hummed. “Apparently it wasn’t her first time. I hadn’t even thawed her out when she told me that I should open a dessert store selling exclusively shaved ice.”

Yeah, that sounded like something Stelle would suggest.

He wondered where the Express was now. How long would they be in open space for before they reached the site of their delivery. They hadn’t specified a time frame for which they’d arrive at their destination, or a date of return. Could’ve been days. Could’ve been weeks.

Hopefully, they’d find no trouble on their journey. Even if they did, they’d probably be able to fight their way out of it. They’d probably find most foes easy to fight. So long as they didn’t come face to face with—

“Hey. Don’t start hiding in your head again,” Cyrene said. “We’re here to relax, right? So… Hm. Tell me about this. There must be a story behind it,

right?”

She pressed her finger—reformed and no longer melted—to the top of his arm, where a ring of scar tissue stitched the flesh to his shoulder. They ran around the entirety of his arm, a deep canyon of golden scarring. Though it no longer leaked the way it had days ago when he’d first noticed the amputated limb was no longer unattached, it was still far from being fully healed.

Looking at it, the wound didn’t look all that bad. There were no accompanied bruises or scabs. His arm looked more like a porcelain doll’s arm that needed its cracks filled.

How he’d reached this point following amputation was difficult to say, but the arm had been rethreading itself ever since he’d been shoved inside of Irontomb. Objectively, regrowing an arm was better than not having one at all, so Phainon hadn’t questioned it too much. Sometimes, bodies were weird.

“I got it while fighting the black tide,” he said.

“After passing things on to Stelle and I?” Cyrene asked. When he nodded, she let out a long hum, contemplating. “Wow, it must’ve been a tough fight even with all those coreflames. You’re lucky you didn’t lose an arm.”

An ironic humour caught in his chest. His smile was a small, wry thing. “I did.”

The admission came with a still silence that froze him at the core. Cyrene’s eyes widened, mouth dropping open in surprise. When she spoke, her voice was a squeak. “You *did?!*”

Phainon shrugged. It was hardly worth being surprised about - it wasn’t even the first time he’d found himself down an arm. Dismemberment got kind of old after a while. The most surprising thing about all of this, really, was that he’d not had to die to get it back. In the absence of another cycle’s Phainon, he’d simply… reattached it himself.

“You’re kidding me,” Cyrene breathed. She poked at the scar, alarmed. “You really lost your arm? It actually came off. Like… properly dismembered?”

“*Why* would I lie about that?”

Cyrene stared at him. Then, she punched his arm - the one that had not been dismembered previously - and let out an incredulous laugh. She said, “Phai, why didn’t you *tell me?* This is the kind of thing you tell people!”

Phainon really didn’t know what the issue was. He blinked at her, confused and too tired to begin unpacking what the true problem was. She hadn’t asked before now and Phainon’s arm was reattached - did it really matter all that much?

Clearly the answer was yes.

And yet even seeing her worry, he couldn’t bring himself to care that he’d lost it.

“Am I supposed to tell you about every limb I’ve ever lost?” Phainon asked.

The fact that Cyrene had to take the time to think about this showed just how absurd their lives had become.

Eventually, she said, “Only the ones that have stuck. Or, er—only from your final cycle onwards.”

Better that he only need to tell her about three than an entire slew of them, he supposed.

“Okay,” Phainon said. And when she opened her mouth to continue, he cut her off and said, “So I should probably mention that my wings were cut off too?”

Cyrene opened her mouth, said nothing, and then closed her mouth again. The look she sent him was purely bewildered. “You had wings?”

He nodded. “Still do, I think.”

If he really focused on the sensation of wings, he could feel a burning itch, thousands of pinpricks against bone. It was possible they were growing back. Wouldn’t surprise him, really. There were too many coreflames to be fully contained in his body, so he’d needed the extra space. His wings were as much an extension of himself as they were the coreflames.

Maybe that was why he was so tired. Regrowing two limbs seemed like the kind of thing that could explain away the exhaustion plaguing him.

“Okay.” Cyrene said, slowly. “Um. What does Hyacine think about all of this?”

He stared at her blankly. Tilted his head as if to ask *‘why would Hyacine have an opinion on this?’*

“You didn’t tell her about any of this during your check-up?”

“...What check-up?”

From the glower sent his way, this was clearly the wrong thing to ask. Cyrene looked appalled at his question.

“After the fight with Irontomb, Aglaea sent us all to have check-ups,” she explained. “You didn’t go?”

It was probably for the best that he just shook his head instead of coming up with any kind of excuse. Admitting that he’d hardly been listening seemed like something that’d only get him told off more. She might not be openly angry at him yet, but Phainon really didn’t want to push his luck.

“You really are a disaster, aren’t you?” Cyrene sighed. “You’re the one who needed that check-up the most! Don’t you realise that?”

“I feel fine,” he said, because objectively, compared to the agony from the cycles, he was. Tired, sure, but his pain was hardly there anymore. Even the *echo* of pain had long since passed. The absence of it was actually kind of overwhelming. “Truly.”

“Yeah, well, I know not to believe you on things like this without proof,” she said. “After this bath, we’re going straight to the Twilight Courtyard.”

Luckily for them, when Cyrene said they were going to the Twilight Courtyard, she was not talking of the one that was situated in the Grove of Epiphany. She was speaking of the Okheman branch that was typically founded near the end of most cycles.

As the true clinic was in a state of disrepair, Hyacinthia and the many other healers of Okhema had converted a school on the outskirts of the city into a makeshift hospital. Classrooms had been converted into bays for long-term patients. The gymnasium turned into a rotating clinic seeing not only those injured during Okhema’s destruction but those with unrelated sicknesses as well.

Cyrene led him through the gymnasium doors and towards a receptionist sat behind a small desk. From the moment they’d left the bath and headed out into the street, she had not let go of his hand. Even when he’d told her he wouldn’t try to run.

“Aitee, wasn’t it?” Cyrene asked, with a soft smile.

“Ah,” the receptionist said. “Lady Cyrene, yes, you remembered!”

“We’re after Hyacine,” Cyrene continued. “Is she around?”

Apparently she was. They’d received a delivery of bandages salvaged from the ruins of another infirmary and the healer had taken it upon herself to check that they were all in good condition. They were given brief directions to the storeroom and before Phainon knew it, they were in motion once more, weaving around healers and patients alike.

They knew they were heading in the right direction when the gentle whinny of little Ica reached their ears. Small and relaxed *‘doots’* echoed down the hall, accompanied by the steady flap of miniscule wings.

(Even after 33 million cycles Phainon still didn’t know how the pegasus managed to keep itself afloat with such tiny wings. He supposed some things were just supposed to remain a mystery.)

They saw the pegasus first. A few steps afterwards, there was Hyacine.

Phainon… hadn’t actually seen her since the ill-timed debrief post-Irontomb. She’d gotten just as wrapped up in work as he had - with all the injured, he doubted she’d done much outside of seeing to the wounded and resting when her shift ended. She looked well. In her element.

When— responding to Ica’s trill— she turned to face them, her lips spread into a warm smile.

“Hyacine!” Cyrene called, dragging them forward at speed.

The healer had arms filled with bandages but that did nothing to dissuade Cyrene from enveloping her in a hug.

“Cyrie!” Hyacine responded. “And Phai, too! Hi, how are you?”

Her warmth and kindness were infectious.

“Oh, I’m fine,” Cyrene said. "We're here for this fool," —at this she gestured towards Phainon,— "he’s been a little silly. We were hoping you’d be able to give him a check-up and make sure he’s alright.”

Hyacine’s gaze immediately narrowed on him. Phainon couldn’t help but squirm beneath her gaze. She said, “Is something wrong? No one passed along your notes so I’d assumed everything was fine but has something changed?”

Phainon glanced from Cyrene, to Hyacine and then towards an open window a few metres past both women. He was probably agile enough to get out before either of them could react—

Cyrene’s hand closed over his wrist once more. Clearly, she was a mindreader.

“Well,” Cyrene said, with a smile that was certainly not as pleased as it could have been. “Like I said— it’s all a little bit silly. Phainon never had a check-up. I thought it was better late than never, right?”

Hyacine’s eyes narrowed. If her arms were not filled with bandages, it was likely that she would have planted both hands on her hips. Instead, in a voice teetering on calm, she said, “Phai didn’t come to have a check-up at all?”

Phainon’s smile was small and apologetic. She was *definitely* going to lecture him, wasn’t she?

“He hasn’t, no!” Cyrene said, because clearly *she* was angry about this as well.

“You’re right, Cyrie, that was pretty silly of him.” Hyacine pressed her lips together. “Come on, Phainon. We’ll do it now.”

…Yeah. Hyacine was definitely pissed.

Chapter End Notes

next time: hyacine is not pleased. a check-up is had.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> i need you all to know that this chapter was written purely as procrastination from doing laundry. now that i've finished i actually have to do it. rough times. sad times.
>
> ANYWAY, i had fun with this one. thanks for all the comments and support - i'm glad you're all enjoying the au as much as i am.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon was marched into the clinic as if he were on death row.

Between Hyacine, Ica and Cyrene, they'd come up with the perfect formation to keep him from fleeing. Hyacine, in the front, led the way, concern and exasperation rolling off her in such strong waves that people turned to see the cause of such a drastic mood change. Little Ica floated to Phainon's left letting out warning whickers every time Phainon's gaze so much as lingered on a window. Cyrene, in the rear, simply smiled every time he looked back as if daring him to try and bolt.

"Some things really never change do they?" Hyacine asked, once they had passed through the crowd and reached a free bay. She waved him towards one of the chairs and closed the curtain behind him.

The seat was, unfortunately, a little too small for his frame. His legs folded up in a small v-shape, leaving him a gangly mess of limb. This is what he got for being over six feet tall in a clinic repurposed from a school. He felt *ridiculous.*

"This time," he said, still smiling apologetically, "it really *was* unintentional."

He really had to fight to keep the smile on his face. If he didn't, it was just going to go either blank or wholly nervous and neither would be received

well. It’d either make everyone angrier at him or it’d make them worry. Neither were viable options.

“Unintentional?” Hyacine echoed, disbelieving.

“Yes,” Phainon said. “I didn’t realise the checkup was mandatory. And either way, I feel fine. I’d have come if I thought I needed to—”

Cyrene, who had perched on the bed by the far wall, said, “Apparently, re-attached dismembered limbs don’t count as ‘needing to see a healer’ these days. Who would’ve known?”

Phainon’s eye twitched. Irritation throbbed at his temples like a migraine. *“Cyrene.”*

“Oh, oops,” she said, blinking innocently at him. Her voice was too chipper, as if she knew how ‘helpful’ she was being. “My bad. But that *is* why we’re here. You know that. You can’t go around hiding actual dismemberments.”

Phainon hated her so, *so much.*

“I’m sorry,” Hyacine said, cutting in before their bickering truly began. “*Dismemberment*?”

He winced at how shrill her voice sounded.

Cyrene nodded. “*Plural.”*

“You’re making it out to be worse than it is,” Phainon said. “My arm is working fine now. It’s like I never lost it.”

Hyacine’s expression was pure, wide-eyed horror.

“You lost an arm.” She said, slowly. “And didn’t come to *see me?* ”

“He lost a pair of wings too,” Cyrene added, helpfully.

She was lucky that she was outside of his reach because Phainon was about two seconds away from kicking her. The distance was too far for petty

violence so he settled on glowering instead.

Cyrene stuck her tongue out at him. Phainon bit the inside of his cheek, shoved his agitation down into the depths of his stomach, and fixed an extremely strained, yet doubly apologetic, smile on his face.

See, totally fine!

“Cyrene’s making it sound worse than it is,” he repeated. “Look at me. I’m still in one piece aren’t I?”

It was for the best that he didn’t add ‘do I *look* like I need a healer?’ because if he had, it would no doubt push Hyacine further onto Cyrene’s side. Words like that weren’t reassurance, they were a challenge.

“I’ll determine how bad it is,” Hyacine said, finally, massaging her temples. “Alright. For now, I’m going to ignore talk of dismembered limbs and just conduct a general check-up. After that… We *will* be coming back to this.”

She began with the typical tests one would expect. The standard checks were taken: temperature (too hot), blood pressure (too low) and pulse rate (regular for a civilian but, sadly, too fast for a Chrysos Heir in his prime).

Hyacine took his weight and frowned. She pressed a stethoscope to his chest and made him inhale in long, deep breaths. Once she’d finished listening to his lungs, she moved on to his heart.

It was as if she was analysing every part of him.

She shone light into his eyes to see how they dilated, depressed his tongue with a long metal strip to see into the back of his throat and even pressed some sort of —of *thing* (he didn’t know what it was called)— into his ears to check that they were healthy too.

Definitely excessive for a typical check-up. At least a quint had passed and she hadn’t even seen his re-attached arm yet.

“Isn’t—” Phainon had to resist the urge to bat her little reflex hammer away when she began knocking it into his knee in an attempt to test his reflexes

and spinal health. “Isn’t this more than you’d expect for a usual check-up?”

“This isn’t a usual check-up Phai,” Hyacine answered and knocked the hammer against his knee. Phainon’s knee spasmed. That probably meant his spine was fine, right?

“...Why…not…?”

Hyacine looked up at him with raised brows, as if she’d expected him to figure it out himself.

“You’ve been carrying coreflames into each new cycle, right? I’m checking to make sure that holding them isn’t causing any long-term damage.”

…She was a little too late on that one, unfortunately. A couple million years too late. Or well—actually, he supposed not. Only the thousand years or so that he’d been trapped inside of Irontomb.

Had it been that long? Or had the time dilation been different? Difficult to know for sure. He hadn’t exactly had any way of tracking time while he was in there.

“And even if you do turn out to be fine— which you’re not— this is the best time to gather a baseline of your health in case you become sick in the future.”

Damn her. She’d found the perfect argument that meant Phainon couldn’t even argue against the continued tests.

“Alright,” He sighed. “How many more of these are there?”

Hyacine’s half-smile was a small thing. Apparently, that meant there were a *lot.* All Phainon could do was go along with her and wait for it to be over.

By the time she finally got to his dismembered arm, his shoulders were sagged and he was half-melted against his chair. Hyacine took to the healing wound with a mixture of medical intrigue and personal dismay.

“Does it feel stiff?” She asked, prodding at where scar tissue melded into muscle. “The scarring might not give you full motion of your shoulder if it pulls on the muscle too much.”

Phainon shrugged. The crevice of scarring bulged slightly at the movement but wasn’t accompanied with discomfort. He said, “Feels like it did before.”

Hyacine’s fingers twitched.

“Actually,” he said, contemplative. “It feels better than it did previously.”

Instead of the burning skin and boiling blood in his veins from before, his arm actually felt like an arm again.

“…Right,” Hyacine said.

She glanced towards Cyrene and the pair shared a look that was entirely too weighted. Something flashed across their faces, small signals embedded into the twitching of lips and wriggling of their noses. Cyrene pressed her lips together. Hyacine sighed. It was a language he did not speak and yet Phainon knew they were somehow talking about *him.*

“Let’s keep going,” Hyacine said and turned back to him.

When she finally exhausted the list of possible examinations, Hyacine dropped onto a chair opposite Phainon, and let out what was probably the deepest sigh he’d heard from her in billions of years.

Cyrene, who had been her scribe this entire time jotting patient notes down on a scroll titled with his name, lowered her quill and said, “We’re finally done?”

“We’re done,” Hyacine confirmed.

It was probably stupid to ask, but Phainon did. “So… What’s the verdict?”

Hyacine simply sat in silence and watched him. Then, she lifted a hand and pinched the bridge of her nose.

…Well, that wasn’t very reassuring.

“I don’t even know where to start,” Hyacine began. “Only you would call this ‘fine’.”

Despite being at a loss for where to begin, she did a pretty good job at pointing out all of the irregularities in his tests. Phainon was granted a crash course in all the ways his body was acting out - though the medical talk went over his head, he got the main point pretty well: It was a testament to his own stubbornness that he’d been able to go about his day without collapsing.

Seemed a bit dramatic to blame it all on his stubbornness but Hyacine looked somewhat incensed so he wasn’t willing to point that out.

“I don’t understand how no one noticed before now,” she muttered. “You don’t even fit into your clothes properly. They’re so baggy and you’re *way too pale.* Someone should’ve sent you to me days ago.”

Phainon opened his mouth, remembered how often people had been asking him how he was feeling during his rounds of the city and then promptly closed his mouth. He’d thought that people were just being polite.

“Wait,” he said. “My clothes aren’t *baggy.* They’re just spacious.”

Hyacine crossed her arms. “They’re practically hanging off of you! I’m surprised Aglaea hasn’t made you new ones already, you’re drowning in fabric.”

That was probably because he was avoiding Aglaea as much as he was avoiding the rest of them. Being able to see where her threads were really helped to avoid them. The anonymity that came with staying outside of her sight was kind of nice.

“They are not at all,” Phainon muttered.

“You’re way too skinny,” Cyrene said. “I can’t even imagine how much energy you waste holding onto all those coreflames. Aren’t you tired?”

Phainon grimaced. That was neither here nor there.

He said, “Not really. Only a little. Because of the wings.”

As soon as he said it, he knew he’d added another nail into the coffin.

Hyacine’s voice was very low when she said, “Oh yes. I forgot about the wings.”

Phainon closed his eyes in surrender. No matter how many of Orynyx’s coreflames he’d gathered, he was sadly unable to reverse time *and* memory. He didn’t have any of Cyrene’s finesse with time. The only way to go was forward.

“Why would they make you tired, Phai?”

“They’re maybe, possibly, growing back in?” He murmured.

From the curve of Hyacine’s brows, she was probably wondering how exactly she could’ve gone on to miss any changes to the bone structure of his back and shoulders. There had clearly been no wings.

“I put them away,” Phainon said. When the two women continued to look at him, waiting for some explanation on what, exactly, that meant, the words were snatched from his throat. “They’re kind of… folded away inside of a synthetic black hole so I don’t always have to walk around with them out?”

Stunned, Hyacine said, “You store your wings inside of a collapsed star?”

He stored a lot of things within a collapsed star. Mostly the black tide monsters and titankin that had gotten in the way during his many cycles. They were all space dust now.

Phainon said, “Where else am I supposed to store them?”

Their disbelief was palpable. That was fair; It was a pretty odd use for a black hole. Most of the universe tended to avoid them - they didn’t tend to harness them as their own personal storage for unwanted limbs.

“...I… Alright.” Hyacine pinched the bridge of her nose again. This time, the pinch left little indents in her skin. “Sure.” A minor pause. “Show me.”

“The black hole…?”

“No, Phainon,” she said, exasperated, “show me what’s left of your *wings.*”

“I can’t really…” He paused, grimaced and just as quickly gave up. “Well, here’s not really the best place for them. They’re a little… warm.”

“A little warm,” Hyacine repeated, unimpressed.

“They might set the building on fire,” Phainon clarified.

Another long stare. Cyrene buried her face in her hands as if his words were causing her physical pain.

“Alright,” Hyacine said. “Outside, then.”

They went outside.

Hyacine led them down a path to what had once been the school’s sports field. It’d been ravaged by falling stone during the disaster and now the ground was lumpy and uneven.

“Does this work?” Hyacine asked.

Phainon shrugged. Depending on how far his wings had regrown, there was a possibility that the grass might get a little singed. Looking at the state of the field, it really didn’t seem like the risk of burnt grass was going to be high on the list of prioritised fixes.

“It should be,” he said, and removed his coat and shirt.

Shooing them both away, he waited until they were halfway across the field before focusing on his wings once more. It wasn’t difficult - the itch was

easy enough to focus on. Flame rippled against the inside of his shoulder blades. The sensation was strong enough that Phainon was certain he'd be able to unfold them with little difficulty. It'd be an easy thing - tear open a hole in reality, retrieve his wings, stitch said hole shut again.

The threads of space and reality weren't difficult to find when you had thirty-three million of Mnestia's coreflames. Phainon didn't even need to close his eyes to control his focus anymore. He just considered where he wanted the tear to stem from, grabbed hold of the seams and ripped.

Sound scraped and distorted. The world went from stable to overtly dense. Loose dirt and pebbles were drawn into the gaping maw of a hungry, deceased star, the space crumbling under the weight of its gravity.

Phainon glanced at the nothingness as if it were, well, *nothing*. He reclaimed the space where his wings would have been. And then, as easily as he'd torn through reality, he stitched the void away for later use.

Once it was fully closed, Phainon lifted an arm and waved to the pair standing at the edge of the field. He called, "All done!"

They returned to his side, gaping. Even Cyrene, who had some understanding of what he could do and as such shouldn't have been so surprised, stared as if she'd seen something that shouldn't have been possible.

Phainon rubbed the back of his neck, cheeks flushing gold as they continued to stare at him. He said, "Do you think Aglaea will be mad about the field?"

Cyrene's lip twitched in a small smile. "We won't tell, if you don't. Right, Hyacine?"

They received a hum. Hyacine was more focused on the wings that were now sprouting from Phainon's back. While she didn't dare reach for them - the heat radiated from his back to such a degree that the air around them grew hazy - she was clearly getting as close as she could without being burned.

“They really are growing back,” she said, a mixture of awe and confusement in her tone.

“Again,” Phainon muttered, for the second time that day. “Why would I lie about that?”

His wings had grown far more than he’d thought they would have. Phainon had been expecting smaller nubs against his back, the beginning of bone and at most, a few feathers of blood and flame. Nothing bigger than his hand, at a push.

Before, the limbs had been almost double his arm length. Currently, if stretched out, they reached the curve of his elbow. The feathers, moulded from liquid flame, were covered in so much stardust and debris that he had to resist the physical urge to bathe them in an even more intense flame.

“I can’t get close enough to properly examine them,” Hyacine sighed. “Phai, is there any way you could make them cool enough for me to touch?”

He grimaced. “I’m not sure…?”

A sigh. “Right. Well. If you don’t know and *I* certainly don’t know, then there’s only one person who could possibly figure it out. I’m going to message the Professor.”

This day was already long enough trying to act normal among these two heirs. Now he had to contend with Professor *Anaxa* as well?

“Is that *really* necessary?” Phainon asked.

Hyacine did not answer. Instead, she took out her teleslate and began to type.

Chapter End Notes

> next time: a scholar makes his entrance. maybe. phainon's already long week of avoidance becomes even longer.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> i'm running late to head to a family dinner to upload this, so apologies if i've missed an immediate typos. i didn't manage to write as much in this one as i'd planned, but that's bc this scene ended up a lot bigger than expected.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

To Phainon’s immense relief, Hyacine’s message to Professor Anaxa was not an immediate summons but a query.

“I’m just asking him if he has any recommendations,” Hyacine said, upon looking up. Maybe she’d seen how his exhaustion had ballooned at the idea of interacting with *three of them* in one sitting or maybe he just looked confused. “It’s a little late for him to visit now.”

Phainon wasn’t sure. He wouldn’t put it past Anaxa. If the man deemed the concept interesting enough then time would cease to exist. It all relied on whether the concept of Phainon growing wings caught his interest or not.

He’d say the odds were an even 50:50. It depended, really, on whether Anaxa would link the wings back to his study of Nousporism.

…What was he thinking? 50:50? It *definitely* fell within the confines of Nousporism. The transformation of coreflames into biological matter, using divine fuel to create equally divine *wings?* The Nousporists were going to have a *field day* with this. It was an application of transmogrification that hadn’t been seen before in Amphoreus.

Something acidic and unpleasant curled under his ribs and squeezed at his stomach. His insides churned. Bile rose in his throat.

…That was probably a sign to stop thinking about the possibility of becoming the Nousporist’s latest case study.

Which was fine by him! He was a pro at burying things away and forcing himself not to think about them.

All Phainon needed to do was remind himself that it was only Anaxa looking at his wings, not the entire grove. He wasn't going to be paraded around as their latest research subject.

"Phainon?" Cyrene asked, her voice cutting through the static of his *totally fine* thoughts. "Is everything okay?"

"Never better," he said.

"…Are you sure? You've gone even paler than you already were."

Phainon smiled and waved the comment away with a well timed shrug. His wings dragged up with the rise of his shoulders, burning with the pull of aching muscle and flame. He said, "Just a trick of the light. Has Anaxa responded yet?"

Typically, when messaging the professor, Anaxa either responded within 5 minutes or after three days. There tended not to be an inbetween.

"Not ye—Oh, wait, now he has, yes." Hyacine's gaze flicked back down to her teleslate as the buzz caught her attention. "Apparently the method of cooling differs depending on how high the temperature of your wings is. Do you have any idea of how hot they get exactly?"

Phainon was pretty sure that Amphoreus did not make thermometers that could withstand the force of his flames at their highest temperature. Most tended to melt. They'd probably melt at the lowest burn too, but hopefully not before offering some kind of number.

"Pretty hot," Phainon said. "I've never really tested it before."

"Hm," Hyacine nodded and continued to type. Clearly, Anaxa's attention wasn't elsewhere because the responding message came almost instantly. "Anaxa would like to know if you'd mind showing him your wings tomorrow morning."

Phainon blinked. “Tomorrow morning?”

“At the second quint of the Lucid hour.”

“Uh.” He’d kind of expected Anaxa to send a time and location without any care for whether it actually suited him, so having a choice was somewhat disorientating. He said, “I… That sounds fine?”

Hyacine’s lips pulled into a gentle smile. She said, “Great. I’ll let him know.”

…If Anaxa wasn’t going to be seeing them until the following day, then that probably meant he was fine to put away his wings, right?

Phainon folded his wings back into unreality, pulled on his shirt and coat and fixed his gaze onto the two women before him.

“Is this check-up all finished for now, then?” He asked.

Hyacine’s lips pressed together into a thin line as if remembering his seemingly poor results. “We’ve gone over some of your results already but I think it’s probably for the best to go over a more thorough treatment plan when we get back to the clinic.”

Ah. Hm.

What if they didn’t do that, though?

“...Can I have a brief overview instead?” Phainon asked.

He wanted to be a good friend but the idea of coming up with a plan for his continued good health drained what little energy remained in his bones. As much as he wanted to indulge her worries, it all seemed like a waste of time.

Hyacine said, “I think it’s probably for the best to admit you into the clinic so we can keep you under observation.” (No.) “Put you on bedrest for the time being until your symptoms ease.” (Double no.) “And then slowly work into easing you into light, non-strenuous tasks.” (Also no.)

“That seems like a lot,” Phainon said. “It seems like too much, actually.”

Crossing her arms, Hyacine’s brows threaded into a frown. She said, “I’m sorry, which one of us is the doctor here?”

“I could be a doctor,” Phainon said, before his brain caught up with his mouth. “There could’ve been a cycle where I became one. You don’t know.”

Hyacine stared at him.

Beside her, Cyrene asked, “Did you ever become one?”

…33,550,336 cycles and not once did he ever entertain the notion of becoming a healer. By Kephale, that was actually kind of sad. Then again… Deliverance didn’t really go hand in hand with a stethoscope now, did it? Typically required a lot more stabbing. Doctors tended to look down on that kind of thing.

“...I did not,” Phainon said.

“Then,” Hyacine said, heaving out a long sigh, “considering how I am the only doctor here, you’ll just have to believe me when I tell you that this isn’t too much at all. It’s quite proportionate to your current needs.”

Phainon grimaced.

“How about,” he tried, “I go home now and get an early night’s rest?”

“This—” Hyacine’s cheeks went gold with the force of a frustrated flush. “Your health is important, Phainon. You can’t talk down the treatment and expect your wellbeing to do anything but plummet.”

He could definitely see her point. Which meant he’d have to give at least a little bit. He could do that.

“Alright,” Phainon nodded. “A *very* early night’s rest then. ”

It was probably a testament to Hyacine's patience that she didn't immediately try to strangle him. Her mouth opened and closed multiple times, reminiscent of a goldfish, before she finally settled on breathing out a long-suffering sigh that made her sound more tired than *he* felt.

"You aren't going to stay no matter what I say, are you?"

Phainon's lips pulled into another apologetic smile as he shook his head. It was really nice of her to offer to treat him as if he were just another one of her patients but her efforts weren't necessary. There was no reason to stay - he neither needed the bed, nor would he have deserved it if he did.

"I appreciate the sentiment," he said, because he did. Truly. It was sweet of her, actually, if you ignored the fact that the sentiment was also a little silly when aimed at *him,* a man who was objectively in much better condition now than he had been in the millions of years prior to this moment. "But there are people who need to be here more than I do. I wouldn't want to take a bed someone else might need."

…That was clearly the wrong thing to say. Hyacine's eyes were beginning to glisten with frustrated tears. From the way her bottom lip was trembling, her frustration was clearly a few minutes away from spilling over into a lecture on self care. Though she bit her tongue, it was clear she wanted to argue with him.

Honestly, Phainon hadn't seen her this angry at him since… huh, he wasn't sure he could remember a time when Hyacine had actually been frustrated at him. Back in the cycles, whenever she was faced with his then failing health, she'd only ever been sad. Devastated, even.

He preferred her frustration over her grief. Though he felt guilty to be the cause of both, anger sat better in his stomach. He could understand her frustration better than he could understand her worry and concern. Phainon wasn't willing to play along? Yeah, of course it made sense that she'd be irritated by that. That, out of *everything*, made sense.

Cyrene placed a hand on Hyacine's shoulder, leaning in to whisper something in her ear. It was quiet enough that he couldn't hear the words.

Hyacine looked to her and Cyrene offered a small smile.

“...Alright, fine,” Hyacine relented, heaving out a sigh. The words were unwilling but she managed to drag them from her throat regardless. “You’ll go straight home and rest?”

That was definitely a thing he’d said he would do but probably wouldn’t. He nodded.

“And you’ll come back for another check-up tomorrow? After you’ve visited the Professor?” She added.

Phainon was pretty sure that if he didn’t come back tomorrow, she’d track him down and forcefully drag him back to the clinic so it was probably for the best that he agreed. He said, “I can come back tomorrow.”

Hyacine stared at him, quietly, for what must’ve been at least a full two minutes. Then, finally, she jerked her head in an unwilling nod, “Fine. I guess that works too. As long as you go *straight* to bed.”

“I will, I will,” he lied.

Squinting at him as if to see how genuine he was being, it was clear that Hyacine was not fully convinced. Her skepticism would’ve been hurtful, had he actually been telling the truth. Since he wasn’t, it felt more than a little warranted. Phainon raised his hands in surrender as if the motion would do anything to placate her. It didn't, but Hyacine didn't outright call him a liar either so it hadn't *not* worked.

He *would* try to go to sleep early - he could probably ensure that didn’t end up being a lie. He just had some things he wanted to get finished first before he did.

For one, he still had a patrol to finish. *And* Phainon had promised to return to Kephale Plaza and remove any debris that had been too large to be removed by Okheman hands alone. After that he would gladly return home, change into his night clothes and rest.

Probably.

If nothing else requiring his immediate attention turned up then *definitely*.

“Okay,” Hyacine said. “I’ll see you tomorrow, Phai.”

Phainon shot her his best attempt at a wide grin. It came out plastic and quite forced, but hopefully the sentiment was still there.

“See you tomorrow, Hyacine.” Phainon said. And then, before Cyrene could open her mouth to even *contemplate* joining him as he made his escape, he added, “You too, Cyrene. See you later.”

Was it a blatant dismissal of her company? Maybe.

Did he particularly care at this point? It was debatable.

A little bit of guilt festered in his chest like an ache, but compared to the ever present guilt he harboured for having killed his friend over and over, it was like a drop in the ocean. Hardly noticeable - he was going to feel bad anyway, so why not feel a little more comfortable while he did?

That sounded antithetical in theory but theorists had clearly never felt this drained of their social battery.

“Sure,” Cyrene said, and lifted her hand up in an almost hesitant wave. Her smile seemed the same though so maybe he was just overthinking it and he wasn’t outright dismissing her at all. “I’ll see you later, Phai.”

He fled. His steps may have been slow, slightly stumbled movements but there was no doubt in his mind that he was fleeing.

Titans, he was tired. When did talking to his friends become so exhausting?

(Probably around the time his mind had stopped hesitating each time he killed them, but hey, who was to say for certain?)

The sun was setting by the time he stopped in a small alleyway, all threads in the city accounted for. He'd fixed any fraying threads he'd found - rebinding them with stronger knots and lattice-like webbing.

That was one task completed. One more to go.

He checked the time on his teleslate - they still had half of the Parting hour to go and, as such, it was still possible that he could get the 'early' rest he'd promised Hyacine - and spotted a new message on his teleslate.

Ah. The express must've reached a pocket of the galaxy that was connected to the intergalactic web. The trailblazer had messaged him a single emoji: a chimera with its head tilted, a question mark rising from its head. Phainon returned Stelle's emoji with one of his own. Also a chimera, though his was half melted into the ground, its soul trying to escape its body.

His teleslate buzzed with a single sentence: *'Disappointed, but not surprised.'*

…Rude, but not terribly unwarranted.

He sent a quick report of how he'd been forced to go to the clinic, received zero sympathy (he didn't know what he was expecting, honestly), and several confusing memes. Then, as quickly as he'd found the trailblazer online and able to respond, Stelle was out of service and his messages could no longer reach her.

"I guess that's as much a sign as anything else to get back to it," Phainon murmured, and began the long trek back towards Kephale plaza.

Chapter End Notes

next time: kephale plaza. and then anaxa. (for real this time).

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> i'd just like to point up to the tags and remind you of one of them.
> angst and humor
>
> *angst* and humor.
>
> definitely rears its head in the first half of this one. so, uh, yeah. please be careful if you're not in the headspace for angst.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Okhema’s ruins were bearable during the day, but when night struck they quickly became haunting.

Daylight was linked with safety. Evernight with danger. To walk through a ravaged Okhema during the day meant to walk through a city that was preparing to rebuild, a city that held hope that it would one day fix itself. To walk through the same ruins at night was to succumb to the danger of entropy and the Black Tide.

Adjusting to a new rhythm of day and night would take time. Hopefully, the people of Okhema would one day begin to associate the dark with restfulness and not the harrowing need to grab the nearest available weapon to protect oneself. The change would come, but it would take longer than the four days they’d lived within the Era Nova.

Until then, the citizens would settle into their new routine - lighting as many candles and torches as possible, locking themselves and their flames inside their living quarters and hiding from a sky dotted with stars.

Phainon couldn’t blame them for it. An Okhema enshrouded in shadows was a harrowing place - shadows slunk just outside of one's peripheral vision, sounds amplified until even the slightest crunching footstep sounded like the prelude to battle, and meagre moonlight illuminated the worst of the

damage in such a way that it seemed as if the world was still actively ending.

…This was the Okhema that lingered in his mind each time he thought of deliverance. It was a tide-torn emptiness that he alone had walked for millenia.

Though wild flames were not actively dancing between the buildings, the glow of candles was enough to spark the memory. It swallowed him whole and Phainon could do nothing but fall into it.

Heat licked across his cheeks as he made his way to Kephale plaza and he knew it was imagined but that did not ease the memory of the burn.

It did not help that speckled rays of light from the moon and stars created ghosts. Refracted light off of closed window panes created corpses in the streets - most of them faces he'd forced himself not to remember, some of them too memorable to forget.

He turned a corner and instead of seeing rubble pushed into piles in front of abandoned infrastructure, Cyrene's broken bodies lined the street. He climbed down stairs and a cluster of three broken pillars removed from the path were the corpses of the three remaining Tribios priestesses, doll-like strings frayed, fabric peeling. His foot caught on a loose rock and when he looked down it was not rock but the bloodied hand of Hyacine, wanting - even in death - to reach out to him.

He grit his teeth, ground his jaw until it ached and kept walking through Okhema's warped streets. The city was disfigured, trying desperately to embellish itself in fanciful decoration - unfortunately, it was trying to use *his* memories to do it. That meant he was faced with a merciless mural of murdered companions and fragmented cycles.

None of this was real.

Phainon *knew* it wasn't. It was not the first time that the world had glitched around him and it would not be the last.

And yet his chest ached at the sight, regardless of the knowledge that what he saw was false. His eyes burned and his blood boiled. He leaned into the flicker of anger - it was better than grieving - and lifted his head high.

He'd fought against a crazed intellitron, a Lord Ravager and even an Aeon. He had not bowed his head to any of them - not once. Phainon was not about to bow his head to false ghosts and aching memories.

The false images followed him all the way to the gate of Kephale plaza. Then, they lingered, unwilling to follow.

Phainon did not look back. He never did. He simply stepped over the threshold into the ruined square and made his way towards whatever piles of debris had been left for him to remove.

There wasn't much.

In his absence, the construction workers had done a commendable job of clearing things.

Where there had been many fallen stones and pillars, now there were only a few left behind. Phainon did a quick count - four. Whether they'd been left for him to remove or left for the following day's work was difficult to say. He removed them regardless.

It would be an understatement to call them heavy. Even a Chrysos Heir would have struggled to pull them along. That was fine - reinforcing muscles with thread would keep them from tearing under the strain, and hardening bones with Georios' coreflames would leave them unbreakable.

The weight didn't feel lighter but moving things became easier.

In no time at all, the rubble was gone and Phainon found himself in empty silence with nothing to do.

Probably for the best to head home then, like he'd promised.

He cast his gaze around the plaza one final time to ensure he hadn't missed anything major. It fell on another pile of debris that seemed more organised

than one would have expected. A small thing, light caught on flecks of gold.

Ah.

That.

Phainon was moving before he could properly think about what he was doing. The shimmer of gold etched into stone left his blood sizzling against blood vessels.

They'd collected whatever remains of Kephale they could find. Not for his sake, he knew that, but it felt almost like some sort of gift regardless. Now he wouldn't need to go *looking.*

Squatting on the ground, Phainon reached for the first fragment of mural. Nothing but stone painted gold. Without any detailing, it had probably been part of the depicted dawn device.

'Do you not see the truth behind this place, Lord Khaslana?'

The words were so clear in his mind that Phainon stiffened and searched for their owner. The plaza remained empty - no life, artificial or otherwise, existed except for him.

He grit his teeth and snarled, "Even destroyed, you won't shut up."

Curling his fingers around the stone in his hand, Phainon heaved out a staggered breath. Unlike before, where it had disintegrated into a fine dust, the rock *melted.* Molten, liquid rock dripped from his fingers, sizzling against the stone courtyard.

The ground beneath him was becoming pockmarked with gold and Phainon couldn't bring himself to care. All he could bring himself to do was reach for another piece of mural and continue to burn.

'Kephale is to Amphoreus what the Destruction will be to the galaxy. The peace that the people thank the Skyfather for is nothing but a… fickle falsification. It is nothing but a prelude to—"

“*Enough.”* Phainon snapped.

Before he could think, he was moving. A piece of half melted rock left his hand with the force of a million coreflames, aimed in the direction of a nonexistent voice. It smashed into a wall at the edge of the plaza and then *kept going*.

Phainon scrambled to his feet, eyes wide, his pulse thudding rapidly against his ribs.

The wall crumpled on itself. Brick collapsed to the floor and shattered as if it were glass.

Behind it, Phainon watched a building stagger, groaning under its own weight. There was no time to support it with Mnestia’s threads. Within seconds, it had succumbed. A plume of dust ballooned in the air like smoke.

…He really hadn’t meant to do that.

His hands were trembling. Strange - all of his body was. It was difficult to know if it was caused by shock, rage or regret. Could’ve been a combination of all three.

“...Oh…” Phainon murmured, the words deafening in the aftermath of his destruction. “...Oh that is… not good.”

At least a second building hadn’t collapsed. Or any more walls. Was that a silver lining? Probably not.

This was all probably just a sign that he needed to get the fuck out of here before anyone came looking.

Bolting wasn’t necessarily the best idea but it was the only option that Phainon could think of. His muscles tensed, his head swam and there was nothing else he could do.

He darted past the exit with such speed he hardly clocked the curl of a tail hidden behind the edge of the gate. Cipher? …No, it was probably just another hallucination.

Phainon kept moving. His steps were rushed, frantic things. His chest was heaving not just from exertion but his rage. It was difficult to put out the flames and let them die - it was difficult to *want to*. Still, he had to do something about the thrum of destruction currently sitting in his veins.

When he eventually stopped, it was in a small dilapidated courtyard just off of an abandoned alley. Alone, he pressed his palms against closed eyes and tried to drink in air with long, deep breaths. It didn't really help, but he hadn't expected it to do much.

He sighed, dropped his hands and opened his eyes.

"Sleep now," he murmured. "Figure this out tomorrow."

The world warped around him, blurred and twisted.

Oh. Okay, no, it wasn't the world, he was just lightheaded. That was fine - he just needed to wade through it. A few seconds and his body would sort itself out. Then he'd head back to his room.

Phainon waited and it did not sort itself out.

Instead, his body wobbled. Spots of black entered his vision and there was little time to catch himself before his legs gave way beneath him.

"Wait—no, *no*—" He stuttered, realisation spreading through now numb limbs.

His body had already waited long enough; It would not wait any longer. Instead, it dragged him to the ground and, as his chin bounced off of stone, it dragged him into sleep.

Consciousness returned with warmth caressing his cheek and daylight prickling at closed eyelids.

Phainon would've been lying if he said he felt particularly rested or that his exhaustion had settled purely because he'd been unconscious long enough for the sun to have risen. He'd clearly rested enough that his body was satisfied enough to return control of its functioning back to him though, which was always nice.

The warmth of the sun had not woken him, though. Nor had his body's relent of control.

He had been woken by the gentle drift of conversation. The voices were those he knew well - though the combination of them was a puzzling thing.

"—breathing appears steady, and past the bruising there's no external signs of injury. Like I said, there's little risk in moving him."

"You can't check for internal signs?"

"Observation shows he'll be fine until he wakes. That will suffice. Any other tests have already likely been undertaken by Hyacine already - I see little point in redoing them. Now, are you going to move him or do I need to send for someone else?"

"You don't need to call for anyone else."

There was a shuffle from nearby.

The idea of being carried elsewhere was so mortifying that Phainon forced his eyes open before he was truly ready to be awake. He flinched back - not from the pair nearby him, but because his head was angled in such a way that the first thing he saw was the literal *sun*.

"Ugh," he moaned, lifting an arm that felt like cement and throwing it over his eyes. "Sun's bright."

"Ah," Professor Anaxa said. "So you're finally awake."

Finally? That implied he'd slept for a long time. The ache in his bones made it evident that he had not.

Phainon turned his head and opened his eyes a second time. This time, no longer staring straight into the sun, he was able to see outlines. Though his eyes stung from staring into a blaze, he could still clearly make out a pair of bodies. Professor Anaxa was staring down at him with crossed arms.

Beside him stood Mydei, who looked a mixture between exasperated and concerned. He was a step closer to Phainon than the professor was - though that wasn't too surprising. From the little he'd heard, Mydei had clearly been brought along as a means of transport. It made sense, Mydei had the most experience in lugging his unconscious body around.

"Mostly awake," Phainon murmured, and lifted a hand to rub the sleep from his eyes. He paused halfway when he caught sight of just how messy his hands were. A layer of dust and rock had dried against the skin. Flecks of gold had mixed with burnt, speckled grey.

He dropped his hand - his eyes had gone through enough when staring at the sun, he wasn't going to make them withstand a dried dusting of granite. Instead, he sat up. Swallowed down the groan that came with the first aching movement of the day.

Mydei opened his mouth to say something and Phainon, knowing he wouldn't necessarily like whatever he said, cut him off before the words could begin.

He said, "Funny coincidence that I'd see you here. What brings you both to this neck of the woods?"

Mydei closed his mouth. The suddenness of his frown left Phainon wishing he hadn't woken up.

"You were late to our meeting," Anaxa said. His gaze was an unmoving thing, a relentless force designed to keep Phainon fixed in place. The design worked - Phainon did not move an inch. "Naturally, I thought it best to come find you myself."

Their… meeting. Hadn't that been during the Lucid hour? Surely he hadn't slept for longer than the ten quints it would've taken to see them into the

Lucid hour.

No, that was absurd.

Yet, with the sun as high in the sky as it was, doubt began to trickle in.

“Imagine my surprise,” Anaxa continued, when it became clear that Phainon had no response ready for him, “when I found you unconscious in this courtyard. It is not the place one would assume Okhema’s deliverer would take a nap.”

He said it in a tone that seemed to imply he had not been surprised in the slightest. As if he’d been expecting something like this to happen.

Napping… yeah, that was definitely what he was doing.

“I was branching out on location,” Phainon said.

Mydei’s frown deepened. He said, “You passed out.”

“Nope,” Phainon said, because denial was his best friend and it would always be there for him. “You can’t prove that.”

“You’ve got bruises that prove that.”

Hm. That wasn’t proof enough. It was intangible at best; The prince was clearly reaching.

“Could’ve gotten these bruises anywhere,” Phainon said. Again, before Mydei could respond, he glanced back to Anaxa and said, “I didn’t realise I was late. That explains why you came,” —hardly, when did Anaxa come looking for those who stood him up? It was utterly *absurd*— “but it doesn’t really explain why Mydei is here…?”

For a moment, the pair simply stared at him.

Then Anaxa said, “Well, I’m hardly capable of carrying you home. I brought Mydeimos here so he could.”

Oh yeah. *Scholar*.

Anaxa wasn't exactly well known for his *physical* strength. Phainon had watched the man struggle to carry a particularly large pile of books - he wasn't exactly someone capable of carrying the dead weight of an unconscious warrior over his shoulder.

"I don't need to be carried anywhere," Phainon said.

"Not now that you're awake, no." Anaxa agreed.

"Debatable," Mydei said, gruffly. "Can you stand without collapsing?"

That sounded almost like a challenge. It probably wasn't one, but Phainon was going to take it as if it were.

"Of course I can stand," he said.

He went to push up, felt his legs tremble and steeled himself.

Mydei, who had been watching him closely, sighed and held out his hand. Phainon stared, not quite registering the meaning. He only took it when Mydei let out an exasperated huff.

Once he was on his feet, his trembling ceased. The change in position had shocked his system enough to allow his body the space to remember how to support itself.

"It's later than I'd have liked," Anaxa said, "and I have some errands I require completing, but we can still continue with our meeting. Are you still available?"

Phainon had just woken in the remains of a ruined courtyard. It was pretty clear that he had no other plans for the day.

He brushed dust from his clothes and sighed. "Yeah, I'm still available."

"Perfect," Anaxa said. "Mydeimos, you may join us as well."

The look in Mydei’s eye seemed to suggest he would have joined them whether Anaxa had given his permission or not.

“Come along, then,” Anaxa said, and led the pair out of the courtyard and back into the streets of Okhema.

Chapter End Notes

next time: mydei, anaxa and a little bit of progress.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> it's been a while, huh? as apology, have a longer chapter! (it was going to be shorter but the scene started to get away from me and I really wanted to stop where I did.)
>
> hope you all enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Okhema’s weather seemed uncertain whether it wanted to entertain sunshine or rain, and thus, had settled for a humidity that clung to the skin like a film.

It was a horrid thing. Though Phainon hadn't noticed it upon waking in the courtyard - his mind hadn’t been able to focus on anything other than the fact that Mydei and Anaxa had found his sleeping body among rubble - he was certainly feeling it now.

For the rest of Okhema, they must’ve been hating how warm it left them. For Phainon, the wet vapours tickled his skin and offered him chills. The water helped cool his boiling body, yes, but the more his temperature dropped, the more he wanted to *burn.*

Also, his clothes were growing more and more damp. Which was an inconvenience. The fabric was beginning to stick to the skin like glue, bunching up uncomfortably. Tugging at the hem of his shirt did little to help; Cyrene had been right when she'd claimed that there was too much loose fabric. Every time he unbunched the front of his shirt, the back half would bunch in a way that left his skin crawling and vice versa.

If he really *wanted* to, he could've used his coreflames to dry his slowly saturating clothes. But that ran the risk of singing the fabric. Or, if his control wavered too much, outright setting them on fire and burning them so thoroughly that the ashes would be too fine for the human eye to pick

out. Walking through Okhema without clothes was already a horrendous idea - walking through Okhema without clothes because he'd *set himself on fire* was even worse.

Yeah, that wasn't going to happen.

Instead he tugged on his shirt one final time and decided that he'd just have to grin and bear it. Mydei's stare had been prickling at his back each time he moved - no doubt watching as he tried to smooth out all of the unflattering folds and bunching of fabric - and he didn't want to give him any further signs that this walk was *uncomfortable.*

Luckily, Mydei hadn't commented yet. He hadn't said *anything* since they'd begun walking, but that didn't mean that he wasn't going to speak eventually.

Maybe he was waiting for Phainon to fill their empty silence. During the cycles that had been their dynamic. Well, not the dynamic of *Khaslana* and Mydei - that had mostly included fighting until his sword pierced Mydei's tenth thoracic vertebrae, at which point he'd leave Mydei's body in a puddle of his own blood and walk away with the stolen coreflame of Strife—

Something caught in his throat. Bile probably. Phainon closed his eyes, tripped over his own feet and managed to catch himself before either Mydei or Anaxa had a chance to right him.

— *but,* yeah. *Phainon* and Mydei's dynamic had always included Phainon filling the silence. He should've been doing that. Right now would've been nice. And was probably expected. But he couldn't think of what he could say. All he could think of was that with the current humidity, the water trickling down his neck was beginning to remind him of blood.

"You okay?" Mydei murmured, moving quicker to reach Phainon's side.

Phainon flashed him a porcelain smile - it was easily breakable yet beautifully artificial. "Just peachy. Loose tile, that's all."

It hadn't been and they both knew it.

But Phainon really wasn't about to start talking about how the *weather* was reminding him of the times he'd murdered his best friend and left his body behind without looking back. At least he'd *buried* Cyrene each time he killed her. He'd only ever buried Mydei's body once.

Their walk quickly descended into an awkward game of *'who will break the silence next?'*

Anaxa and Mydei might have been seasoned pros at keeping to their silence, but they did not have Phainon's current dedication to the cause.

Eventually, it was Anaxa who spoke next. They'd just turned onto one of the larger roads that had been built as a private walkway for droma deliveries, heading towards the outskirts of town in the direction of the Path of Parting. The professor said, "So, tell me about your wings. What were the circumstances that led to their development?"

Before Phainon had the opportunity to respond, Mydei's voice cut through the silence. Confusion filtered into his words. "Wait. What wings?"

"My wings," Phainon said. Which was probably just stating the obvious and didn't actually offer any clarification at all. *Or* any answer to Anaxa's question.

Was Mydei frowning again? Ah - yep. That was definitely a frown. Still mostly a confused one - Phainon was pretty sure the Kremnoan had a frown that displayed every one of his emotions. Well, except for happiness, of course. That was the rare emotion that allowed the softening of his eyes and the slight tug upward of his lips.

That was a nice thing to imagine - Mydei's smile. It'd been a thousand years since he'd seen it but the memory sat warm behind his ribs.

"You have wings now?" Mydei asked.

Phainon hummed, affirming.

“Yes, Mydeimos,” Anaxa said, waving the question aside as if he’d expected more from the prince than *confusion.* “He does. Do keep up.”

Despite himself, the faintest smile tugged at Phainon’s lips. It was a rare thing - this duo interacting with one another often enough within a cycle to develop enough familiarity for Anaxa to speak to Mydei in such a way that could be viewed as minorly teasing - but whenever he got to see it, he was always reminded of how dear his friends were to him.

He knew, of course, that he loved *all* of the Chrysos Heirs to - literal - death, but there were some combinations that always reminded him of it more than others.

“Since *when?”* Mydei asked.

From the way he was eyeing his coat, it was clear he was looking for any sign of the additional limbs. Phainon rolled his eyes. Anaxa had also cast his gaze over his shoulder, steps slowing as he fixed a questioning gaze onto Phainon.

…What was a good amount of years to have had wings for, again? It wasn’t like he could just outright say that he’d had his wings for the past 315 million years. That would leave his lies redundant and sure, Phainon wasn’t the *best* liar in Amphoreus - that was *definitely* Cipher - but he should’ve been able to keep things together for at least a week, surely.

“I couldn’t tell you exactly how many,” he said, rushing the math in his head to figure out what would be the best number to give. How many cycles ago made the most sense? How many coreflames was, in his lie of 33 cycles, too many coreflames for a body to hold? “Maybe… some time between the twentieth or twenty-first cycle?”

Yeah, those numbers worked. He’d have had at *least* ten thousand years for the wings to have grown in and 240 coreflames were probably enough flames, in this retelling, to need extra space in his body to store them.

“If you have wings,” Mydei said, “where are they?”

Currently, the old pair had been abandoned in the depths of the Archforge, buried beneath the many piles of abandoned bodies that would go on to be repurposed into anti-matter legion puppets. But Phainon knew they weren't asking about the *previous* pair.

"Stored away," he said. "Staring at my coat isn't going to make them magically appear."

The prince scowled.

"Yes," Anaxa said, oblivious to the weight of Mydei's scowl. Or, perhaps, fully aware of it and simply unwilling to highlight its existence. "Hyacinthia did inform me of your storage methods. Inside of a black hole, was it?"

"Inside of a *what."*

"Yes," Phainon said.

"How fascinating," Anaxa hummed. "To use gravitational collapse and spatial distortion in such a manner. And to manage to do so in such a way that avoids degradation of what is stored inside. Surely this requires a subsectory layer of reality within the sphere of unreality of the black hole." He nodded his head. "It's truly remarkable."

If the professor thought it was remarkable, then it probably was.

Phainon didn't necessarily agree, but then, he was hardly a scientist. There wasn't much he knew about gravity or black holes or *reality* in the first place. He knew how to alter it in the same way that he knew how to breathe - instinctually. It didn't feel special anymore. It just felt like another tool utilised to reach the Era Nova.

"Though," Anaxa said, finally, "from what I have been told, the action of opening and closing the space hasn't been fine tuned and so the accompanying destruction might not be cost–effective."

“Yes, well,” Phainon said, absently, “If you ever need help with landscaping, then it *definitely* becomes cost-effective.”

Or if ever Amphoreus needed to fight more monsters. A little bit of ruined land was always favourable to letting it become overcome with the Black Tide.

Anaxa set unimpressed eyes onto him and shook his head. “As lucrative as demolition companies might find your skills, it is still necessary to figure out a way to keep the damages minimal.”

“Figure it out?”

“I would hope you are not intending on destroying Amphoreus’ landscape every time I request to see your wings. Are you?” Anaxa said.

Well… no. But Phainon hadn’t exactly planned on bringing them out all that often, either. There wasn’t any point to it. Why bother flying when most places in Amphoreus were easily navigated by foot? Even if he needed to go anywhere further than walking distance, he could travel via the space anchors that the trailblazer had left behind. Surely they weren’t that hard to use?

“How often are you going to request to see my wings?”

Anaxa turned his gaze back to the road. It had opened up even more - they weren’t quite at the path of parting yet, but they could see the bridge at the edge of their vision. Beneath it, the river that bisected the city shimmered - people had clearly been doing well in removing debris from it; the water was much clearer than it had been at the beginning of the Era Nova.

“Arguably,” Anaxa said, “any number higher than zero should be enough to want to minimise gravitational damage.”

Alright. Well, yeah. He can't really deny that one, can he?

“...Right,” Phainon said. “Well, if you don’t mind offering your help on that, Professor.”

He wouldn’t typically ask for the help but - this wasn’t for his sake. It was for the sake of Amphoreus. And… even if it wasn’t… the idea of figuring out how to minimise destruction left him wanting to curl up under a blanket for… at least a decade. As much as he hated being so destructive, it felt impossible to figure out how to counteract it whenever he *was*.

Just like Lygus had said: For him, it was an inevitability.

He was always destined to be better at destroying things than he was at keeping them in one piece. Amphoreus. The Chrysos Heirs. *Himself*.

Knowing how to mitigate damage didn’t come naturally to him. If he needed to swallow his pride and have Professor Anaxa tell him how to do it so that he wouldn’t ruin the Era Nova and watch it crumble in his hands, then he’d do it. He would add it to his penance - another goal, another wish, another—

Titans, he was tired thinking about everything that still waited for him.

“It will act as an interesting thought exercise,” Anaxa said.

Well, at least one of them would find it interesting.

What were the chances that Anaxa would find the destruction in his chest as interesting? That he’d take it upon himself to try to deconstruct it, to remake him the way Nanook’s gaze had atomised him, had left his body trembling as he’d fought, knowing that he was simultaneously being unwound and reshaped at the same time.

Would he be enthralled by the concept? Or would he be horrified?

…Ha. As if he’d ever share *that*.

“Thanks,” he murmured, and tried to put all thoughts of the Aeon from his head before he destroyed something *else*. Before the rage returned with such a vengeance that they were able to see past the cracks of his porcelain smile to the flames within and see that the Phainon *they* knew wasn’t ever

coming back, he was just a monster now, only fuelled by hatred and bloodshed and—

“We’re here,” Anaxa said, and his whirring thoughts settled.

They had reached a large building that had been used for hosting smaller community events. Phainon had been to a few over the many cycles. A couple of weddings. Once or twice, literature conventions filled with handwritten scrolls, visited with Castorice after pulling some strings to let the pair explore after the hall had closed to the general public.

Currently, the main hall was being used as a makeshift mess hall.

Tables lined the hall. Most were filled - it must’ve been some sort of dinner rush, as the hall seemed almost packed full with Okheman and Kremnoan alike. A roar of chatter that seemed cacophonous. It was the sort of noise that was currently missing from the inner sections of Okhema. Lively and welcoming, if not a little too loud.

Why had they come *here* of all places*?* If he was going to bring out his wings, surely they wanted somewhere far emptier.

Oh, of course - Anaxa had mentioned chores that he needed to get done, hadn’t he? Phainon wasn’t sure why he’d assumed the man would be completing those *after* they’d seen to his wings.

Why had they come to a mess hall, though? It was hardly the sort of place he could see Anaxa coming to willingly. Usually, the professor was far more antisocial - he’d always been one to keep himself isolated.

…Surely that hadn’t changed during the *single* cycle he hadn’t been present for. Stelle hadn’t caused that big of a deviation as the Deliverer, right? He knew his fellow Chrysos Heirs. Nothing could change them *that* much.

“Why…?” He murmured, before remembering that it wasn’t actually any of *his* business and that questioning their location wasn’t the politest thing he could do.

If Anaxa thought his question rude, he wasn’t bringing attention to it. He simply spared Phainon a momentary glance and said, “They’ve delivered some reagents here from the grove. The two of you can entertain yourselves while I receive them. This might take some time.”

He had led them into the hall but now deviated down one of the corridors, disappearing into its depths. Phainon watched as he walked away until the tasseled edges of Anaxa’s billowing coat followed him around a corner.

Then, he was left alone with Mydei.

Mydei, who was waiting for him to finish staring after Anaxa as if he’d lost a lifeline - which he had because now he had to interact with Mydei, *alone.*

He wasn't ever going to be ready for this.

“They’re delivering things here?” Phainon asked, when it seemed that Mydei wanted him to say something. *Anything*.

Mydei dipped his head in a nod and led them into the hall. They weaved through city guards, kremnoan soldiers and civilians alike as they ventured towards one of the empty tables at the far end of the hall. Phainon’s lips pulled into a half-smile each time he made eye contact with anyone, trying to ignore how his name rippled through the room as if he were *respectable*, one of their saviours and not a murderer trying desperately to atone.

“It’s difficult for couriers to run packages through the city,” Mydei said. He was paying the crowd less mind - most of his focus remained on Phainon. “They don’t know what’s structurally stable and what isn’t. So they’re sticking to deliveries on the outskirts of Okhema, for now.”

That made sense. Most couriers weren’t capable of walking away from a collapsed building with only a few injuries. If they entered the wrong part of the city, they’d be risking their lives. It just wasn’t worth it.

…Phainon could offer to run deliveries through the city too. It was something to think about - with Zagreus’ coreflames, it wouldn’t take too long to get from A to B.

Though, really, the need would be made redundant if he put more effort into rebuilding Okhema and keeping it structurally stable.

“No one’s been injured since the evacuation, have they?” Phainon asked.

“Not grievously," Mydei said. “Most people aren’t stupid enough to go outside of the reported ‘safe zones’.”

He sighed, and added, “Though, Aglaea’s going to have to update those reports. Apparently, some areas aren’t as safe as we thought they were.”

A shiver ran down Phainon’s spine. Had he… missed something with his threads?

“What do you mean?” He asked.

“A building collapsed last night by Kephale Plaza,” Mydei said. He wasn’t looking at Phainon pointedly or anything, and yet, as they settled into their seats, Phainon found him unable to sit still. Squirming beneath a gaze that didn't know it should be judging him.

Ah. That had been him. He hadn’t missed anything with his threads; He’d just lost his mind during the night and subsequently lost his temper. Ha.

Yeah, no, he wasn’t going to own up to it. He’d rather—

Well it was probably best not to consider all the things that he’d do to keep *this* a secret. Probably wasn’t the healthiest thing to entertain such thoughts.

“No one was hurt?”

Mydei shook his head.

That, at least, was a relief. He swallowed the sigh of relief before it could give him away and tapped his fingers on the table instead.

“Aglaea’s looking into it,” Mydei said, which sent a wave of dread crashing against Phainon’s spine. Something caught in his chest. He was going to have to keep avoiding her, then. Lest she realise he was the culprit.

“I see,” Phainon said, and stared at the cracks in the wooden table.

They fell back into silence.

It unspooled like thread, extending further and further, until it became unbearable and Phainon—

“Ah, Lord Phainon, Lord Mydeimos,” came a voice from behind them.

—was fine, actually. He looked up and smiled because he was *fine.* And he wasn’t losing his mind. And Aglaea wasn’t looking into the destruction that *he* had caused.

The man wasn’t one that Phainon remembered the name of. He recognised him though - a chef from Janusopolis who he succeeded to save from the black tide and bring to Okhema more often than he’d failed. He had a teenage daughter who had wanted to be a poet. Millions of cycles and she’d only ever made it to Okhema alongside him three times.

She was standing beside him now, delivering food to the various patrons. Currently, she held a tray that held two bowls.

Stelle had managed to save her this time.

(Or maybe… he could congratulate *himself* for the fact she was here. He’d kept the black tide away from their last cycle, right? So maybe he could pretend he’d managed to save the both of them in a fourth cycle?

..

…No, he shouldn’t take that accomplishment from Stelle. She’d kept them all alive. *He’d* gotten himself trapped inside of Irontomb.)

“We just wanted to thank you both for saving Amphoreus,” the man continued. Phainon really should've known his name. Why couldn't he remember it? “I know it’s not much but we hoped a meal would show our thanks. Please, enjoy.”

His daughter set down the tray between them, offered a smile and quiet thanks of her own, and before Phainon could think to refuse said offering, they were gone. He stared into the space they had once occupied, eyes wide.

Mydei took one of the bowls and placed it in front of him.

Staring down at it, Phainon froze.

They'd brought out stew - something filling that was easy to make large amounts of for all those utilising the mess hall. It smelled… inviting. Nice. They were wasting it on him. He didn't need to eat. Hadn't in… millions of cycles. Hadn't been a point in doing so.

"What is it?" Mydei asked, as he took the other bowl for himself.

"Ah," Phainon said, guiltily. "I don't—"

He couldn't really bring himself to look up from the stew. Carrots and potatoes floated in the broth. They'd used Droma meat in it too - either that, or there was some other meat with a purple hue to it that he'd never heard of across millions of his lives.

Mydei was waiting for him to continue, so he forced out the words. "I don't need to eat anymore. You know... because of all of the coreflames. I don't even get hungry anymore."

The exhaustion hadn't just brought him weariness - currently, it had brought him uncertainty too. He didn't know why he hadn't refused the offering while they were still there. Politeness, probably.

"They didn't need to— I don't need—" Finally he dragged his gaze *up*. Mydei was watching him as if he'd determined that Phainon was not a person but simply a bunch of puzzle pieces that he needed to clip together. "They should've given this to someone who needs it. That's all."

Mydei continued to stare at him. It was as if Phainon could see the cogs moving behind his eyes. Churning away, around and around, as if trying to

figure out the best thing to say. Mydei had always been serious about nutrition and eating well; He was probably going to turn this into an argument, wasn't he?

Apparently not.

Because eventually, Mydei just shrugged and said, "Okay."

That was it…?

"...*Okay?"*

He wasn't going to make any comment? He wasn't going to push, or tell him that he needed to?

Mydei was just going to… *accept it?*

"Yeah." Mydei said. "You don't have to eat it. We'll just send it back."

Phainon couldn't do anything but stare as Mydei began to eat.

No arguments raised. They would simply… send it back?

…Well. No, they couldn't. That would be rude. And past being rude, it would be a *waste.*

33 million lifetimes of growing up in Aedes Elysiae had all included his mother teaching his child self never to waste food - especially in the winter months when their harvest had been sold and fresh produce became more scarce. While those memories didn't always feel real anymore after all of the truths he had learned about Amphoreus, the lessons they instilled stuck with him.

Waste not. Want not. And all of that.

So no - he couldn't just let them throw it out. Phainon couldn't do that. Disregarding the kindness of the people whose dreams he'd decided to carry for eons, wasting things that he shouldn't have received in the first place—

Phainon’s breaths caught in his chest as he reached for the spoon.

(*“When,”* a part of his brain hissed, rattled and raging, *“did the idea of food become so stressful?”*

“Probably,” the part of himself that was stuck in eternal grief replied, “*around the time we realised that we’d killed everyone we could ever share it with.*”)

The first bite was the worst. He’d forgotten that his body was inhospitable to anything that couldn’t withstand intense heat, and a bite of potato was quickly rendered ash against his tongue. He choked, coughing flakes into his hand.

Mydei’s stare was a weighted thing but he did not say anything.

Phainon had to figure something out so that the other man wouldn’t worry. Before Mydei could ask, he shoved another spoonful into his mouth. This time, he let instinct take over - a thin layer of water courtesy of Phagousa’s coreflames, to keep the intense heat from burning the food so quickly. He managed to swallow it down before the food started to burn. There was only an aftertaste of burning.

On the third bite, he adjusted his coreflame usage enough that he could begin to taste the stew. There was a hint of spice to it, possibly paprika. And herbs, too, though they’d been mixed into the broth well enough that they didn’t feel gritty against his tongue.

The flavours were explosive. He wasn't entirely sure if it was in a good way or not. It tasted good, yes, but it was all accompanied by something he couldn't name.

How long had it been since he’d let himself indulge in tiny kindnesses like this? Even if it was only to ensure things were not wasted? Even if it left panic rising in his chest?

…His stomach lurched. Not with nausea, but as if, after lifetimes of being ignored, it was glad to have finally found itself of use once more.

When he’d finished - stew filling consumed and broth drained - Phainon placed his spoon down on the table beside his bowl and stared into the now empty crockery.

He felt… strange.

Like he didn’t understand himself as well as he thought he did.

“I guess you were hungry after all,” Mydei said, as he continued to stare into the empty bowl. As if this hadn’t just opened a bag of worms and he wasn’t currently questioning when, exactly, he’d reached a point of not understanding his own mind anymore, or his body, or—

—Phainon *really* couldn’t think about it. If he did, he was going to cry and if he did that then what happened if he couldn’t *stop?*

Remember, he reminded himself, trying to add some cheer into the thought and falling flat. *I’m fine. This is fine.*

“Maybe,” Phainon murmured. “Mostly I didn’t want to waste it.”

Over his head, he did not see the way that Mydei lifted his gaze up. He did not see the way he made eye contact with Anaxa from across the room. He did not see the small exchange of nods. Nor did he see their rising concern.

All he saw were the cracks at the bottom of his empty bowl.

Was it strange, if it reminded him of himself?

Chapter End Notes

> next time: anaxa finally, *actually* gets to look at phai's wings. phainon thinks that he's maybe ~~probably~~ having a minor breakdown.

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

> *in which phainon's having a bit of a meltdown and today becomes even worse than yesterday.*

Chapter Notes

> you ever look at your characters and wonder why they're refusing to go along with your original plot ideas? yeah well, that's me currently. i had set ideas and then this chapter was written and now we're going elsewhere with it. whelp. it be like that sometimes.
>
> also, just a reminder - i don't have a beta so I typically look for typos and the likes on my own. if you ever spot any that i've missed, pls feel free to point them out!! thanks~
>
> oh, also, if y'all want to speak with me or get lil updates on my writing in general. find me on twitter under @MintCLeaves

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He couldn’t stop staring at the bowl.

Phainon’s attention was laser focused on it. Each ceramic crack burned itself into his retinas. He ran his fingers absently across a chip on the rim - it was the faintest thing, only visible if one truly *looked* for it, not even enough to prick skin if he applied pressure.

“Phai—n.” Mydei must’ve been saying his name but the words felt like they were coming from somewhere far more distant. As if he’d plunged his head into water and was struggling to hear through all the pressure and the chill. “—n’n.”

It was difficult to snap out of it. To look away. Phainon could only stare as his thoughts started to stick like syrup - difficult to traverse, trapping him

like a fly that couldn’t break free. Maybe passing out had knocked things out of place in his head. His thoughts were rattling against his skull. His senses *rippled* and he was certain that the world around him was glitching more than ever. Everything was tinged red. Errors in the code. The only way to stop it was to start over—

“Phainon.”

He jolted as a hand blanketed his own. A mixture of warmth and cold. Colder than the fever that was his permanent temperature. Warmer than hands wrapped in gauntlets should have been.

Phainon’s gaze jolted from bowl to flesh and something caught in his chest as he saw the bare skin of Mydei’s hands. One moment, they were clean, a grounding touch that had brought him back to the present. Next, they were sticky and stained with gold. Mydei wasn’t wearing his gauntlets. Had Phainon not noticed this whole time? What if something happened?

(If Phainon tried to kill him now, Mydei wouldn’t even last a *second).*

“...Yes?” He murmured, and tried to blink the glitching hallucinations away. It was only half successful. They disappeared but never for long.

“Are you alright?”

…He was beginning to think that maybe he’d gotten a concussion when his body had decided it was time for a quints long siesta without consulting him prior to the event. A concussion would explain why his thoughts were moving strangely and his senses running haywire.

“I’m fine,” he said and, looking up, smiled at Mydei in an attempt to dislodge any remaining embers of concern that the prince was holding on to.

Mydei did not look like he believed him.

—The world glitched, his sight blurred and for a moment the Kremnoan didn’t even look alive. Just glassy-eyed, just choking on the remaining

embers of life left inside of him—

“...Right,” Mydei said. “Are you… sure? You seem…” He paused, as if trying to find the right word. “...Dazed.”

“Never better.” Phainon said. His voice sounded far away; As if it wasn’t his own. A dead, dying thing that held no warmth. And yet, his body felt warm. Too hot. Something inside of him was burning. “...Where are your gauntlets?”

“My… what?”

Phainon lifted Mydei’s bloodied-clean-bloody-clean-*bloody* hand and held it up between them as if it explained everything. “Your gauntlets. You’re not wearing them. Where are they?”

Mydei’s brows furrowed. He said, “I put them away. I don’t need them while rebuilding Okhema.”

Ha. Something bitter and ironic rose in Phainon’s throat and it took all his effort to stop it from emerging. Mydei didn’t realise that he was sitting opposite his murderer because *Phainon* refused to tell him. Didn’t realise that all it would take to kill him at this point was a single slash of his sword. Didn’t realise that he wasn’t *safe* enough to set his weapons down.

“You should wear them,” Phainon murmured, releasing Mydei’s hand.

Brows furrowing even deeper, Mydei stare was unending. “Why?”

…Why *was* Phainon’s mind currently snagging over Mydei's lack of weaponry? Probably the concussion. Or maybe the panic from *eating* had opened the floodwalls to all the rest of the worries lurking at the edge of his consciousness. The numbness he’d gained after millions of cycles, courtesy of the coreflames, had left him. Now *something* had to fill its place.

Was his mind cracking at the edges? He didn’t know. All Phainon really knew was that something wasn’t right. Something was *wrong*. With *him*.

“You might need them,” Phainon said.

“Why don’t you have Dawnbreaker with you, then?” Mydei asked.

Phainon flinched. He couldn’t stop it. It was a full body thing. His muscles seized and his eyes widened and he could not *stop* the dread that filtered into his blood like a curse.

Dawnbreaker was currently held prisoner in the same place he trapped his wings. After breaking free from Irontomb, he’d barely been able to look at it - let alone touch it. So he’d let his powers swallow the sword up, out of sight. There wasn’t a soul in the world capable of being harmed by it now. Not even by accident.

Because he was *never* going to bring Dawnbreaker out. Not in Amphoreus. Not until he left the planet behind to end the Destruction once and for all.

“Phain—”

“Anaxa’s been gone for a while,” Phainon said, hands slamming onto the table with enough strength that the wood split with spiderweb cracks. Luckily, he still had enough hold on himself that it didn’t begin to burn. He pushed up to his feet. “We should go look for him.”

“He said he’d find *us,”* Mydei said. “Just sit back down.”

Yeah. Phainon couldn’t do that. Ash was beginning to catch in his throat and he was all too aware of the fact that his temperature was rising in response to his agitated state. He needed to get out. If he didn’t, he was pretty sure he’d end up setting something on fire.

“He’s got to be here somewhere,” he said and looked over his shoulder, scouring the room for any signs of the professor.

Too many people. Yet not many with Anaxa’s green hair. Most people had more neutral hair colours - there were few people in Okhema that Phainon had met with mint shading. He squinted, trying to disregard Mydei’s voice behind him and made his way through the crowd.

There, near the exit, the man was leaning over a box and inspecting whatever was inside. Components. Ingredients for whatever soul study he'd decided to investigate next.

Phainon kept moving until he was beside Anaxa. His smile was only *slightly* unstable when the professor looked up.

"There you are, Professor," he said.

"Phainon," Anaxa said, brow raised, his working eye widening. "You're creating steam."

"Am I?" He asked. Sure enough, a quick glance at his shoulder showed that faint ripples of steam were rising from his body. The edge of his collar was singed. "Oh. Well. Sometimes that happens. It's fine."

"...I see." Anaxa's gaze flicked past him, to Mydei who had followed close behind, and then settled back onto Phainon. "I'll survey the rest of these later. Let us depart."

The sigh of relief that Phainon exhaled was so deep that it felt cavernous. He ignored Anaxa's stare, pointed towards his box of components and asked, "They look heavy. Would you like me to carry them?"

The professor's widened eyes had settled. He'd returned to his usual assessing glances. He said, "Best not to. They're sensitive to heat. Mydeimos will carry them."

Phainon was about to open his mouth to argue that he was more than capable of lowering his body temperature when the edge of a flame caught on his sleeve. He felt the burn as if it were an extension of himself. Slapped a hand over it in an attempt to snuff it from existence.

"Sure," he said and Phainon's wide smile wobbled but refused to fall.

Their next walk was even more awkward than the first.

Luckily, there was a lot less conversation this time. Phainon was left to focus on settling the flames before they could take root and burn him completely. Anaxa and Mydei were content to leave him to cool off, to settle his body that currently steamed in response to raised stress levels.

They talked, but mostly between themselves. Quiet murmurings that Phainon wanted to believe weren't about *him* and, as such, was willing to believe related to the professor's experiments. Probably wasn't true. But Phainon didn't care.

He just wanted this day to be over. Even more so than he'd wanted *yesterday* to be over.

Reality was still a half-moulded thing around him. Last night, at least he'd been able to blame his dead friends in the streets on the strange lighting of the Evernight and the flickering of candles. Now, he couldn't blame it on anything but himself.

Phainon kept his gaze on the backs of his living friends and did his best to ignore all the dead ones. Reminded himself that the dead ones weren't real. He was just a little stressed. And concussed. Probably. Those two things were making the usual hallucinations worse. If he pretended they weren't there then maybe they'd go away.

A dry chuckle caught in his throat. Yeah, *right.* Like it would be that easy.

They left the outskirts of Okhema behind, headed across the Path of Parting and made their way outside of the city. Sunlight continued to bathe them as they walked - it was foreign, to be able to walk away from Okhema and not feel like its light was abandoning them.

Veering off of the path, Anaxa led them towards an abandoned expanse of grass by the riverside. Luckily it was not too overgrown, though some patches were much taller than others.

“Try to minimise the destruction and bring them out quickly,” the professor said, as he waved Phainon forwards. “We’ll stay here until you’re finished.”

Phainon nodded, and removed his coat. Once he'd removed his shirt, he folded the clothes and held them out to Mydei, who took them with a quirked brow.

“I don’t want to set them on fire,” he explained.

“Of course,” Mydei replied, slowly. Then, “That’s a risk?”

“Coreflame wings,” Phainon shrugged.

Mydei opened his mouth, considered, sighed and then closed his mouth. He said, “Sure. Makes sense. Why not?”

“Go on then,” Anaxa said, waving him towards the open expanse of field. “We don’t have all day.”

There wasn’t any reason to delay so Phainon headed further into the grass and began focusing on the feel of his wings. Like usual, they were not hard to locate. The feel of them never really disappeared, it just got a little harder to track. Not quite a numbness, more like he’d pushed the sensation of them to the furthest recess of his mind.

Then, it was just a matter of reworking space.

Easy work. Just like the day previous. A rogue clump of wet grass smacked into his shoulder as the gravity of his black hole settled into Amphoreus. Phainon let out a faint hiss of annoyance, but past that, it was routine as usual.

Open the black hole. Take out wings. Close the black hole.

(He was half tempted to kick at loose dirt out of sheer *pettiness*, but Phainon knew that he was being watched. He shoved the irritation down and told himself that he was above being angry at *grass*.)

The flames engulfing his wings were burning hotter than they usually did. Each feather - usually golden, dappled with white at the edges - shone a dazzling white. Blue flame tinged at the edges. Any dusting from the black hole was washed away in the blaze.

Before bringing his wings out, he'd reinforced himself with coreflames to keep himself from burning. His body - capable of withstanding the heat - held up fine with the faintest reinforcement of water, but the buckle of his choker began to melt and he was forced to remove it before it melted into skin.

His clothes too, struggled against the heat. Luckily, Phagousa’s coreflames kept them from the worst parts of incineration. The grass around them was not as lucky. Grass boiled from green to yellow before his eyes. Then, the longer stalks began to crumble into ash.

Phainon sighed.

“Hm,” Anaxa called, from a distance, making his way over. He lifted a hand to his chin, contemplative. “From what Hyacine informed me, I had thought the temperature was lower than this.”

“The temperature fluctuates,” Phainon said, tiredly, once both the professor and Mydei came to a stop a few feet away.

“Do you have control over it?”

“To a degree.”

Anaxa nodded, considering. “Does utilising coreflames make the burn worse or better?”

Well, he was currently using them to stop from burning everything and it hadn’t exactly made the heat any worse. No, it seemed that the burn was purely controlled by his emotions. Whenever exhaustion slunk in, the flames were lazier. When his rage burned at its highest, the coreflames resonated with it and scalded everything in his immediate vicinity.

Currently, Phainon was learning that panic and guilt manifested heat in a similar way. Though, luckily not quite as molten as his rage. The coreflames weren’t combusting in the same way as when he was enraged. The heat wasn't as volatile, or explosive. It was just *there*.

“Neither,” he said. Anaxa didn’t need to know that the heat was determined by his emotions. If he did, then he’d realise how wild said emotions had become. “The coreflames just burn. Using them doesn’t change how hot they are.”

Again, Anaxa hummed.

Beside him, Mydei crossed his arms and narrowed his eyes in thought.

“Very well.” The professor nodded. “I assume you’re capable of using more than one titan’s power at a time?”

Phainon nodded.

“First, I’d like you to try dousing these flames. Phagousa's coreflames should work effectively in doing so.” Anaxa said.

That was… well. Phainon glanced towards the nearby river and pressed his lips together.

“That’ll only put them out for a few seconds,” Phainon said, after a moment. “I don’t think I'll be able to control enough water to permanently put out—”

“Yes, yes, I know that. As soon as the flames are doused, you’ll use Orynyx’s coreflame to halt the time around your wings. You'll only need to put the flame out for a matter of seconds.”

Alright. Well that was a little bit more plausible. Hopefully. While he wasn’t able to reverse time or mould it in the ways he wanted, it wasn’t an altogether impossible task to halt it in its tracks, though the longer he wanted to pause things, the harder it would become. He'd done it a few

times. Only for a few seconds at a time and only ever in his divine form, but he had proven that it was possible.

Holding it in place for longer than a few seconds though… Maybe if he utilised Mnestia's threads, he could keep the clock firmly in place and that could help keep the time attached to his wings from moving forwards?

"Will I need to do anything else?" Phainon asked.

"Not yet," Anaxa said. "Try that first."

Nodding, Phainon made his way to the river. Phagousa's coreflames thrummed in his blood, bringing with it the scent of sea salt on the breeze. River water rippled in recognition of the power in his veins. Small bubbles of water rose like teardrops falling in reverse. Then, larger spheres.

Phainon raised a hand and the water followed suit. His brows twitched as he focused. Fire was so much easier to control - he wasn't nearly as practiced with liquids.

He brought the water spheres together, - winced as they rippled between transluscent, red and gold, - merging them into a single ball, heavy and distorted under the swell of it's own weight. Then, he tilted his head, considering how best to drench his wings.

"...No point in overthinking it," Phainon murmured, and - considering it was the easiest and only option he could think of - proceeded to loosen his hold on the water and drop it over himself like a balloon. He staggered under the sudden weight that crashed over his shoulders and rooted himself in place with the help of Georios' coreflames to keep from toppling over.

Hm. Okay, so he could've thought a little bit more about that plan. A quick glance over his shoulder showed that the water had snuffed the flame somewhat, though not entirely.

Already they were beginning to burn again.

Hair clung to his forehead. Phainon scraped it from his face with his fingernails and let out a long sigh. Every part of his body was dripping and soaked.

…Titans, he was an idiot.

Phainon turned back to Anaxa and Mydei, somewhat helplessly, and said, “I don’t know what I’m doing.”

“We can see that,” Anaxa said. He was *absolutely* judging him. “You’ll need running water to keep the flames doused. Create a moving stream between yourself and the river.”

Oh right. Yeah, that made more sense. Phainon could do that.

Why couldn’t Anaxa have offered that before he’d dropped several tonnes of river onto himself?

Creating a moving current of water was more difficult than simply altering the gravity of a set amount. He had to weave a route for this new river to follow and then alter the directional flow into something that was mostly contained. Then, let it crash across his back and wings - he shuddered at the sustained cold it brought - and move it along before his own body temperature boiled it.

By the time he was finished, Phainon’s chest was heaving from the exertion.

…Orynyx’s coreflame wouldn’t be any easier to use. Still, at least he knew how to pause time. Now it was just a matter of focus.

Visualise a box around the space he wanted to freeze in time. Each atom inside the box would need to be slowed - Mnestia’s coreflames could help with that. Thread space into a fixed state and reinforce it with the force of hundreds of Orynyx’s coreflames. Time cracked at his mental fortitudes. Phainon added a few thousand more coreflames into the mix.

It took seconds at most but it felt longer. Using Orynyx's coreflame always felt like that. Time sat weird in the mind whenever the titan's power was utilised.

It was altogether exhausting. The exertion left him feeling like he'd run a marathon. Phainon leaned forward, hands on his knees and inhaled deep pockets of air. Keeping the altered time in place around his wings wasn't quite as hard as pausing time in the first place, but it was still difficult. His heart raced in his chest.

"Fascinating," Anaxa said, as both he and Mydei moved closer. "I hadn't thought that you'd be able to do it immediately. With the amount of coreflames you have, it should've taken a lot more practice to reach this point."

Phainon control over the river cracked. Like a waterfall, the floating stream of water crashed into soil, soaking the three men.

"What?" He gasped, his chest heaving.

"Time rarely wants to hold still. It's in a constant state of movement," Anaxa said, wiping the water from his face as if it were little more than a minor inconvenience. "Whether moving backward or forwards, it's always *moving.* To halt it in place… I'd have expected it to take more than thirty-three coreflames."

"I—" Phainon stared, wide-eyed. "—What?"

"Perhaps the power of other coreflames strengthens them? I'll have to rework my equations - I hadn't accounted for this." Anaxa said.

His gaze narrowed in on Phainon's wings. Doused as they were, it was now possible to see each individual feather, and the slow growth of bone beneath them. They were back to their gold colouring, glowing softly like embers in a fire. "How large were they before they were cut off?"

Mydei muttered, "Cut off?"

Phainon ignored him and said, “Approximately… double the length of my arms?”

For a moment, Anaxa simply stared at his now much smaller wings.

Then, his eyes narrowed. “I see.”

He said it in the tone of someone whose mind was beginning to spark with multiple realisations. A shudder rippled down Phainon’s spine.

“...Three hundred and ninety six coreflames, was it?” Anaxa asked.

Mydei’s gaze flicked to Anaxa, questioning.

Phainon swallowed down dread. Then, because it had caught in his throat on the way down, he cleared his throat. Sweat caught on the back of his neck. He said, “Yeah.”

Anaxa continued to stare. His gaze had caught Phainon in a vice - There was nothing he could do but stay rooted in place, let out a small, shaking breath and attempt to keep his expression as neutral as possible.

“...Is that so?” the professor said, dryly.

Chapter End Notes

> don't worry phainon. you're obviously still dreaming. none of this is happening. you're still staring at the bowl!
>
> *(he is not, in fact, still staring at the bowl).*

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

in which, phainon crashes tf out.

Chapter Notes

oh boi. oh, oh, OH BOI.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon’s wings were twitching with the instinct to hunch his shoulders.

If he did anything at all in response to Anaxa’s questions it could *not* be that. To hunch his shoulders would imply that he was guilty of something. If he showed any weakness, then Anaxa was going to read him like a poorly constructed pamphlet that was beginning to curl at the edges.

So, he tried to ignore the twitching that rippled across every feather. Straightened his shoulders and pushed any guilt down into the pits of his stomach alongside every other emotion he’d deigned unnecessary for the current moment.

Then his wings twitched again, accompanied by a full body shudder that racked down his spine with enough force that Phainon’s body trembled in the aftermath.

Ah.

That wasn’t guilt but something more physical. The trembling of his body wasn’t caused by repressed emotion - he was shivering. He’d quenched his flaming wings, drenched himself in water and now the gentle breeze felt like a winter gale. Bumps rose on the flesh of his arms, hair standing on its ends.

“Cold,” he murmured. He reached out to Mydei, footsteps slippery in the now-muddy field and said, “It’s freezing. Pass me my shirt?”

Mydei passed him the shirt. It only had a little bit of blood on the fabric from his bloodied-clean-bloodied hands. He said, “Cold? It’s the middle of summer.”

“I run a little warmer these days,” Phainon said.

There was no way he was getting this shirt over his wings without struggle. He squinted at the fabric, considering how best to move forward and eventually settled on ripping an extra hole into the fabric. His finger fumbled at a first attempt, but luckily, he managed to tear through the fabric much easier on his second. Pulled the new shirt over his head and wiggled his wings until they were freed from a prison of shirt. “Coat?”

The coat was more gold than white. Glitch-stained in blood. Phainon did his best to ignore the stickiness of it as he wrapped it around his shoulders. Probably best not to rip this - Aglaea wouldn’t be too pleased if he did. He could replace the shirt easily enough with just about anything but this coat was irreplaceable. Aglaea had made it for him herself.

He pulled the fabric around his arms in an attempt to soothe his shivering. It didn’t make him feel warmer - it felt about as useful as wrapping oneself in a loose paper towel - but at least the breeze no longer caressed bare skin.

“The coreflames have severely increased your temperature,” Anaxa noted. Since he’d asked about the coreflames, his eye had been narrowed, flicking between Phainon’s wings and face. As if observing every single secret that was hidden behind both. “It seems you regulate your body temperature through your wings. With the flames put out - the cold sets in.”

Phainon grimaced.

“Though, to think that your body is already showing signs of hypothermia…” Anaxa trailed off. Frowned. “Three-hundred ninety six coreflames. From thirty-three cycles?”

Dread coiled in his stomach. Phainon pulled his coat closer around him and said, “*yes.*”

“That can’t be right,” Anaxa said. “The temperature difference wouldn’t be this extreme with that many coreflames. The body wouldn't react as severely. There must’ve been more coreflames.”

Mydei’s gaze flicked between Phainon and Anaxa, lips pressing in a thin line.

“Phainon wouldn’t have…” The Kremnoan muttered. His focus settled solely onto Phainon, the press of his lips twisting with grim understanding as if realising that yes, actually, he *absolutely* would have done whatever Mydei was currently thinking.

“How many other cycles were there?” Anaxa asked.

Beside his dread, something hotter was beginning to curdle in his chest. It didn’t help with the shivering, or his base temperature; This, he knew immediately, wasn’t physical. It was something that needed to be pushed away. Something that was better ignored; Better not to think about it lest it settle in his blood like a disease.

“How many other cycles were there…?” Phainon repeated, the words catching against his tongue as if glued there. His eyes widened. What… the hell? How did someone figure out the truth from casual observation? It didn’t make sense. “Professor. What are you talking about? There were only thirty-three.”

The only way out of this was through it. He was going to have to play the clueless baby chicken that Stelle had once said he was.

Phainon tried to meet their eyes - found that the flicker between lifeless glass and wakeful suspicion was too much, even for him - and cast his gaze to the ground by their feet. It was littered with their corpses. How… wonderful.

Phainon’s lips twisted in distaste.

“Like I said,” Anaxa said, “the temperature difference with four hundred coreflames wouldn’t be enough to cause hypothermia in their absence. Chills, perhaps, but the body would adjust quickly. So how many—”

“*Thirty-three cycles.”* Phainon repeated, more forcefully. One of the dead, not-really-there, Anaxa corpses twitched its fingers, as if trying to tear himself back into life and join the argument. Sunken eyes stared at him, demanding the truth. Despite himself, Phainon leaned back, away from the corpse.

“Disregard the temperature fluctuations then,” Anaxa - the real one, the one that he hadn’t killed yet - said, forcefully. “There are other indications. With your coreflame usage and what I’ve observed of your wings, it’s not feasible for it to have been that small a number. It doesn’t fit with the math __”

“Have you considered,” Phainon said, thickly, “that maybe your math is just *wrong?”*

The words were torn from his throat before Phainon could really think them over. Thick. Warm. Tingling against his tongue alongside the beginning of blossoming irritation. When he tried to push it down alongside all the rest, it sprung back - indignant - even more inflated than before. It was like someone was shovelling coal into his chest, throwing dying embers and lit matches alongside it, encouraging the burn.

It didn’t make sense. The suddenness of it all was enough to stagger him. Wasn’t anger supposed to build more slowly? Curated over a long time, the fire tended to over eons, flame stoked bit by bit?

This was more like a flash flood. It seemed as if it had come out of nowhere.

“If it had only been one equation faltering I would consider it.” Anaxa said. Which was even more infuriating because what kind of person assumed they were only capable of being wrong *once?* “But there are multiple factors pointing to this theory being the truth. We already determined that

one would expect more than thirty-three of Orynyx's coreflames to be able to—"

"—And now you're an expert on *Orynyx's* coreflame too? How do you even have a frame of reference for what each coreflame should be capable of? That's— That's *ridiculous—"*

"Would you *quit* interrupting me?" Anaxa snapped. "Getting defensive only proves my point further, Phainon. I have a frame of reference from when the Trailblazer inherited the coreflame in the previous cycle. Now. If you'd simply *listen,* I'd explain that it's not just these two things that act as indicators."

Phainon's breathing was a fast thing. His eyes narrowed on one of the not-there corpses. They— *it*— was *smirking* at him. As if to say *'you've lost this debate, Khaslana. What, you thought you could win?'*

"Unless you are lying about the previous size of your wings - which I presume you were *not*, for there is little reason to lie when time will have them regrow back to a similar length - then they would be too large a container for a mere 'four hundred coreflames'. You would need to hold more."

The anger in his chest was beginning to boil. It was as if, in pausing the burn of his wings, he'd set the rest of himself alight. His chest ached. Familiar rage trickling in, making itself at home as if it'd never truly left. Just momentarily disguised itself as something weak and less predatory.

Why was he feeling so strongly about this?

This was Anaxa - of all people, he was the one most likely to approach the truth. He was the smartest person that Phainon had ever met. He always figured out the truth, eventually. The truth of the world. The truth of the Flame Reaver. The truth of… of *everything.*

And it wasn't even as if he was all that attached to this particular lie, *anyway.* It'd been an accidental thing. Stelle wasn't going to let him keep it forever.

…Maybe it was because it’d been billions of years and Anaxa had never *once* let things go. Couldn’t he have just dropped it, this time? Let Phainon rest and tell them the truth on his own?

Couldn’t he just let Phainon keep this lie of his for a little while longer? He hadn’t even had it for a *week.*

“And how would you determine how much space a coreflame takes up?” He challenged, because… well, in this regard, he and the professor were quite alike. Phainon wasn’t very good at letting things go either. “These wings are the *perfect* container, no matter the number. Flame spreads, professor. It fills whatever container you put it in.”

Anaxa crossed his arms. “I’ve possessed coreflames of my own, Phainon. I know their dimensions. Four hundred flames in *that* large of a wingspan? They wouldn’t burn with nearly as bright a flame as what we witnessed earlier.”

Something cold was collecting in Phainon’s eyes.

His gaze flicked up to the professor - ha, he was flaking away like he always did upon ripping the coreflame from his chest and disintegrating upon the wind - and ground his teeth together. Gnashing things, something wild was prowling inside of his veins, begging for release. He wanted to blame it on the Destruction’s influence but this, he knew, was all *him.*

(Beside him, Mydei’s golden gaze had shuttered. Realisation had caught him in its tight grip. From his heavy stare, it was clear that— if asked— he would take the professor’s side in a heartbeat. Something in the back of his head *snarled* at the betrayal he felt over the idea of the prince taking anyone else’s side but *his.)*

Phainon’s fingers twitched as if reaching for his sword. Muscle memory preparing to solve the problem in the only way he knew how.

Maybe it should’ve been sickening, the realisation that - after billions of years - his first instinct was murder. Maybe it should’ve rattled him.

It didn’t.

It just made the rage filling his chest burn even brighter - a supernova that was cracking at the edges of his skin, of his consciousness, of his very *being.*

Phainon was so sick of his own mind. Of the anger and exhaustion. Of all of the *hate.*

“Fine,” he said, finally. “How many coreflames would I need to have?”

His voice was dull. Though the bite had not faded, though his words were saturated, it was less explosive. Colder now - in the way that fire confused the senses when its heat had reached a level that nerves could no longer process.

“...Excuse me?”

“How many of Orynyx’s coreflames would I need,” Phainon said, frost catching on each syllable like sharp fragments of glass. It sliced sharp as a needle. “In order to pause time on my wings. How many?”

Both Chrysos Heirs were staring at him.

Of course they were. Phainon had all but confessed to them. This was the closest one got without actually saying that he’d lied, wasn’t it? Why they seemed surprised was beyond him - this was what Anaxa had pushed for. Phainon had been trying to *protect* them, to spare them the pain of the truth, but what did he care?

He’d been willing to tell them the number of cycles in the beginning until *they’d* gotten upset over such a miniscule number. If they wanted to force him to increase that number, then fine. That was on them. They could impale themselves on the truth of something larger if they really wanted to. Who was he to stop them?

“Well?” He pressed.

Professor Anaxa looked less resolute now. Less determined. Having the truth confirmed had allowed for something wary to catch in his eye.

Apparently that weariness didn't breed hesitation, though. He said, "Hundreds for the initial pause. To keep time paused for as long as you currently have though, without any visible struggle, it would take thousands."

Fine.

Fucking. *Fine.*

Phainon threw his hands into the air and said, "Thousands! Alright. Thirty-three hundred cycles then. That's how many cycles it's been. Does that fit with your math?"

Mydei, wide-eyed, lifted a hand and pushed the Professor back. He said, "Deliverer—"

Something ugly and violent caught in the back of Phainon's throat. It tasted of blood and *ash* and millions of shattered dreams.

"*Don't,*" he spat. "Don't call me that."

"I—" Mydei's brows raised. Almost infuriatingly, he lifted his arms, almost as if placating some wild beast. Phainon would show *him* wild. His teeth ground together with enough force that he wouldn't have been surprised if his jaw cracked from the aftershock. "Sorry. *Phainon."*

Oh. This was Mydei trying to calm him down, wasn't it? Well, *tough shit*. He didn't *want* to be calm. He wanted to burn like he always had, to fall into the sweet release of his anger and let it carry him through into tomorrow. Every other part of himself was something that he was carrying for others - this anger was the only thing that was *his*.

"No," Phainon snapped. "I'm not done. He hasn't answered if it's enough yet. Right?"

His gaze fell back onto Anaxa. His body was glitching so much between real-unreal, dead-alive, smirking and afraid, that it was difficult to tell what the true Anaxa currently looked like.

“Tell me,” he continued, “is three thousand cycles worth of coreflames enough to fill these wings of mine? Or is that number too small? *You* tell *me,* Professor. *You’re* the expert here.”

Around him, Phainon could feel something cracking. Probably time. Maybe his own mind. He didn’t care. Let it do so. What did it *matter?*

Anaxa said, “...I would expect the number to be even higher. Tens of thousands.”

Bitterness caught in Phainon’s chest. Swollen, like a festering wound that had been infected by years and years worth of self-flagellation.

He laughed. Sharp. Harsh. The edges of it distorted. His mind was *melting.* “Fine. Thirty thousand then. Does that work for you? Does that fit the narrative of your equations?”

Anaxa opened his mouth but no words came out.

Ha. *Haha.* So even the great *Professor Anaxagoras* could be stunned into silence, huh? He’d been through millions of cycles but this? This was *new.* Anaxa *always* had something to say.

Did that mean that it was finally Phainon’s turn? To say something and not have to be so fucking *polite* about it all the time?

Maybe it was.

The words bubbled from his throat against his will. A fresh, burning sludge formed from years of silence and trauma, from buried rage and having reached the edge of sanity time and time again.

“You know Professor,” he snapped, “you’re not nearly as smart as you think you are. Maybe if you were, you’d have actually survived at least *one* time.

You would think that at least *once* in all of these cycles a certified genius such as yourself would have managed to keep himself alive?”

Breathless, he tried to catch his breath but it was impossible - the words continued. Phainon couldn’t bring himself to stop even to *breathe.*

“But *no.* All of your math and equations and theories, it never factored in survival, did it? I mean, why would they? Your theories only ever focus on subjects that are *utterly inconsequential*. Titans? The Era Nova? Who even *cares* about any of that? You’re seriously—”

“*Phainon,”* Mydei said, cutting through the words with a chill so deep that it caught hold of his words and froze them in place.

Phainon cast his gaze from the heavily glitching Anaxa and let it settle on Mydei. He was still pushing Anaxa back, step by step, widening the gap between them and *him.*

A corroded, glitching version of Dawnbreaker burst free from his ribcage.

He couldn’t stop the laugh that caught in his throat. Nor the rage that now found itself focused on the Kremnoan.

“And *you,”* he snapped, because now he really *couldn*’t stop. If he didn’t keep speaking, he was going to tear Dawnbreak free from unreality and do something that couldn’t be reversed. “Mydei. Don’t get me started on *you.* Ha. Mydeimos the Undying. What a false title that is. If you were *truly* immortal, you’d have come *back.* You’d have made it to the end too. It’s pathetic. You’re path—”

Time cracked in full.

One moment, he was trembling with rage and shivering from the cold of suppressed flames.

The next, his wings reared with a blazing inferno. Flame licked at his skin, at the grass around him, at his clothes. It burned *everything.* His clothes, the grass, his own *hallucinations* - even clumps of dirt were sizzling away into

cinders. Behind him the river erupted with steam, like a volcano ready to erupt.

Mydei yanked Anaxa into his arms and threw the pair of them back. *Away*. Flame caught the edges of their clothes, their hair, but past being slightly singed they were relatively untouched.

Phainon heaved in a long breath. It rattled against his lungs. This fury that had raised its head and now ran rampant in his blood was an ancient thing. Transformed from grief, he'd been holding it longer than the universe had drawn breath. It was eternal. The deadliest thing that lived between the curl of his ribs.

…Ha.

Haha.

He hated them. Mydei. Anaxa. His fellow heirs. Okhema. Amphoreus. All of the people that lived within the planet's atmosphere. He *loathed them.* For all the dreams they'd placed on his shoulders. For the title they'd forced him to bear, over and *over and over,* without any promise of release.

Hated how easily they died.

Despised them for the fact that his mind could replay the stuttering melody of every final breath, every failing heartbeat.

Loathed them for every set of final words they'd ever given him.

Detested the fact that even now, in what was meant to be an era of *peace*, he still couldn't protect them from anything. From the truth. From *himself*.

…Hated how after everything, after *33 million cycles* of suffering, they were still the most precious of people. That he still wanted to carry everything so that they'd never have to. That even while he burned, he wanted to plunge himself into ice so that when he held them in his arms, they would not burn with him.

He hated Amphoreus and cherished it. He loved his friends and, simultaneously, wanted them dead.

Grief caught in Phainon's throat. Tears evaporated before he could summon the strength to cry. In the absence of a sob, he *laughed*, because it wasn't *fair.* It was meant to be *over* and it wasn't. He was meant to be fine but how could he ever be, after *everything?*

It took Mydei pulling himself and Anaxa to their feet for the haze of flame and rage to settle enough for him to think.

"I—" His breaths shook with the weight of momentary restraint. "I—I'm sorry. I shouldn't have—"

Nope. Even trying to talk was fraying the edges of his mind.

He met Mydei's gaze. He was watching Phainon as if he were going to shatter. Ha. That was laughable. Out of all of them, he was the least breakable. The Kremnoan let out a shaky breath and opened his mouth—

—And Phainon lifted a hand, pulled on every single one of Orynyx's coreflames at his disposal and trapped his fellow Chrysos Heirs in time before any words could break the silence.

Staying here wasn't an option. He couldn't *be* here. If he stayed…

No. He couldn't think of what he'd do if he stayed.

So instead of thinking about it, he *moved.* He curled Janus' coreflames around his fingertips, summoned an infinity gate and fled from his friends.

Chapter End Notes

> phainon: i wonder where all this rage has come from. it all seems kind of sudden.
> also phainon: has been suppressing all the anger and irritation any time it's shown up in the previous eight chapters.

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

:))

Chapter Notes

Iny drew an *amazing* comic of Phainon's crash-out last chapter. Like. My god, my guy. I am still in awe. I keep going back and looking at it because I'm in love with the way Phainon is illustrated??

Now that we're on chapter 10 - I want to say thanks to everyone for all the comments and kudos. I typically try to respond to all comments but y'all are treating me so much and I'm struggling to keep up ahaha. If I miss your comment in my replies, then I'm sorry, but I definitely appreciate each and everyone. Thank you all for enjoying my little au!!

(Oh, also, I've updated the tags a little. Not much, but you know. Ye.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The infinity gate spat him out into the decaying remains of the village that had birthed him.

For a moment, Phainon simply hovered above what remained of Aedes Elysiae. Suspended in space, his gaze snagged on crumbling buildings and half-collapsed barns. Thick vines of ivy had attempted to reclaim the buildings to no avail - they'd long since withered alongside the village that had always been destined to die. Then quivering wings drooped, unable to keep him held above the destruction, and Phainon was dropped down onto scorched earth.

It was dry and coarse against his toes - sizzling beneath his feet as lifeless soil ruptured into ash.

There had been a time when the thought of Aedes Elysiae would have halted his anger; When it had offered a sense of peace, past an initial wave of grief and loneliness. But that had been whenever he thought of *before.* Of back when it had stood, when it had lived and breathed.

Seeing this version of home, knowing that both his own and Cyrene's foggy recollection of the life that had come before was not enough to reform it into something alive, that there were simply too *many* memories of a destroyed Aedes Elysiae to ever bring it back to what it had once been, only managed to stoked the rage in his chest.

His flames reached a temperature so high that his skin was beginning to sit *wrong* around his bones. Tight. Malleable. His flesh was incandescent with molted gold - less like he was a person and more like a half-forged weapon awaiting the strike of a hammer.

Trembling, Phainon managed two steps closer to what remained of the village. It was as close as he could allow himself before he was forced to admit that, currently, the task of entering was impossible. Physically, his body resisted each step, working against him and the rage that this place wrought within him. Mentally, he just *couldn't.* He could see people burning at the edge of his vision, could hear their screams, but he couldn't get closer because they weren't *his* to save.

Exhaustion caught in his chest, cracking it open. His mind swam through a tide of light-headedness and glitching memories.

A snarl caught in his throat; Even his body was trying to temper him. Clearly it had not received the memo that Phainon wasn't willing to douse this flame just yet. If this current form of his was unwilling to let him burn and *burn* then he'd force himself into another that would.

Lifting a hand to his chest, he dug nails into flesh and *tore.* Flame poured free from the tear, speckled with sizzling drops of ichor. The surrounding skin charred, blackening like hardened ash, forming a chrysalis for his transformation into a divine form.

Coreflame crystallised, wrapping him in a sphere of gold as his transformation progressed. They burned against his hands, blistering the skin in black and gold. Coreflame tore through the stitches of muscle, jagged deposits bursting from his shoulders with such violence that it hitched his breath.

Divinity leaked out of the cracks in his chest. Burning. *Soaring.* The temperature of it crackled the air, condensing it like a half-drawn breath held over eternity. It washed over him, staining him with the poison of destruction, seeping into every part of his being. Into the sun tattoo that now burned like a brand. Into his eyes, unseeing but for the glint of promised - ~~revenge~~ - *salvation* on the horizon.

It even filtered into his blood, singing its shrill song, harmonising with all of his hatred and his rage.

Sound burst free from a burning throat. Guttural and filled with wrath. Not a yell, or a shout, but something that could not truly be described. A sound unlike any other, it wasn't something that should have been formed by human vocal chords. It had reached abyssal depths of despair, broken and distorted.

Phainon's legs buckled beneath him and his knees crashed into ash.

The earth trembled beneath the weight of his anger. When curled fingers dug into ashen soil, it quaked alongside his trembling hands. When he screamed, unable to keep the broil of his hostility inside of his chest, the ground split, cavernous, reaching deep into Amphoreus' core.

It wasn't fair.

Above him, the sky responded to his own volatility as if his rage was its own. The atmosphere splintered under the weight of its oncoming storm. Thunder resonated with the heavy pound of his pulse, lightning striking out at everything in the vicinity that the blazing inferno of his divinity had left untouched.

It had never been *fair.*

At the further edges of the village, gentle waters grew tumultuous. Waves crashed against the edges of a rotten pier, consuming decayed slabs of wood, swallowing half-standing structures and dragging them into the depths of sea.

He'd just wanted to *help.* To protect everything he held dear. To keep everything from falling apart for just a little bit longer. Why weren't they letting him? Why did they always—

Space rippled around him. Distorted. It did not quite sit the way that space should. Heavy, the sky pulled down, squishing the atmosphere as if pressing on a sponge. Infinity gates opened, and closed, *opened, closed.* Fragmented passages leading to nowhere and everywhere. Into endless blazes and hungry stars. Into spaces encased with death, with trickery, with *strife.* Fractals of impossible dimensions, ripped open with golden thread and sewn back together just as quickly, only with uneven stitches that left reality an uncanny appropriation of what it should have been.

Phainon heaved in gasping breaths. With each one, the space filled around him.

His friends had come for him.

Bleeding, decaying things but they had come. Aglaea, stitched with gold, lifeless but for the strings that walked her closer like the puppet she was. Tribbie, fracturing over and *over,* like she always did, reaching out with a smile and the promise of tomorrow.

Anaxa, trying to step closer but disintegrating further with every breath of storm around them. Castorice, skeletal and never quite there - just smiling as time ground bone to dust. Cipher, always just outside of view, only visible in his peripherals, constantly moving even despite all of the holes stamped into her body. Hyacine, reaching out, always reaching out, even as her body *burned*.

All of them with thousands and thousands of duplicates. Thousands piling up around him, weighing down on his shoulders, adding to the weight of

deliverance. Various deaths, all of them the result of his action. Of his *hatred*.

Phainon felt something bump against his skin, and there he was. Just the one copy, considering the fact that he *always* died in the same way.

Mydeimos the undying, glassy-eyed, lying face down in the ash. Dawnbreaker sticking out of his back as if a natural fixture to his body. Blood pooling around his torso. Staining his hair, his face, his hands, his—

Phainon's lips trembled. Something caught in his throat and he wasn't sure what it was. He reached for the false Mydei's hand, lying limp at his side, and pulled on it so that the corpse was half in his lap, half collapsed on the earth before him.

"Tell me, Mydei," he murmured, rage giving way - momentarily - to pain that wracked his very core. He pressed Mydei's hand against his cheek and let his eyelids shutter. "Is there still any tenderness left in my eyes?"

No response.

Of course there wasn't.

The only answer that Phainon received was the way Mydei's glitching body began to crumble into ones and zeroes. It would've been kinder if he'd been reduced to ash - at least, then, Phainon could've convinced himself that Mydei had once been *real*. Instead—

Instead, Phainon curled now-empty hands around clumps of hair and *screamed*.

And around him, whatever remained of Aedes Elysiae ceased to exist.

—

Eventually, the rage plateaued.

Not for lack of a spark, but because even this divine vessel was unable to sustain itself against the heavy weight of exhaustion weighing down on him. His anger remained, though now it was an unconscious thing. The coreflames took hold of it and acted in his stead. A flicker of flame wrapped around his shoulders like a blanket. It pressed against drooping eyelids and promised to continue burning in his stead while he rested.

Emotionally drained, but for the rage that would never cease, Phainon closed his eyes.

He slept.

At the edge of his consciousness, he could feel the extended burn of his divinity reacting to his emotional state since his mind was not present to guide it. The sky wept tears of rage and continued with its tempest. The earth shook, manic laughter as it split itself, as it remoulded the landscape and began tearing itself apart once more. Even space continued to contort. Misshapen, it wrestled with itself, trying to make sense of its new reality.

Each time he opened his eyes, fatigue reared its head and stared at him.

Phainon could not see the point in refusing it any longer. Suspended in what looked like the end of the world, he simply closed his eyes and leaned into the collapse.

It was difficult to know how long it took for the exhaustion to claim the coreflames as well. But eventually, even they too began to tire.

First, space began to unfurl. Gates closed. What was compressed began to ease, the pressure lifting slowly. The quaking earth’s trembling became soft shakes. And then, they ceased all together. The unruly waters of Aedes Elysiae returned to the same peaceful ebb and flow that remained in half-faded memories.

The rain lightened. The storm settled.

And with a gentle caress of wind, the remaining traces of grey were nudged from sight and the skies of Aedes Elysiae cleared.

Phainon woke to the warmth of sunlight against his cheek and the scratch of fabric across his back.

…Fabric?

Even after this extended period of rest, Phainon's body still felt heavy. It resisted movement. Even lifting his arm to tug on the fabric felt like a large undertaking.

Pulling it from his body, he was surprised to find that it was a blanket. It felt like wool, but as tired eyes tried to comprehend its sudden existence, he could see that it was more than that. The memory of wool. A blanket stitched from memoria. It was slightly singed but clearly capable of withstanding the heat of Phainon's wings.

For a moment, all he could do was stare at it.

Then, Phainon wrapped it around his shoulders and burrowed into its warmth. He closed his eyes, not for the sake of rest, but for the sake of bathing in the quiet comfort of something soft and gentle.

When he convinced himself that he should open them again and take in his new surroundings, Phainon was met with a desolate wasteland. Everything was ash. Though the earth had reshaped into something jagged and violent, there was little around but rock and cinders.

Mostly.

Because several feet away, there was a bag. It was an old, fraying thing. Well-loved. Most likely waiting for *him*.

Wariness caught in his chest.

And curiosity.

His legs shook with each step. By the time he dropped to his knees before the bag, the entirety of his body was trembling. He pulled the blanket closer around his body and just… looked at it. It wasn't anything special - simple

fabric, neutral colouring. The handle was torn at the edges and the threadwork had clearly been loosened under a lifetime of strain.

Someone had loved this to its end. And now it was… here. Waiting for him to find it. To *open* it.

So he did.

It was not filled with much. A bottle of water. Two rolls of bread, wrapped in brown paper to keep them from growing stale. A yellow chiton, its bright colouring vaguely familiar. A recognisable pair of purple trousers. A teleslate. And lastly, a folded piece of scrap parchment.

Hesitant, he unfolded it.

The writing was both familiar and unfamiliar. Something he had once known as well as his own, and yet, over time, had began to forget.

Phai,

A care package for you. I hope you slept without nightmares. If you need anything - you always know where, in this place, I'll be. Take your time, my dearest friend, and rest well.

He stared at the words for a long time. Reminded himself to breathe. Closed his eyes and held the note as closely to his chest as he held the blanket.

And when his breathing began to even out, Phainon stood.

Because the note was right - he knew where she would be, and he was not so cruel as to force Cyrene to wait for him any longer than she already had.

Chapter End Notes

next time: a meeting in what was once aedes elysiae

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

> a meeting in what was once Aedes Elysiae

Chapter Notes

> look, phainon and cyrene - to me - are so sibling coded. they love each other so much. i adore them. i want to hug them both and squeeze them and never let go.

Back before they had been forced to watch Aedes Elysiae die, there had only ever been one place that Phainon had needed to search if he'd wanted to find Cyrene: The pond west of the Sacrament Courtyard.

She - and subsequently Phainon himself - had spent so many hours playing in the water and climbing the nearby trees that their parents had decided to spruce the place up for them both. Cyrene's father had fixed up some old chairs and a table so that they could always draw and write stories within the shade cast by their favourite tree. Phainon's father, Hieronymus, had climbed up onto the thickest branch, armed with several pieces of rope and tied thick knots around it, using the branch to hold the large swing that he'd carved from leftover wood that had been lying around ever since he'd fixed the hole in their leaking roof.

They had spent their early childhood swinging on it. When they'd been little, it had been big enough for the both of them to sit on, shoulder to shoulder, with plenty of leftover space. As they'd grown, however, it had become *Cyrene's* swing. She spent more time patiently swinging, while Phainon - filled with energy and the endless need to tire himself out - had raced through the village and trained his swordsmanship skills.

Whenever she was not busy, she was always there. Swinging. Or writing in her book and designing more oracle cards for her divinations. *Or* sitting at

the edge of the water, feet submerged, simply enjoying the sunlight that slowly baked them in the oven of summer.

The tree supporting her swing had long since burned down. The table and chairs had decayed - though whether by his hand in this era or the last, he wasn't sure. Nothing remained but murky water and large deposits of grey ash.

And, of course, Cyrene herself.

She was knelt at the edge of the water, one hand pressed against the earth to keep her balance, the other reaching out into the pond. At first, it was difficult to see what she was doing. It wasn't until Phainon shuffled closer that he could make out the fact that she'd fashioned a net out of ice and was now scooping debris from the water's surface.

For a moment, it was too much to simply look at her.

Phainon closed his eyes and pulled the blanket tighter around his shoulders. The earth trembled gently beneath his feet - a minor quake rippling in response to his discomfort.

Cyrene paused.

Then, she turned to face him.

There was no freeze in her expression. No uncertainty. From the second she spotted him, her gaze softened and a warm smile spread across her lips. There was ash in her hair and she looked exhausted, but upon seeing him, there was nothing but clear relief and affection.

"Hey Phai," she said, without even an inkling of hesitation. "Did you sleep well?"

He stepped closer. Not because he particularly wanted to but because he wasn't sure whether he'd be able to speak loudly without the words scraping against his throat. A fist clenched the handles of the bag Cyrene

had left with such force that Phainon was surprised it wasn't merging with his skin.

Had he slept well? Doubtful. All he could really say was that he *had* slept. There wasn't much more to it than that. Well? Poorly? Who cared?

"What are you doing?" He asked.

Cyrene shifted as he made his way closer - not in an attempt to get away, or closer, but simply to allow him the space to settle near this pond without being forced to climb over the many sharp deposits of razored stone that now encased the water. She said, "Filtering the pond."

Ah.

His fault.

She was stuck trying to undo the mess that he had caused. Phainon had only caused trouble for her in the aftermath of what could only be labelled a tantrum. His foot paused, midair, freezing as if *he* were the one with an affinity for ice.

This time, the tremble of earth beneath them was enough to stagger him. He tripped, displacing a pile of dust that caught in his chest and left him wheezing around heavy coughs.

Cyrene's hand pressed into the ground. Half-lifting to her feet, she began to stand—

"Don't." He gasped, frantic.

She halted. "Phainon—"

Despite himself, he raised a hand and shooed her away. "Just… Just stay there. I don't…" He shook his head, trying to speak around his coughs. "Just stay there. Please."

Cyrene's smile had dropped. Concern had trickled into the gaps of her furrowed brows and though he could see that she wanted to argue with him,

she slowly lowered back onto her knees. Soft, her voice only a whisper on the wind, she murmured, “Alright. I’ll stay here.”

He didn’t thank her. Just tried to dislodge ash from his chest and settle his rapidly beating heart.

“There’s water in the bag,” Cyrene said, as his hacking continued. “It’ll help.”

He tore into the bag and grabbed the bottle, uncapping the lid and drinking in long gulps. She was right. It helped. Though his throat remained raw, the splash of water helped soothe the ache like a balm.

They fell into silence.

Tucking his knees close to his chest, Phainon pulled the blanket around his body even tighter. It would be impossible, he knew, to hide behind it entirely but the idea of being able to hide even a *little* helped to settle some of his… rising panic? He wasn’t sure what this tightness in his chest was.

Cyrene’s gaze flicked between him and the blanket. Then, watchful eyes flicked away completely. Gaze averted. A quiet kindness that she had not spoken of, and yet Phainon had identified almost immediately. She’d realised he couldn’t handle her attention, and thus, had removed it.

His shoulders loosened. Strange… he hadn’t realised that they had ever tensed. When had they done that? Maybe when he’d woken… Or when he had opened the bag and found Cyrene’s note hidden inside?

Or had it maybe been when he’d seen her outline and realised that he’d ruined yet another thing for a person he loved— and despised— so deeply?

“Are the clothes I left you alright?” She asked. Perhaps, even without looking at him, she’d identified that his thoughts were beginning to rise like a tidal wave, prepared to pull him under and deemed him in urgent need of distraction. “I thought you might be warmer with them too. Mixed with the blanket, you’ll be nice and toasty.”

The clothes? …What clothes?

Oh. *Right*. The clothes that had been included in her care package. Bright yellow and deep purple. An outfit that Aglaea would've hated. *Had* hated. Cycle after cycle. Whenever she had seen him show up in such clothing the seamstress had declared him an affront to fashion and decided there and then to sew him a whole new wardrobe.

In this, the goldweaver had seen fit to declare war against his poor fashion choices.

"I thought…" He frowned. "...Aglaea threw them out. Didn't she?"

"Well, not these ones, no." Cyrene said, moving her hands so that they rested in her lap. "They're not the same clothes you wore in the past. But.. they're pretty close to it, I think? I'm pretty sure they should be your size. They might be a little big, if anything."

Absently, he pulled out the purple-stained trousers. The fabric was not quite as soft as the blanket around him, but they weren't coarse either. A little worn. Not brand new. A thumb-sized tear in the leg had been messily stitched back together.

That they weren't brand new was a relief. And yet, he couldn't help but feel guilty to receive them regardless. This… wasn't something he could accept. It didn't fit the image that he'd been forced to uphold for millenia.

"I can't wear this," he said, bitterly. Behind him, his wings flared at the realisation that this was a kindness that he was not supposed to accept. For *Okhema's* sake. "They're not the kind of thing you'd expect an upstanding *Chrysos Heir* to wear."

Objectively, he knew why Aglaea had always taken these clothes away from him. There was an image he'd had to uphold and haphazard, second-hand clothing wasn't a part of that. Pristine white was better for the cause - unmarred by the black tide, untouchable and *clean.* Gold because it symbolised both the flame chase and his allegiance to the goldweaver. Blue because… well, because it looked *good*.

Even knowing all this, it was hard not to be angry that he'd not even been allowed to keep *this* part of his identity. No room for individuality of this kind in any of the flame chase journeys. No joy to be allowed in bright, contrasting colour schemes.

Not that is mattered, anymore. It was difficult to be anything *but* that perfectly curated role. A fake deliverer not only by prophecy but in costume and personality as well.

Cyrene let out a loud, somewhat overtly dramatic hum. More like she was trying to capture his attention than because she'd seen any *actual* point in humming.

Phainon glanced up from the trousers and waited.

"Phai," she said, once she was certain she held his focus. "Do you still like brightly coloured things?"

…Did he?

Phainon wasn't sure. He hadn't thought about it in… a truly long time. He'd always been stoking his rage and that had meant bathing in hate and reminding himself of everything he *loathed*. Focusing on things that he liked would've been counterproductive. Somewhere within the cycles he'd started to forget any of the details that humanised himself.

Did he like bright colours? Well, he didn't *hate* them. Was that the same thing? He didn't know.

"I don't…" His brows dipped, the beginning of stress curling his shoulders. "...really remember."

Cyrene lifted a hand to her cheek. As she always did when thinking deeply over something she thought was of great importance, she tapped the pads of her fingers against her cheek. As a child, she'd said it was to stimulate her thoughts. As an adult, she stuck by the same words, though they both knew it was just a habit with no further meaning.

“Alright,” she said. “Let’s start a little smaller, then. Do you want to wear these? Or would you prefer it if I collected something from your current wardrobe?”

“Aglaea—”

“—Isn’t here,” Cyrene said, both firm and gentle. “It’s just us. What do *you* want to do?”

Phainon reached into the bag and pulled out the chiton. He stared at fabric that looked like it’d bathed in sunlight until it’d absorbed the colour into each thread. It was old, and yet, it looked like the colour had never once dared to fade.

From yellow chiton, to purple pants. He looked between each as if Cyrene had asked the world of him. Had asked him to solve some intangible problem that was incomprehensible, impossible to even *begin* solving.

He closed his eyes. Breathed in deeply and held the air in his lungs. Which option would he hate less? The options left him feeling both exhausted and... and *strange*, so it was just a matter of choosing the least uncomfortable option.

He breathed out a sigh. Ran his fingers across old seams and steeled himself.

Then, he made a decision.

One that did not regard deliverance, or the fate of Amphoreus, but rather something that solely regarded *himself.* Who *he* was.

“...I still like bright colours,” he decided. Hesitant, yet also tinged with the finality of someone who had just stumbled upon one of the truths of their own being.

When he opened his eyes again, Cyrene was grinning. Unabashed, her expression was as warm as moonlight. Gentle in much the same way as the blanket around him felt.

“Then,” she said, “I’ll close my eyes and you can go put those on, alright?”

“I—”

“*Unless,”* Cyrene continued, grin widening, “we want to go find something even *brighter.”*

His lips quirked for half of a moment, before falling flat. He shook his head. No. These would be fine.

“Or,” Cyrene continued, “you can just stay wrapped up in the blanket. That’s an option as well. It’s up to you.”

Phainon let out a half-sigh.

It shouldn’t have been this hard to salvage parts of himself, his own wants, but here he was, clearly struggling. It was exhausting. He’d just slept for… however long he’d slept, and he’d only managed to wake more tired than when he’d fallen asleep.

Another sigh. It was a full thing, now.

“I’ll wear them," he said. "Close your eyes.”

He reverted back into a more human form and got changed.

If he tried to don them while still wearing this divine form, the clothes would simply melt from his skin like butter against flame. After all, unlike the blanket, this new outfit wasn’t reinforced with memoria.

Once dressed - his wings tucked away for another day, the coreflames stored away and now much less reactive to his emotions - he padded back towards Cyrene, wearing the blanket around him like a shield.

The trousers were too short on his legs. The fabric of the chiton was loose around the biceps. Phainon probably looked *ridiculous*.

Yet, this outfit felt a million times more comfortable than the clinical clothing of Amphoreus' 'Deliverer'.

"So," Phainon said, quietly, as he returned to her side. He hesitated several steps away, unsure whether he could force himself closer. "What now?"

"Hm?" Cyrene tilted her head towards him, half opening her eyes.

"You didn't come all this way to bring me clothes and ask what colours I like," Phainon said. "So… what next?"

She didn't say anything, not at first. Instead, Cyrene patted the earth beside her, a mushroom cloud of dust and ash whooshing into the air at the movement.

Phainon squinted at the ground as if it was going to morph into a horrifying beast. .

Then, reluctance showing in the heavy dragging of his feet, he sat beside her. His knees were pulled close to his chest, arms wrapped around them protectively. Resting his chin on his knees, he stared out at stagnant water. He could see physical *clumps* of ash floating atop it like a film. Either the clumps hadn't been in the water long enough to settle, or the pond was simply *that* full of waste that it could not be poisoned any further.

"That depends on you, really," Cyrene said. "I'm not going to ask if you don't want me to."

He didn't.

Since he'd been awake, his mind - while scraped raw from the weight of his own rage and grief - had been wrapped inside of what he could only describe as a *bubble*. Trapped inside, everything felt… distant. Far away.

He could feel the heat of his own rage, but there was a disconnect. Though he knew it was there, it was as if his connection to it had been halted, momentarily. All he felt now, was *tired.* Worn.

If he talked about it, then he'd burst the bubble and everything would come crashing back. Later he would ask. Later he would learn everything he could about what had happened while he'd slept and explain what had happened on *his* side, but right now…

"Don't ask me about it," Phainon mumbled.

"Alright," Cyrene said, "I won't."

Hesitant, she lowered her head onto his shoulder. Together, they stared at what remained of their home, a landscape that was as unwelcoming as every one of their previous experiences. They lapsed into a silence that was only interrupted by a docile breeze.

An age later, Phainon tilted his head and let it rest against Cyrene's. He closed his eyes.

"What are you thinking about?" Cyrene asked him.

Honestly… not much. His thoughts remained as thick as syrup. They all existed outside of this bubble of dissociation. Currently, the only thing he could think of was how thoroughly *drained* he felt.

Not just physically, but mentally.

"...I'm so tired," he murmured.

Cyrene reached for his hand. Clasped their fingers together and admitted, in a voice far more serious than he'd have expected from her, "Me too."

"It was too much to bear," Phainon continued.

"It was," she agreed.

When he sighed, it was just as light as the breeze around them. A whisper against the wind. She squeezed his hand, and he— after some hesitation— squeezed back.

More silence.

“I just want to rest,” Phainon admitted.

Another hand squeeze. “Then let's go back. You can climb into bed, and I’ll keep guard over your room to make sure no one disturbs you.”

He wasn’t sure whether he was ready to leave this place yet. To return to Okhema and face his fellow Heirs. To face his *friends* and the questions they no doubt held for him.

“Cyrene?” He murmured.

“Yes?”

“...You don’t need to guard my room.” Her hold on his hand loosened, as if to pull away. He tightened his own hold so that she couldn’t let go. “But… Can you stay for a while? I don’t…”

He couldn’t get the words out. That she’d offered him the first semblance of choice, of *comfort,* that he’d felt he was *able* to take in millenia. That he wasn’t willing to let that disappear just yet.

“I’ll stay,” Cyrene promised.

Breath rushed from his lungs with heavy relief.

“Well then,” she continued, voice no louder than a whisper. “Should we go home?”

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

> phainon and cyrene return to okhema. they rest. they talk. there are glitches.

Chapter Notes

> maaan, i wanted to get this out sooner but i was struck with a bunch of fatigue this week. work really has a way of draining you out, huh? or well, it does to me. anyway, i hope you all enjoy!! i like this chapter a lot, actually.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the end, their return to Okhema was quite underwhelming.

After a final, solemn farewell to the empty space of Aedes Elysiae, Phainon rid space of any remaining crinkles and proceeded to open an infinity gate that led to his Okheman quarters.

Through the gate, his room was exactly as he'd left it: Closed curtains. The space dimly lit and leaving the room dull and lifeless. Dust had yet to settle but even still the room looked stifling and aged - the only sign of life being that of his unmade duvet, thrown over his mattress with little care of whether the bed was properly made or not.

Phainon tightened his hold on Cyrene's hand and stepped through the gate.

When the gate closed behind them both, Phainon's room became much darker. Little light settled around them and the only thing that Phainon could see clearly was the mattress. It beckoned him closer like an old friend.

Phainon shuffled forwards. Didn't even lift his feet properly as he moved, weighed down by exhaustion as they were.

When he reached the mattress, he collapsed onto it, surrendering himself to gravity.

Cyrene, still holding his hand, was pulled along with him. She yelped, weight falling entirely onto Phainon, who let out a loud grunt as his breath caught in his throat. He face planted his pillow at force. Cyrene's elbow split his side with such force that he gasped.

For a moment, they both existed in silence. Cyrene, blinking at the wall as if trying to process what had just happened. Phainon, trying to catch his breath.

Then, Cyrene broke into a breathless set of giggles.

Phainon didn't laugh but his lips twitched with the beginning of something that could one day evolve into a smile.

"Some warning next time, please?"

Yeah, maybe. He was definitely going to have an elbow-shaped bruise across his ribs. *And* a Cyrene-shaped bruise on his back.

"Mmph," he breathed into his pillow, closing his eyes.

"Are you alright?"

Another *'mmph'* into his pillow.

"No clue what that means," Cyrene continued, lying beside him. Then, she began wriggling, trying to settle comfortably. A task made more difficult by the fact that her hand was currently being held prisoner by Phainon's own. The position she settled on was an awkward thing - jutting his elbow out at an acute angle that reminded him of a chicken's wing. "But I'm going to assume that you're not dying and that you're fine."

Phainon nodded into his pillow, and then, considering how uncomfortable their current positioning on the bed was, proceeded to drag Cyrene closer. Once she was close enough, he freed her hand and threw an arm over her shoulder.

A breath caught in her throat. Torn from Cyrene in a way that was purely accidental - instinctual and without any forethought. Her body tensed, momentarily, as if even she'd been caught off guard by her reaction.

Phainon froze. Then, he began to lift his arm.

A hand whipped out and grabbed hold of his wrist before he could pull away entirely. Then, whispering, Cyrene said, "Phai?"

"Yeah?" He murmured, half into his pillow, half towards her. Guilt tried to swim in his voice but he forced it away before it could settle. Some things were only meant to be felt internally - his guilt wasn't something to plague others with.

"Can I hug you?"

It was phrased as if it were just like any other question. As if it were not important. And yet, there was a quake to Cyrene's voice, a thick loneliness to it that she'd been unable to hide entirely. And in that way it ceased to be a question, instead shifting into a quiet plea. He had little doubt that this was a question she'd been wanting to ask for a very long time. Perhaps millions of years.

Phainon couldn't quite bring himself to answer her with words. The idea of answering without the sincerity that Cyrene deserved in this moment was so overwhelming that nausea settled in his stomach. She deserved kindness, and understanding - not the ruin and bitterness that festered in his soul.

Even after seeing what he had done to Aedes Elysiae, she was still requesting comfort from *him*? That was foolish of her. Stupid. It warmed him and he wasn't sure whether it was in a good way or a way that filled him with dread.

Instead of speaking, he raised his arm and held it in place, leaving Cyrene enough space to shuffle up to his side.

It took her a few moments to move. When she did, it was first with the slowness of someone waiting to see if the gesture would be rescinded.

Then, upon realising that he would not drop his arm before she could cross said barrier, she moved with a speed that sang of the end of an eternal wait.

Cyrene's arms wrapped around Phainon's waist, her forehead pressed against his collarbone, holding him as tightly as she possibly could. It was as if she were worried that, at any moment, he might disappear like a memory on the wind.

Phainon lowered his arm around her and, though he had noted it, did not mention how her shoulders had begun to shake. Instead, he murmured, "Get some rest."

"You too," Cyrene said, in a voice both thick with unshed tears and bursting with inconceivable joy. "Sweet dreams, Phainon."

Between periods of sleep, whenever wakefulness caught hold of him, Cyrene informed Phainon of what he had missed.

Squinting at rays of sun that had broken through the gaps of his curtains, he forced glassy, sleep-filled eyes onto a tangle of pink hair and tried his best to ignore how the sun bathed the room in fire and burning fields of wheat.

"You were gone for six days," Cyrene told him, when finally he asked. It was between his second and third attempt at sleep. His stomach squirmed, sharp nails digging into his intestines.

Almost a week of… of what? A tantrum?

It was a week that he could have spent rebuilding Okhema.

"Six?" He murmured, dull and dispassionate.

"Yes." Cyrene, bless her, was doing her best to filter the worry from her voice. It manifested instead in the way she rubbed circles into the back of his hand with her thumb.

What a waste of time.

And yet, even knowing he'd wasted so much time, there was little want to get out of bed and make up for it. He should've been pulling his weight, taking the time to fulfill the duties that had been passed onto him as a Chrysos Heir. Instead, Phainon could not bring himself to do anything but close his eyes.

He simply held his best friend closely in his arms and let out a long sigh.

"Did you spend all that time sleeping?" Cyrene asked. Her voice was gentle. She continued to work circles into his hand. Phainon's thumb twitched as if to copy the task, before falling still. Best not to try. He didn't want to hurt her.

He hummed, managing a half nod. Sleep's outstretched hand was similar to Cyrene's and he fell back into another doze with the sensation of her hand in his.

Between naps, he learned more.

Cyrene had been with Castorice when it had all happened. The pair had been taking a break, talking over poorly brewed tea - Cyrene had tried her best but she was shockingly out of practice - and rating their favourite romance novel tropes. Then the sky outside of Okhema had lit with a streak of fire so bright that it could have been confused for starlight.

Of course, Chrysos Heirs that they were, the pair had done what no sane person would: They had run *towards* the perceived danger. Through crumbling streets, along the path of parting and towards an expanse of field that now had gouges of earth ripped free from its core.

The field was also burning.

Not good. Especially since, in the middle of the flames, protected by a ring of water, were the frozen bodies of Mydeimos and Anaxagoras.

Not frozen in ice but in time.

While Castorice had not known what she was looking at, Cyrene had known from a single glance. There weren't many people who could alter time like this within Amphoreus. The answer of '*this must've been Phainon's doing*' wasn't hard to settle on. Knowing Mydei and Anaxa, they had likely pushed too far and this was the result.

The why hadn't been important to Cyrene at the time. What mattered more to her, then, had been the *where*.

Where, exactly, had Phainon gone in the aftermath?

"Of course that wasn't hard to figure out either," Cyrene murmured. At this point in her story telling, they'd shifted on the bed. Cyrene sat against the wall and Phainon lay with his head in her lap. Her fingers carded through his hair, gentle, detangling any knots and kinks. "Ever since we were little, you'd always go to this same wheatfield on the southernmost edge of the village whenever you were overwhelmed. Since you can open gates, why wouldn't you have gone there?"

Subsequently, she'd asked Trianne to transport her to Aedes Elysiae as well.

It was at this point that the others realised - in part - what must have happened. Things had gotten loud. Concerned. Without Mydei and Anaxa around to explain, they had little explanation available.

Yet, the explanation didn't matter.

All that mattered was finding *him*. A gate was opened and…

And that was when Cyrene had realised that things hadn't just gone a *little* wrong, a momentary dispute or argument bubbling over, but that something *very* bad had happened. More extreme. Less overfilling a cup with water and spilling the remains, and more… shattering said glass under the weight of a waterfall.

Because… Trianne's open infinity gate did not open the way that it should have.

The gate had rippled. Liquid silver showing an image of an Aedes Elysiae that was actively tearing itself apart. The sky snarled. The ground buckled. Past the opening in space, they could see other gaps leading to places that the brain couldn't fully comprehend. Space was contorting on the other side of the gate.

One moment, they were just observers. Then, the destruction caught hold of Trianne's infinity gate too and its shadow began to creep through the opening. It dug claws into the ground around them and seeped through with a roar. The edges of space sharpened and curled. It moved in ways that were not tangible.

Their gate, infested as it had become, glistened with unshed tears as instability bled into Okhema and began to shake the earth. Heat leaked through the open expanse between city and village and began to burn. The air was static with electricity so intense that it sparked thunderclouds into being, a storm biting at the skies of Okhema and settling there as if it belonged.

"Trianne had to close the gate so that nothing else could break through," Cyrene said, with a sigh. "And we had to wait."

"I didn't mean for it to reach Okhema," Phainon murmured.

"I know." Her fingers paused in his hair but she didn't pull away. Less like she was rescinding her kindness and more like she'd stopped in an attempt to think more on her words. "Past what broke through we only felt small quakes and rain. And what *did* break through didn't stay for too long. Just a day or two. Everything else was contained to Aedes Elysiae."

Phainon breathed out a sigh.

More mess. All his fault.

And yet, still, he couldn't bring himself to care.

He would start caring again later. It was a promise. When the tiredness left him, when he didn't feel so far removed from his body that emotion began

to feel like it could sit right in his body, he'd try. For now, he closed his eyes and bathed in the comfort of Cyrene's presence.

She returned to running her fingers through his hair, and Phainon slept.

Sometimes, Cyrene was not there when he woke and Phainon would find himself alone, wrapped in a bundle of memoria and blanket.

She always made sure to tell him in advance, of course. A note left on the bedside table, written in bright pink ink that seemed to shine like ice in the dark of the room. There was always a half-remembered memory of the warning being uttered after a gentle shake to his shoulder had roused him enough to receive a hum of acknowledgement, half-awake. Always a warning to explain that she'd left to get food, or because her duties had called and she couldn't step out on *all* of them.

He never thought twice about where she was going because that wasn't important. He didn't *care* why she was leaving. All that mattered was the promise that she was coming back.

Still… It was difficult to exist in this space without Cyrene there to ground him.

The first few times, he managed to slip back into unconsciousness before it became too difficult. He woke, and Cyrene was not there so he slept.

Except, this time, after the second nap, she was not there either.

This time, when Phainon woke to an empty room, his perfect bubble of disassociation thinned to such a degree that it felt like it had popped. Heat spread through him, hatred catching hold of his soul like a flare, filling both his room and lungs with smoke.

He burned through several layers of mattress. His pillow incinerated to ash. Phainon choked on a laugh, or a cry, and stared silently at his wall with

wide-eyes until, in her absence, the world once again began to glitch.

It was as if his mind, seeing how desperately he wanted the comfort Cyrene brought him, had decided that it would be better to fill the room with countless copies of her. The room dripped with her blood. The burnt mattress glitched until, horrified, Phainon crawled out from a pile of her burning bodies.

A shattered version of Cyrene stared from behind the mirror.

And then, after he'd launched a shoe towards the wall, his chest heaving, dead eyes stared at him from the hundreds of shards he'd created.

Cyrene - the *real* one, probably - had returned to smoke. To shattered vases that had once mattered so much but no longer held any *worth.* To Phainon in the middle of the room, covered in soot and unable to breathe properly as he pulled and pulled on the loose threads of the *Deliverer's clothing*, tearing them to pieces.

He did not hear her return.

He did not realise she was there until a balm of ice had settled over his burning skin, holding his shoulders firmly. Then, her frantic voice reached his ears. *His* name, repeated. Over and over. And he'd realised she wasn't a memory but something real. All the other Cyrene's burned. The real one was accompanied with frostbite.

"Cyrene," he gasped, and threw himself into her arms.

She wasn't ready to take the brunt of his weight. Together they toppled onto the ground. Phainon's hand cupped her head to keep her skull from cracking open on the harsh floor. The glitch of gold blood on his hands disappeared in a string of dispersed code.

Now that she was back, the dead Cyrene's in his vision were clearly dolls. They hardly looked like her at all. He choked on a bitter laugh and closed his eyes so that he couldn't see them anymore.

“Phainon.” Cyrene said, voice shrill and panicked. “What happened? Are you—” A pause. Then, as she pulled him close into her arms, “I’m back. I’m here. You’re alright now.”

She repeated the words and he held her with a tightness that must’ve been painful but she didn’t comment on it.

When they settled, Phainon half-slumped against her shoulder, he murmured, “Cyrene?”

“Yes?” The worry was still there. And fear. She was scared but he couldn’t think of why she would be. He hadn’t done anything to make her feel unsafe, had he? If not, then why would she be scared?

“Is any of this…” He crinkled his nose. Disassociation was beginning to catch in his eyes again like mist. “Is any of this even… *real*?”

“Any of this…?”

“The Era Nova,” he elaborated, staring at the shards of glass past her shoulder and all of Cyrene’s additional eyes trapped within them. “It’s not just in my head, is it?”

When he managed to tear his focus from the glass back onto Cyrene, she looked seconds away from tears. Her pupils wobbled with flickers of light caught in the ocean of her stare.

“Yes,” she said, voice cracking under the weight of her own sorrow. “It’s real. It’s not just in your head. I promise.”

He couldn’t think of any reason why she would lie. Not when looking as distraught as she was. And either way…

Either way, he knew what Cyrene looked like when she lied. Her nose twitched. Her right brow would dip, minutely. She wasn’t doing any of these things - therefore, she must’ve been telling the truth.

(Or, at least, *she* thought that this was all real.)

“Alright,” he said, numbly.

“Does it not feel real?” Cyrene asked.

He wasn’t sure. Maybe in the beginning, when Stelle had been present it had felt real - because it was impossible to make someone like *Stelle* up. She wasn’t fiction in the way the people of Amphoreus were. Her and Dan Heng and the other outsiders from the Astral Express. They felt real because they were unfamiliar.

They were unknown variables. With them gone…

“I don’t know,” he said. It was better than saying *‘no’*. “Sometimes it’s…”

He paused.

Shook his head.

He couldn’t immediately find the words and he was too tired to try, so why bother?

“I don’t know.” He said. And then, “You promise that this is real?”

“Yes,” Cyrene said. Tears spilled from her eyes, finally, no longer able to contain them. “It’s real.”

Phainon’s fingers twitched by his sides. He reached a hand up and wiped them away with his thumb. He murmured, “Why are you crying?”

“Because you aren’t,” she said. “Because you won’t.” She paused, her lips wobbling. “It’s real. I promise this is real. We made it. Our plan worked.”

He wiped away more tears. Then, he pulled Cyrene back into his arms and held her while she cried all of the tears that he could not.

“I believe you,” he murmured.

He didn’t know whether he was telling the truth or not.

Chapter End Notes

next time: more phairene sibling bonding, the other half of cyrene's story of what happened over those 6 days and a conversation with the trailblazer.

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

> should be resting, probably, but hey guess what. i wanted to upload this chapter regardless. i like writing. it's like a secret medicine for the soul. anyway, i hope y'all enjoy this update. i enjoyed writing it.
>
> cutiepie on twt has created some wonderful art for moments from ch11 and ch12. and also for a moment from this chapter too, but i'll put THAT link in the end notes!!
>
> anyway. yeah. look at how long this one is in comparison to the other chapters. are y'all proud of me? i'm proud of myself. haha.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once her tears had dried and the burn of rosy cheeks had settled, Cyrene pulled Phainon to his feet and fashioned his blanket around his shoulders like a protective shield.

“I know you’d rather go back to sleep,” she murmured, when he let out a sigh in protest, wavering on uneasy legs, “but we really can’t stay here. There’s too much smoke and soot. It’s not safe.”

Phainon blinked at her, blankly. Then with a sigh, he said, “Where are we going?”

“Silly question,” Cyrene said. “If not your room, then obviously we’ll go to mine.”

He pulled on his coreflames until space felt malleable enough to open a gate between the two rooms. Then, Phainon paused, his brows furrowing into a deep v-shape. It was all fine preparing to warp space, but he didn’t know where to place the receiving gate. He didn’t actually know where Cyrene’s room *was.*

Had she ever told him? No. Probably not. There hadn't been a need. Phainon didn't know where to find *any* of the Chrysos Heirs. Which was kind of stupid, actually, because avoiding them would've been a thousand times easier if he'd had any idea of where they find them at any one time.

He released his hold on his coreflames, letting the power dissipate back into his blood. Then, he dropped his hand back to his side, limp and useless.

"Alright," Phainon murmured.

He cast a final glance around his room. Cyrene had been right - it really wasn't inhabitable anymore. His mattress had been reduced to cinders. The ceiling had been coated in black. The room - once a place of life, had been reduced to a burnt home of torn thread, broken ceramic and smashed glass.

Titans, he'd really made a mess of things, hadn't he?

Why…

Why had he done that? Why had he gotten so angry that he'd torn this place of comfort to pieces?

…It didn't matter. It would, later, but right now he hardly felt anything at all. Just a nothingness in his chest as he stared at the destruction he'd wrought.

Cyrene smoothed out the edges of Phainon's blanket one final time. Then, she took his hand and led him from the room, closing the door behind them with a muffled thud. Other than a layer of soot on the door handle there was little indication of the ruin that lay within.

They stepped out into a long corridor of apartments that overlooked the square leading to Dawncloud. Through sunbleached pillars they could see the movement of civilians in the plaza - some wandering to and fro, going about their daily business, and others making themselves comfortable on the patch of grass at its center to bathe in the sun and peace that Okhema had been gifted with.

Phainon, unused to it all, reared back from rays of sun and lifted a hand to cover his eyes. It must've been the middle of the day; The temperature was blistering in a way that was only experienced during the Action hour.

"It's this way," Cyrene said, once his eyes had stopped watering from the sudden shift in brightness. There was no rush to her steps. It made it easier for his own lead-lined body to stumble beside her without too much protest.

This area wasn't one that Phainon was too familiar with.

Well - as unfamiliar as anything could be after billions of years worth of memories within Okhema. It wasn't an area that he'd spent many years *living* within. There were two main places he had lived within the city: The Okheman barracks, among his peers in the army and, after being scouted by Aglaea, a room in the western corner of Marmoreal Palace.

The residential district nearby the entrance to Dawncloud hadn't fallen within the purview of 'home'. He'd frequented the area in the past but only ever with the intent to visit. Even now, with his quarters here, he knew it was only temporary. He'd probably be relocated again once the city was renovated.

"Is it far?"

Cyrene halted mid-step and turned him towards the balcony. Past the plaza's grassy center, there were multiple apartment buildings similar to the one they stood within - all painted white, with long swooping arches leading into corridors that overlooked the nearby streets. Many of them were lined with different colours of bunting. Orange. Lilac. Blue. Identical buildings told apart by this simple splash of colour.

"Across the grass," Cyrene said, pointing towards one of the buildings. "The one with the blue bunting. That's where we're going."

It wasn't anything more than a short walk.

And yet it felt as if she were asking him to walk miles.

“I’ll open a gate—”

Cyrene cut him off with a soft shake of her head, squeezing his hand. “I know you’re tired, but a walk might do us both some good. What do you think?”

He stared at Cyrene’s apartment building with the blue bunting and then let his gaze flick down to the plaza before it. Phainon’s lips twisted into something reminiscent of a grimace. He said, “There are people down there.”

“There are,” Cyrene agreed, with a shrug. “Does that matter?”

Of course it did. Phainon didn’t have the energy to play nice and be the fake Deliverer that they all thought him to be. It took effort that he just… couldn’t bring himself to expend. The people of Okhema expected him to be put together at all times, ready to lead them into a bright future. To be eager to do so.

The only thing that Phainon was eager to do, was curl up in bed with his blanket and sleep even longer than he already had. Social politics and responsibility was just another hindrance waiting to drain him.

If people saw him as he currently was… what would they think? Wrapped in his blanket, wearing horribly mismatched clothing, his body covered in soot. If they looked at him and saw that his eyes were glazed over with a distance that could not hide his detachment from the city he’d sworn to protect then they would only be disappointed.

The whole point of being forced onto the pedestal of Deliverer was that he would give the people of Okhema hope. That he would free them all from any dismay that ailed them.

“When they see me like this, they’ll…”

Cyrene squeezed his hand again as he trailed off. Her smile was minute, her eyes sad. “When they see you, they’ll be glad to see that their saviour is taking the time to recuperate after saving the world.”

Right.

But… he *wasn't* their saviour. *Stelle* was. She was the true Deliverer.

Phainon was just the one who had held onto the role until she arrived and could inherit it. It'd never truly been his. Phainon had always just been a placeholder until the real deal had shown up.

But he couldn't say that. He knew that the second he tried, Cyrene would chide him for it. Tell him not to underplay his part in everything. She'd keep trying to convince him that after all of this he was a hero and not one of Amphoreus' villains.

(He'd bought them all time, yes, but he could've been kinder while doing so. Even Phainon knew that much.)

Now wasn't the time to say any of this.

"Cyrene," he murmured instead, "I'm not even wearing shoes."

"Oh, well that's easy to solve." Cyrene let go of his hand and unclasped her sandals. Slipped out of them without a second thought. Once she'd leaned down to collect them, sandals dangling from her fingers, she reclaimed his hand. "If I'm not wearing shoes either, then people will hardly judge the both of us, right?"

A cold thumb began rubbing circles into his skin once more.

Of course, Phainon was still hesitant. Why wouldn't he be? The walk felt less like it would take them five minutes and more like Cyrene had asked him to commit to something that would take five cycles.

But… Cyrene was trying.

Even he could see that much.

Since she'd tracked him down to Aedes Elysiae and left a care package beside his sleeping body, she'd been accommodating his needs without a

single complaint. It mustn't have been easy, dealing with *him* day in and out. Offering him care when he wasn't able to reciprocate it.

He'd not been able to voice his appreciation to her yet. So… Phainon could at least try his best to meet what requests she did make without being too difficult. Even if he *was* reluctant, a little walk was hardly going to hurt.

Phainon didn't exactly care about helping himself, but he could try if that was what Cyrene wanted.

"Alright," he sighed.

They trudged down the corridor, sedate and unhurried. Climbed down stairs as if descending a mountain. Headed out into the plaza as if exploring a new, hostile land. Phainon's shoulders were hunched, muscles pulled taut as he fought to avoid eye contact with any passersby.

Cyrene, noticing his apprehension, began to fill the silence. Her voice washing over him like a gentle balm designed to keep him from getting trapped within his own anxieties. "You know, I've been messaging March 7th a lot since the express left. She's got so many recommendations of movies and magazines from all around the cosmos. Did you know that directors hire out whole *planets* for the duration of filming. The planet becomes one huge set. Isn't that insane?"

Phainon tried to focus on Cyrene's voice.

Tried to ignore the way that heads turned towards them.

At one point, he made eye contact with an older man with hair greying at the roots who lifted a hand in a wave, and Phainon flinched back from the attention before he could begin to think. A bunch of children started pointing at them and Phainon found himself infinitely glad he no longer needed to eat, or drink, because nausea flooded his stomach and he wanted nothing more than to hide.

Cyrene must've noticed the rising tension in his body, because she picked up her pace without a word.

Objectively, Phainon knew it would be better to pull back his shoulders and stand straight. To force a smile onto his lips and pretend that everything - that *he* - was *fine.* But he just… couldn't. Instead, he curled his shoulders and offered his best attempt at becoming invisible.

"And she's also been introducing me to new music, too," Cyrene continued. If her voice was a little louder in an attempt to distract him further, then Phainon wasn't going to be the one to point it out. "One of the artists, Robin, is apparently *super* nice and totally talented. The Astral Express helped her planet too. When we get back, I'll play you some of her songs. The music isn't like what we're used to here. It's more… peppy and upbeat! You'll love it!"

He leaned into the sound of her voice.

Lost himself in the feel of grass beneath his feet.

Tilted his head to stare at the ground so he could avoid the watchful gazes of the people around him and wished for time to speed up so that they could reach the end of the plaza as soon as possible.

It didn't.

Unfortunately, it appeared as if toying with time was something that required conscious thought.

And the second he tried using the coreflames consciously, Cyrene would *absolutely* know it. He wouldn't even have plausible deniability - she'd see right through him to the rising sparks of gold in his eyes.

"See, I told you it wouldn't take long at all," Cyrene said, tearing him from the depths of his own thoughts. He glanced up to blue bunting and a welcoming shade. "Wasn't even five minutes."

Phainon swallowed a sigh and instead tried to smile. He said, "It didn't take long at all."

It felt as if it'd been an *age.*

“Come on,” she said. “Let’s head inside.”

Cyrene’s quarters seemed far more lived in than Phainon’s had ever been.

In one corner, scrolls had been piled haphazardly on a desk, kept in perfect rolls by fraying strings that had clearly seen better days. In another, she had pushed a sofa up to the wall nearest the window. It was an inviting thing, plump cushions buried beneath multiple blankets.

Before it, a small table housed a lifetime of memories. Memoria given photographic form - mostly snapshots of moments not from the cycles but from the days following their end. A smiling Cyrene stood with the Astral Express members. Another photo with groups of the heirs.

The only photo that was clearly from within the cycles were the photos of the two of them. Of Cyrene and *Khaslana.* One when they’d been gap-toothed children sat side by side on their swing. Which could’ve been from *any* cycle, really. Another from what was clearly the first - the pair of them in Okhema. Brightly smiling - Cyrene in her priestess clothing, Phainon in the uniform of the Okheman army.

A time before the Flamechase had asked their active participation.

Phainon’s gaze flicked between all of the photos, almost unseeing. Of all the things to remember… Well.. he supposed these weren’t the worst photos in the world.

Cyrene led him to the sofa, pushing him gently onto the seat.

As he sunk into the cushions and the comfort they provided, Cyrene moved to closed curtains. The rails rattled as she threw them open, bathing the room in gold highlights. Phainon squinted, lifting his hand and throwing it over his eyes with a groan.

“Oh, come on it’s not *that* bad,” Cyrene said, with a small laugh. “Light is good for you. Staying in the dark isn’t healthy, you know.”

She pulled on the window frame until it slid free.

“Plus, I need to air this place out,” she continued. “It’s been a while since I’ve been here. The draft is *extremely* welcome.”

Phainon didn’t say anything. Simply toppled to the side against the many pillows on the sofa with a faint sigh. The light wasn’t particularly unwelcome. After all, he’d never really spent much time resting beneath the sun within the cycles as either Khaslana *or* as Phainon, so arguably it was a nice change of pace.

“I’ll close them again in a while, if you want me to,” Cyrene said.

“It’s alright,” he said, and wrapped his arms around one of the pillows. The edge dug into his cheek, like a dimple, and when he closed his eyes the emptiness that met him was tinged with orange. Less like the burn of a flame and more like the skies of a falling sunset. “I don’t mind.”

“As long as you’re sure.”

He hummed.

The room fell quiet. A lack of conversation as Cyrene went about her own business, leaving him to rest. Just soft footsteps as she moved back and forth. The sound of running water and then glasses being placed nearby. The scrape of a chair being pulled back. The unfurling of parchment.

Usually, he’d have fallen asleep by now.

Instead, he was wholly motionless. Leaning against pillows, atop blankets. Thinking of nothing at all, just listening to Cyrene’s movements, bathing in the rays of sun that had been welcomed into this room. Simply… existing.

It was…

Arguably, he'd call it *nice*. Existing here without any expectations. Without being forced into conversation he didn't want to have. Without being asked about what had happened to make reality feel false, like it was seconds away from fracturing.

She was giving him the space he needed. From herself. From their fellow heirs. From *Amphoreus.*

…Because he was taking the time to recuperate after helping to save the world, was it?

She'd said it as if it was warranted. He wasn't sure whether it was or not but if she was buying him the time to do so, then it was only right that he make use of what she had given him. That meant trying. He couldn't spend all of this time sleeping. Surely he needed to do more?

Though… He wasn't sure what exactly trying meant anymore. Not in this capacity.

He'd figure it out. Just like he'd figured everything else out. Start with something small and… well. Build on it from there.

"You were going to show me music from another planet?" He murmured into the quiet.

"Oh," Cyrene said, surprise colouring her voice. She'd probably expected him to have fallen back to sleep by now. Or maybe she simply hadn't thought he'd ask, that her words had fallen onto deaf ears earlier when he'd stopped responding to her words. "Yeah, of course. Robin, right? You want to listen now?"

Phainon opened a single eye. When it became clear that he held her attention, he nodded.

"Alright." She was beaming. A bright, wide-eyed smile as she reached for her teleslate. "Oh, let me think which song to show you first. From her latest album, maybe? Or maybe—"

She was rambling, scrolling through tracks as she struggled to decide on which album to show him first. Eyes crinkling, both opened and forgoing sleep for a little longer, he watched his friend mumble about tracks and whether it was best to show *her* favourite or the fan favourite.

Finally, she managed to choose.

“Ah, here,” she said at last, pressing play.

A bounce of sound washed through the room. Synthetic but not in a way that seemed false. Rather, it seemed energetic. A steady beat of drums that could be mistaken for clapping hands. A warm voice filled with joy. And… something else. Not a lyre. Definitely strings, but deeper than the stringed instruments of Amphoreus. Cyrene sang along and fumbled over lyrics she hadn’t yet memorised, bopping her head to the beat.

Utterly foreign. It was unlike anything he’d heard in his billions of years.

Something wholly new.

“What do you think? Do you like it?” Cyrene asked, as the track flowed into the next.

Phainon let out a small sigh. The tiniest of smiles tugged at his lips. He said, “Yeah, I like it.”

“Then I guess we’re having an impromptu concert?” she asked.

“Seems like it,” he murmured.

The next time he woke, night had set in.

He didn’t remember falling asleep. Just remembered the steady beat of another planet’s melody and a voice that made the world feel a little more real. Music was still playing, although now it had shifted from Robin’s

music into someone else's. Also unfamiliar. This song was even softer, more like a lullaby designed for sweet dreams.

Candles had been placed on the table, flickering inside the room like friendly stars in the sea of night. One larger candle was scented, circumventing the smell of burning that had been brought on by the various tealights. A familiar scent. Fruity. Pomegranates.

Phainon's eyelids lifted, lazily, as his gaze went in search of Cyrene. She sat at her desk, nursing a cup that had steam rising over the edges, leaning over one of her scrolls. Wholly engrossed, he doubted it could have been anything but a romance novel.

Best not to distract her while she was reading. She'd always hated being interrupted in the past. Whenever he'd dragged her attention away at the best parts of the romance, her cheeks would always go splotchy in her anger and she'd beat her fists against his arm in her indignation until he'd taken Snowy and raced away.

'Can't you let the princess receive her confession in peace!' He could practically hear the words as if they'd been uttered yesterday.

He'd forgotten about that. It was strange that he was only just remembering it now. Weird that he was remembering it at all.

Phainon didn't exactly want to interrupt so he shut his eyes instead.

He was just beginning to drift off once again when the candle's scene snagged on a stray thought that had been floating untethered in the back of his mind.

Eyes snapped open. Phainon jumped up with enough speed that his legs, bound in a bundle of blanket, were strung together as if in a net and he toppled over the side of the sofa with a thud. Letting out a small grunt from the floor, he pulled on the blankets in a weak attempt to free himself from their restraint.

One of Amphoreus' so-called saviours and he'd been bested by a *blanket* of all things.

"Phai?" Cyrene asked. When he looked up, she was turned in her chair, one of her brows raised in a perfect arch as if silently wondering what was wrong with him. Luckily, she hadn't started laughing. He'd… have probably preferred if she had, actually. Instead, she looked like she was struggling to tell whether she should be concerned or not.

"Cyrene," he said, sitting. And then, since he'd already pulled her away from her reading: "I didn't restart time."

He was met with a blank look.

Something urgent caught in his chest. He said, "I didn't restart *time*. Have Mydei and Anaxa been stuck out in that field this whole time?"

For a moment, Cyrene simply stared at him.

Then, her lips twitched at the ends and she broke into a fit of giggles so intense that tears collected in the corner of her eyes. As if the idea of him having kept their friends frozen in time for the better part of two weeks was comedic and not a tragedy.

"No," she said, around her laughter. "They're not in the field anymore. Nor are they trapped in time."

Phainon's cheeks reddened.

"I'd have asked you to free them from the time freeze if they weren't already," Cyrene said, with another small laugh.

"I can't believe I forgot to even *ask,*" he murmured. Had he undone the freeze unconsciously? He didn't remember smoothing the ripples in time that he'd created, but if they were free…

He blinked. Remembered who he was looking at.

…Cyrene had definitely freed them from time herself, hadn't she?

“How angry are they?”

“Not particularly,” Cyrene said, joining him in a crouch on the floor. “Mostly they’re just concerned about you.”

Bathed in flickering candlelight, she continued her explanation of what had happened in Okhema during his absence.

Freeing Mydei and Anaxa from time hadn’t been an immediate thing. It had taken days of chipping at the cracks of time. Considering how Aedes Elysiae hadn’t been navigable, Cyrene had been available to work away at it.

At first, progress was slow. But, of course, considering how many coreflames had been used to press pause on the two Chrysos Heirs, that was to be expected. Persistence was key. The longer Phainon had been away, the less power his coreflames held over the pair.

Two days later, they’d been free.

“They were a little disorientated,” Cyrene said. “For them, days had passed within a second. One second they were with you and then, the next they were with me. I don’t think they really believed it’d been days at first.”

…Titans, the professor was definitely going to add this into his stupid equations of… of *coreflame science* or whatever it was that he’d named it, wasn’t he? He wouldn’t be surprised if the man was already questioning the number of coreflames *again* after this show of power.

Phainon tipped his head back onto the sofa’s cushions and stared, unseeing, at the ceiling. “I told them that it was thirty three thousand cycles instead of just thirty three.”

“Yeah…” Cyrene agreed. “Professor Anaxa said as much.”

“He asked you how many there were, didn’t he?” Phainon asked.

Cyrene hummed, affirming.

“Did you tell him?”

Cyrene tilted her head, before breathing out a sigh. She said, “I really should’ve. But, well, we made a really stupid pact, right? That I wouldn’t. So… no. I didn’t.”

For a moment, Phainon stared at her. Then, his lips quivered, disbelief catching in his throat like an abandoned laugh. He said, “You didn’t?”

“Nope.”

“You probably should’ve.” He said.

“Oh absolutely,” Cyrene said. “If you won’t, I really think that *I* should.”

“But…?”

“But,” she continued, “I was kind of a little annoyed that they pushed you for an answer so much. So I didn’t want to tell Anaxa how many cycles it’d been.”

Despite himself, a laugh caught in his throat. “You didn’t tell them because of spite?”

“A little bit,” she agreed. “But I also didn’t want to tell them before talking to you about it first. That wouldn’t be fair.”

Phainon tilted his head towards her. Didn’t say a word.

“But I do think it’s time that I told them,” Cyrene said.

“It’s not even been two weeks,” Phainon sighed.

“This secret is too heavy to keep. It wasn’t meant to be kept.”

He heaved out another sigh. This one was deeper. The kind of sigh that left the lungs struggling from hyperdeflation.

“Let me think about it?” He murmured.

“Of course.”

Later, after he’d abandoned the sofa for a bed, Cyrene having stolen the duvet, half splayed across the mattress and leaving him with very little space at all, Phainon reached for the teleslate that she’d gifted him and turned it on.

The room brightened with blue light.

Squinting at it, Phainon was surprised to see that it had already been set up in much the same fashion as his old teleslate. Same applications, same background…

Oh. Cyrene must’ve recreated his old teleslate using the Remembrance’s power.

He pressed a thumb into his messages, brows instantly furrowing at the sheer mass of them. He’d not really checked his teleslate since they’d entered the Era Nova, so it shouldn’t have been surprising to see how many unopened messages awaited him.

Messages from his fellow heirs. Some from friends outside of the Flamechase. One from Chartonus. A couple from Theodoros. A few from Dan Heng and March 7th.

And then, finally, of course - Stelle.

He would read the other messages later. Right now, he wasn’t ready to read the onslaught of them all. Didn’t have the energy for it.

Instead, he opened Stelle’s messages and - without reading the messages she’d sent him these past few weeks - began to type.

Phainon

When are you coming back?

Her response was an instant thing. As if she'd been waiting for it.

Stelle

i'm not too sure. soon hopefully?

herta wants to do some experiments that she needs me here for but those are usually pretty quick.

why? have they confirmed the next date for seal slammers? is it soon? if it's soon you HAVE to sign me up. i need to reinforce my status as champion.

Phainon

I think I'm having a nervous breakdown.

For a moment, there was nothing.

Then Phainon was met with three bouncing dots. The jump of an ellipsis announced that Stelle was typing.

He waited for a minute. Then for two. Then, he realised it was probably best to stop counting altogether and Phainon simply settled on watching the screen with wide eyes. When the response finally came, his teleslate buzzed with such ferocity that he almost dropped it in his surprise.

Stelle

oh.

phainon. babygirl.

yeah.

we been knowing that.

Phainon

What?

Stelle

33 million cycles? if you didn't have a nervous breakdown after all of that, you'd be a psychopath.

honestly, i'm surprised it took this long.

Phainon

Oh.

Stelle

also…

partner. sunshine child of mine.

you're literally insane.

so many screws loose in that pretty little head of yours.

what were you expecting?

Phainon

…

Titan's above. I'm the dog in the room that's on fire.

Stelle

yup.

Phainon

Fuck.

Stelle

double yup.

Chapter End Notes

cutiepie's wonderful art for this chapter (based on a snip I put onto twt) here

next time: a video call. hot chocolate. the night sky. and a patch of grass.

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

> “Hey babygirl!” Stelle said, loud and merry, “how’re things on your side of the galaxy?”

Chapter Notes

> i know i promised hot chocolate in the previous chapter but circumstances changed. hot chocolate will have to be delayed. i know, i know. i have betrayed you all and i offer only my humblest of apologies.
>
> anyway. we broke 3.5k kudos?? uh. wow. guys. i'm glad you all enjoy the fic as much as i do. i hope you have as much fun reading it as i do writing it.
>
> also, i've been enjoying writing this chapter to octopath traveller's 'Frostlands' which. wonderful track. really kinda captures the ending to this chapter.

In the silence of Cyrene’s room - well, mostly silent but for her soft snores echoing from beside him - Phainon stared at his teleslate and considered how, exactly, he was going to source multiple fire extinguishers.

The extinguishers would need to be metaphorical, of course.

(Though metaphorical or not, it appeared that they were *very much needed.)*

A nervous breakdown?

Him?

Even while he’d been typing the message to Stelle, Phainon had had his doubts. He’d considered the very real possibility that he was simply exaggerating the state of his own mind. Exhausted? No. He was just a little

tired. People grew tired, sometimes. Anyone who'd been stuck within Irontomb for a thousand years, fighting the blacktide and the force of its corruption would be tired. He wasn't drowning in his own grief, he was just a little upset.

And then Stelle had responded.

Simple messages yet unwavering in the agreement expressed within. Yes, the messages had taken time to reach his teleslate, but it wasn't due to any hesitation. If anything, the messages had simply reminded him of the first day of the Era Nova when Stelle had looked at him with such appalled horror for being a complete and utter *moron.*

Huh.

Wasn't even on the planet and yet he could practically see her judging him in his mind's eye for taking so long to come to any realisation on the state of his own mental health.

So far trapped in his own mind, he barely registered the buzzing of his teleslate in his hand. The screen had switched off, releasing the room back into darkness. A single buzz wasn't enough to catch his attention enough to steal him from his now whirring thoughts.

Phainon could agree that his mental health wasn't exactly in a *good place,* but the claim that he was literally insane? Surely not. That, at least, must've been a joke. Maybe another meme? Stelle often made references to things he didn't understand. Maybe this was just another reference.

Another buzz. And then a third.

Until the room lit with blue light once more, and the vibration of his teleslate became a more constant thing. Ongoing in an attempt to reclaim his attention. What was she *doing,* at this rate Stelle was going to blow up his phone with the sheer amount of messages—

He glanced down.

— Incoming Video Call: Stelle —

Out of pure panic and a little bit of surprise, Phainon fumbled his attempt to answer the call and instead declined it.

Another small, feeble buzz.

Stelle

Rude.

She phoned him again. This time the vibrations felt far more indignant, as if the trailblazer was trying to prove a point from the other end of the galaxy. When he tried accepting the call, his thumb was less shaky and he managed to press the awaiting green button.

The screen burst to life with a glow of warm yellow light as the video call connected.

Stelle, centre frame, looked as she always did. Messy grey hair sticking up as if she'd crawled out of bed without a care, curious golden eyes glistening with mirth. The edges of her lips were pulled up into a loose grin, though her entire body seemed *tense.* Concerned.

The room she was in was a familiar one. She'd shown it to him the day after the Era Nova. Her room on the Astral Express - photos plastered to the walls courtesy of March 7th, a fair number of bird plushies behind her and a toy clock with legs and a face. She must've been sitting at the desk because he could see the sofa and all its *many* cushions over her shoulder.

“Hey babygirl!” She said, loud and merry, “how’re things on your side of the galaxy?”

Phainon glanced towards Cyrene, to how her brows furrowed as the noise threatened to rouse her and proceeded to lift a hand to his lips and shush the trailblazer with a voice bordering on a hiss. He said, “Quiet. Talk quieter. You’ll wake Cyrene.”

Stelle’s eyes widened. Comically so. She said, “Oh, you and Cyrene out here having a sleepover without me? Makes sense why my screen's all dark and I can’t see shit, but hey, where was *my* invite?”

He had to give credit where credit was due. She was quieter. Not by much, but there was some hush.

“You—” Phainon grabbed hold of his memoria blanket and slid off of the bed. “You’re halfway across the galaxy. Any invite would’ve— Partner, you wouldn’t have been able to attend.”

“Still would’ve been nice to have an invite,” Stelle sniffed. Though from the smile she threw at the screen, it was clear the offense was all faux. “... Ignores my calls and doesn’t invite me to sleepovers. I’m telling on you to Dan Heng.”

Phainon was pretty sure that Dan Heng would simply roll his eyes and do absolutely nothing, so he said, “You do that, partner,” and moved from the bedroom to the living room.

He ambled towards the small coffee table and the candles that had been previously snuffed out. Considering how Phainon was the closest thing to a living flame in all of Amphoreus, there was little need to start searching for wherever Cyrene stored her matches. Instead, he simply snapped his fingers and small bursts of flame caught the edges of candle wicks, bathing the room in a low flicker of candlelight.

An abandoned mug on the table was quickly utilised as a stand for his teleslate. Once it was in place, he dropped onto the sofa, again toppling over onto his side and reaching for now familiar pillows.

“Also,” Phainon continued, shifting into a position that allowed him to stare at his teleslate without cricking his neck. “Why do you keep calling me that?”

“Calling you what? Babygirl?”

Phainon hummed, affirmative.

“Well, you never call *me* that,” Stelle said. “And one of us needs to be babygirl so—”

“Do we?”

“Mhm. It’s totally a thing, trust me.” He trusted the trailblazer on many things, but on this, Phainon remained skeptical.

“Right,” he said, slowly. “It sounds… a strange thing to call someone.”

“Nah,” Stelle said. “Not strange at all. Now you have access to the wider universe, you’ll see it’s just affectionate. One day you’ll even start using it yourself. It’s written in the stars.”

“Is it?”

“Sure is,” Stelle said. “I can’t *wait* to get to be the babygirl in this partnership. March doesn’t think I can make it take off. But I’m faithful to the ways of the babygirl. We can walk this journey together, partner.”

Phainon stared at her grin and found that once again, he had no true understanding of what she was talking about. He simply said. “Sure. I’ll… note it down for the future.”

Stelle’s eyes lit as if taking the words as a promise. As if she had just won something very important.

Then, they began to simmer, showing more of the tension from before. As if even with her wish to keep things light-hearted and upbeat, the concern was bubbling whether she wanted it to or not.

“So,” she said. “Dog in the room on fire, huh?”

Ah. It seemed they were doing this then.

He didn’t say anything. He simply lifted one shoulder in an aborted shrug and sighed. There wasn’t any reason to deny it, was there? If Stelle had brought up the claim of a nervous breakdown then maybe he’d have been able to pretend it wasn’t all that bad, but a room on fire was always a concern - no matter how many flames currently filled it.

“What are you going to do to stop living the life of that particular meme?”

His next sigh was even louder than the previous one. Pulled from the depths of his soul, it was the accumulation of lifetimes of smothered breaths.

Phainon said, “I don’t know.”

“You don’t?”

He shook his head. Just because he’d identified that things were bad didn’t mean that he knew how to magically fix it. Didn’t even mean that he *wanted* to. Earlier, he’d felt certain that he needed to try, that for Cyrene’s sake he was capable of making even a tiny start.

But that had been earlier in the day, delirious on the sound of her laughter, with new music in his ears and an adrenaline surge of panic misinterpreted as eagerness. Now it was night and he vacillated between wanting to try to leave his metaphorical burning room and wanting to stare into the flames as his mind burned.

So the room was on fire. So *what?* At least that meant it was warm.

At least that meant he could still feel *something.*

“I don’t know,” he repeated. He lifted his gaze from his teleslate to shadows of flame dancing across the coffee table. He brought his knees up close to his chest and wrapped an arm around his shins. “Do I have to do anything?”

On the other side of the call there was silence.

Certain that if he glanced back at the screen, he'd be met only with sadness, Phainon kept his gaze raised. He wasn't sure whether he'd take back the words if he didn't keep looking away. If he saw sorrow in any of his friend's eyes then he'd fold and go back to lying to keep them happy.

"No," Stelle said, eventually. "You don't."

She was halfway across the galaxy and yet Phainon could still feel the way that space could tremble under the weight of unspoken words. The trailblazer was trying her best to find the best words that could help. After all, that was the role of the nameless. Wasn't it? To build connections and use them to *help* in whatever ways possible?.

"But I—" She trailed off. Paused. Tried again. "I think…" Another pause.

He could hear movement but from where he'd refused to look down, it was difficult to tell what it was she was doing. It could've been anything from resettling at her desk, to reaching for some item that sat past the space captured by the lens of her teleslate.

Quietly, Stelle said, "If you don't want to do anything, then don't. There isn't a person in all of Amphoreus - no, in the *cosmos* - who could reasonably ask that of you."

Again, she trailed off into silence.

This time, Phainon wasn't able to stop himself from glancing back at his teleslate. To Stelle, brows dipped in a v-shape, frustration present in the press of her lips and the way her gaze felt *heavier* than it ever had during the entirety of their friendship.

She met his gaze through the screen and held it.

Steeled herself.

"Phainon," she said. "I don't know if you've realised it yet but… if you turned around tomorrow and said you were done, like *done*-done, that you couldn't keep going and that this was it, that you didn't want to do anything

ever again… I don’t think anyone would be cruel enough to ask you to keep trying. They’d hate the outcome but they’d accept it. Because you’ve suffered enough. And you deserve the right to choose.”

“I—” Phainon shifted, pushed himself up on the sofa and held his pillow close to his chest.

“At this point,” Stelle continued, after a sharp inhale. As if she wasn’t entirely sure whether her words were helping or not, but thought they were important to say regardless. “You’ve earned the right to do absolutely *nothing*. No one is going to ask you to. And it’s not because they don’t want to but because it’s not up to them. It’s up to you. You’re the only one who can make that decision.”

Phainon’s brows furrowed.

The last time he made a proper decision for himself, it’d been alongside Cyrene and it had led to billions of years worth of literal *hell*.

“I—” His teeth pierced his lips with the full force of his uncertainty. “Partner, I don’t… I didn’t mean anything by the question, I just— Well, I was simply thinking out loud. I don’t…”

He held the pillow more tightly within his arms.

More silence between them. Though now some of the tension had eased from Stelle’s shoulders. She said, “That’s fine then. I just thought someone should tell you that. So you knew. Because the other Chrysos Heirs probably won’t say it.”

“Alright,” Phainon murmured.

“Now,” Stelle said, clapping her hands together. With it, the seriousness faded back to her usual half-grin, bright eyes promising mischief “Enough of all the heavy stuff. What are we, bodybuilders? I think not. Tell me, partner - What do you do these days to offer yourself even a little bit of comfort?”

The jump in her mood was so sudden it felt like whiplash.

For a moment, all he could do was simply blink and try to make sense of the words. She had one of those beacon things that ensured he heard Okheman when she spoke and yet he still had to take the time to parse the words.

“Uh…?”

“In the cycles. Before them. As Phainon. Or Khaslana. Any of it.” Stelle prompted.

Phainon blinked, almost absently.

As a child, he’d hidden himself away between stalks of wheat and stared out across a sea of gold, but that wasn’t necessarily a viable option these days. Gold reminded him too much of blood and wheat was a sore reminder of the home he’d spent too many years destroying.

As Okhema’s Deliverer, he had found comfort in connections, in other people. Whenever things became too much, he would find his fellow heirs and converse with them. Days spent helping Hyacine move supplies into Twilight Courtyard storage rooms, or helping Castorice study during their time at the grove. Spars with Mydei. Shared tea with Aglaea while they discussed the latest changes in the internal affairs of Okhema and its politics.

Yet this too had become difficult. He wasn’t that same person, anymore. Every conversation with his fellow heirs felt taut. Uncomfortable. Like each interaction took place on a bed of shattered glass, and there was no way of getting through it without tearing oneself apart and leaving the room bloody and in pain.

So all that really left was the little comforts he had allowed himself as Khaslana.

During his time as the Flame Reaver of each cycle he had allowed himself one single comfort.

A single hope.

Standing motionless, he would stand apart from the world and tilt his head up to the sky. There, he would wait. Watch for any signs of change. For any signs of deliverance.

“I used to watch the sky,” he admitted, finally.

“Perfect,” Stelle said. “Love me a little stargazing at late o’clock in the morning. Well, let’s both go outside and have a staring contest across the cosmos. I bet I’ll win. I’m the universal champion when it comes to staring without blinking. March will back me up.”

Phainon did not know Miss March well but he was pretty sure that she would not be backing Stelle up in this particular claim.

Still, the idea of a staring contest that spanned several galaxies was stupid enough to make him unfold his legs and rise to his feet. After a quick glance into the bedroom to ensure Cyrene was still resting peacefully, Phainon blew out the candles and crept out into the night.

“Are you outside yet?” Stelle asked.

“Yeah."

Cyrene lived on the bottom floor so there were no stairs to navigate. Just the one corridor that led out to the plaza around them. It was sparsely lit. Outside, he spotted a few streetlamps with flames that had long since died out and now held only the glow of still warm embers.

“Can’t exactly see the stars yet,” Stelle said. “You gotta keep moving if we want to see anything.”

Phianon kept moving.

Out of the complex that housed Cyrene’s building. Out into the plaza - empty and devoid but for him and the trailblazer.

“It’s quiet,” he murmured.

“Peace typically is,” Stelle noted.

They kept moving. Or rather, Phainon continued walking further into the plaza, towards the patch of grass that sat at its centre. A little trampled on from all the footfall, but even beneath the glow of stars he spotted a few wildflowers peeking through.

“Get comfortable,” the trailblazer said, as his toes curled around grass, cuffs of his trousers soaking through with morning dew. “You’re about to lose this staring contest in real time, babygirl.”

Though she wasn’t capable of fully seeing it through the darkness, Phainon shook his head. He lowered to the ground, resting his head against the grass and said, “Who knows, maybe you’ll lose your champion title tonight partner. Anything could happen.”

“Those be fighting words Sir,” Stelle claimed. “No one takes my championship title. On three, okay?”

He placed his teleslate beside him and focused on the sky. Free from Aquila’s grasp, the stars were visible in a way they’d never been before. Or maybe it was simply because the galaxy beyond wasn’t a simulated one and thus was more fleshed out and real. The reasons didn’t matter.

What mattered was that the sky shone.

The constellations, once depicting the titans, were now different. New stars, new galaxies. Eventually, the Grove would rewrite their star charts to depict the stars of Era Nova. Other people would leave this place and explore them. The choice was there for them. The galaxy was alive and able to do so.

“I bet you totally just blinked, didn’t you?”

“I haven’t,” Phainon said. “Are you saying that because *you* blinked?”

“Not at all.” Stelle said. And then, a few seconds later, “How about then. You *absolutely* blinked then didn’t you?”

The laugh caught in his throat. A small thing; A bud of contentment - not quite sprouting but getting there. Phainon hadn’t blinked but he said, “Sure, Partner. You caught me.”

“Hmph.” The trailblazer laughed. Loud and infectious. The kind of sound that made a person want to join in. “That’s what you get for trying to beat the Intergalactic Baseballer at a petty competition. I get to retain my title for another day.”

“You sure do,” Phainon agreed and smiled up at the stars.

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

a butterfly makes an appearance.

Chapter Notes

happy halloween!!

when thinking about how to react to the phrase 'trick or treat', i decided on 'treat'. so here's a little treat for you all! it's a little shorter than usual, but i think you'll see that where i stopped was a very natural pausing point. it's alright to have a chapter shorter than 2k every now and again. forgive me!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“—When even *Boothill* was turned into origami I was like, maaan, we’re definitely cooked. You know?”

A hum, half awake and only partly listening.

“And—” The speakers muffled slightly, as if Stelle had moved closer to her teleslate's microphone. She said, “Hey, partner, are you still listening?”

With heavy eyes, Phainon did his best to smother his yawn — only partially successful — and said, “Yeah. Keep going.”

“You’ve gone all quiet.”

“Just listening.” He said. Though he hadn’t been wholly listening to the words, focusing more on the tones of Stelle’s voice and the way her cadence rose and fell along with the tension of her anecdote, he’d processed enough that he had a general impression of the story. “Then the ghost turned your ranger friend into a bird, right? That's what happened?”

Though skeptical, Stelle said, “...That is correct. Mostly. Boothill’s not just a ranger but a *galaxy* ranger, but yeah that's pretty much the gist of it. Huh. Turns out you’re able to snooze *and* listen at the same time. Just make sure not to fall asleep *completely,* alright? There’s still more to the tale.”

Again, he hummed. Though he had long since closed his eyes, he could still see stars twinkling at the back of his eyelids. It was preferable to the empty void that had been the sky of evernight during the cycles.

“I’m not going to fall asleep,” Phainon said.

…He fell asleep.

Between one thought, he was listening to stories from the so-called land of dreams, and in the next, he was jolting at the gentle embrace of something warm.

His fingers brushed against it. Not as thick as a blanket though clearly it was the summer equivalent: not quite as thin as a sheet but somewhere in the middle.

Phainon opened bleary eyes and realised the stars were beginning to disappear. Not because reality was fading but because Okhema was preparing for dawn and they simply couldn’t be seen as easily in a sky that was a haze of orange and red.

There was purple too, though that wasn’t within the sky. It was in the curl of plaited hair, in the long brush of fabric covering hand to elbow and a lilac gaze.

He had not seen her since the day irontomb fell. Now, she stood only two paces from him with a woven basket in hand.

“Castorice…?”

She startled at the suddenness of his attention, stumbling back.

And yet, once she had regained her balance, everything about her seemed to soften. Her eyes, her smile. Even her voice, though *that* softness was also

mixed with apology. “Ah, I’m sorry. Did I wake you?”

The blunt answer was yes.

Rubbing his eyes, Phainon scanned their immediate surroundings. Though few people were moving on the very outskirts of the plaza, the early hour kept it mostly vacant. Only he and Castorice existed at its centre. And if they were the only two then it must’ve been by Castorice’s hand that he was blanketed in further warmth.

He pulled his aching body up so he was sitting, and offered a half shrug. “It’s alright.”

If anything, it was probably for the best. He’d not intended to fall asleep while on his call with Stelle, no matter how inviting the stars had been for dreaming. Better to wake now, while everything was still quiet, than wake later to a plaza bustling with life and curious eyes.

“Ah, so I did…” Castorice’s smile shifted into something just as apologetic as her tone. “I thought you might sleep better with another blanket since it's always quite chilly at this time. I should’ve expected you would wake up instead....”

The sheet had pooled in his lap when he’d sat up. Phainon reached for it. It was a woven thing the colour of clay, uniform in most places but for fraying patches and worn edges.

“Did you make this?” He asked.

“Not this one, no,” Castorice said. “Though Lady Aglaea *has* promised to teach me how to weave one of my own when everything calms down.”

It was as good a conversation starter as any other and yet Phainon let it pass him by.

During the cycles he would’ve asked more. Would’ve asked after future projects, after *current* projects. He would have done anything to pull a warmer smile from his friend’s lips, to bring forth any signs of life.

It was just... he didn’t know whether he was allowed to ask those things anymore. Or maybe it simply felt wrong to do so, after everything.

So instead of asking any of those things, Phainon said, “It’s early. What are you doing out?”

Castorice’s cheeks grew gold at the question, gaze falling quickly onto that of the basket in her hands. It was a round wicker basket - if he squinted, it was possible to see multiple flashes of colourful fabric inside.

“Well,” her voice was not embarrassed, as her flush might have suggested, but rather contained a serene sort of excitement. “I’ve been volunteering at the newly opened Garden of Life with all the little chimeras. They’re early risers so I’ve been rising early too.”

Whirring cogs clashed at the back of his mind as he stared.

The words didn’t compute because he’d simply never heard them before. Not from Castorice. As much as she’d always coveted the chance at a normal life, the ability to be able to help plants blossom or animals thrive, she’d simply never been able to. As the Hand of Death, she was simply too deadly.

In fact, Phainon wasn’t sure he’d seen her interact with chimera very much at all. Full grown chimera had always been wary, as if they could sense her link to Thanatos. And the little cubs… those *Castorice* herself had always avoided. Cubs were far too impulsive and filled with curiosity, after all.

If she were volunteering then that meant—

“Your curse—”

The gentle smile from before bloomed into something he had never seen. Though Castorice had smiled in the past, it was never with as much radiance that bled from her now: Eyes crinkled under the weight of a beam, cheeks golden with sheer joy.

She had *dimples.* Phainon had never known because Castorice had simply never smiled with enough force for them to go noticed.

“It is gone,” she said with a practically breathless laugh.

“Gone…?”

It was only as Castorice nodded that Phainon realised how little distance there currently was between them. Even whenever she had known he’d had enough coreflames of his own to mitigate her curse with his own power, she had always made it a point to remain five paces away.

Now, at most, she was two.

“Yes. My touch— these *hands.…* ” She glanced down to her hands and though all the cycles would suggest an oncoming frown, she continued to smile. “They are no longer made of ice.”

Castorice raised her gaze to meet Phainon’s stare, unflinching, radiating sheer and utter *relief.*

“There is warmth in them.”

Something in Phainon’s chest, glass and fragile, *shattered.*

And he continued to stare.

Stared as Castorice’s smile began to dim with concern. Stared as his fingers twitched by his sides. Stared as liquid began to pool in his eyes.

“Lord Phainon—?”

Then, all too quickly it was not enough to simply be staring anymore.

He scrambled to his feet, unthinking. Reached for her hand not with tact, or hesitation, but with a desperation that only millions of years of watching someone smile without said smile reaching their eyes could foster.

Castorice was right. Her hand was warm.

He could not feel the familiar chill of Thanatos' embrace. Not the coreflame, not the lingering press of the Hand of Death's curse. There was no need to fight against her curse with his own power because there was no sign of it having ever *been there*.

"Castorice," Phainon said, and her name caught in his throat as he said it. He was choking, unable to express himself with anything but the tears that had broken free from his eyes and were now rolling down his cheeks. "It's really gone. You can finally—?"

She didn't say anything.

She didn't need to.

Castorice simply dropped her basket onto the grass beside them and raised her arms, inviting him to step into her embrace. And though Phainon did not deserve such kindness, though he had been the cause of so much of her agony, he could not bring himself to turn her down.

Instead, he stepped into the fold and scooped her into his arms. Pressed his forehead against her shoulder and did his best to pretend that his own shoulders were not trembling. Unsure whether to hold his friend loosely, lest he hurt her, or hold her tightly so that he could be sure that the moment remained real, he wavered and ended up at a halfhearted middle ground of holding something easily breakable with tender care and firm grip.

It was not until she began to hug him back that it shifted into a more comfortable thing.

Castorice gave absolutely *terrible* hugs.

Her arms wrapped around his torso. Too tight for breath, it was less an embrace and more the cradle of a python readying to crush a man to death. Her fingers dug into flesh with too much force. Her hands were *trembling.*

And yet, terrible as it was, it was also perfect.

Phainon let out a laugh that was as wet as his eyes. His voice was thick with... with *something*, some emotion that he could not begin to name and thought he should have, he could not bring himself to lift his head from Castorice's shoulder as he murmured, "I am *so* glad for you, Castorice. You deserve this."

"Lord Phainon," Castorice said, in much the same tone as his own. "If you keep crying, I don't think I'll be able to stop myself from crying as well."

"I just—"

He trailed off. Finding the words was too difficult.

Instead, he just leaned into the warmth of the woman once cursed by Death and realised that with this warmth, she felt *real*.

Phainon was being held by the Castorice of the Era Nova. He was not being held by the ghost of her from the cycles. No copy of the Hand of Death had ever been this warm. At long last, he could finally hug his friend without the promise of death looming over them both, ready to drag him, unwilling, into the Sea of Souls.

"I think I understand," Castorice said. Her own voice was cracking now, raw in a way that she usually did not show. "It has been a long wait for both of us, hasn't it?"

"Yes," he breathed.

"It might be too late to say it now," she murmured and tilted her head so that her cheek pressed against his temples, "but I've been waiting to say it, so I will. Thank you for bringing us into the Era Nova, Lord Phainon. I pray this Era will be far kinder to you than the last."

Chapter End Notes

> how to make someone who has suffered so much over billions of years cry? oh well, how about offering him something that makes him so

inexplicitly *relieved* and happy, that he sobs tears of joy? yeah. that'll do it!

also - i have a lot of thoughts on this chapter in terms of phainon's characterisation, but maybe we'll get into that another day. if people want to hear my ramblings, ofc!

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

> thanks again to everyone for the lovely comments that you've left, i love and appreciate them all!
>
> wanted to do a longer note but honestly guys, i'm tired. i'm just gonna go to bed instead haha. hope that you enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

During the cycles, Phainon had only ever offered Castorice a hug one time.

It had been very early on. Before the coreflames had begun to burn away both his insides *and* his emotions, before the rage had claimed him as kindling. Before he'd donned the role of executioner, before he'd stopped caring whether his friends survived any set cycle and had still tried his best to work *alongside* the flamechase to buy them all a little extra time.

Back then, he'd had maybe… seventeen coreflames of Death nestled within his chest.

Enough that he could feel her curse like an ache in his bones and know that while it would try to drain his vitality, it would not do so with such speed to make it so he could not afford his dear friend an embrace she so desired.

Back then, Castorice had looked at him as if she might cry. Not with tears of joy but with a grief unlike any he had ever seen her display in the cycles following.

"Lord Khaslana," she had murmured, fingers twitching as she held out the eighteenth cycles' coreflame of Death in icy hands. "You know I couldn't possibly accept such an offer. It would be selfish of me to take even a little bit of life from you for my own comfort when we all have such a long journey ahead of us."

His face must've shown his disappointment because she'd added, "On the day that this is all over and we finally reach the true Era Nova, please embrace that Castorice instead. Until then, we shall both have to wait."

He'd promised to wait until the end of their journey. And he'd held onto the promise, at least for a little while. Until it had faded, like most promises that he'd made within the cycles began to fade - not from lack of care but from the slow decay of memory. By the time the promise had unravelled from memory entirely, he had become Castorice's executioner and there had been no place left in his chest for such attempts at kindness.

'It has been a long wait for the both of us,' Castorice said now, and Phainon knew it was not in reference to this promise, but it felt like that eighteenth iteration of Castorice was speaking through her regardless

…Of course she was. Every iteration of his friend was still *Castorice,* no matter whether she remembered or not.

Caught in this sudden reemergence of memory, Phainon didn't track the moment that they both sank to their knees. It was only when morning dew began to leave his trousers damp and uncomfortable that he began to catch on. His body shuddered but whether it was from the damp or his own rising emotions was difficult to say.

Maybe it was both. Maybe neither.

Phainon didn't know.

All he *did* know was that he probably should've let go of Castorice by now. Having someone who had sown more death than even she, the Hand of Thanatos, had *witnessed* continue to hold onto her like a lifeline must've been a harrowing experience. The issue was that he simply couldn't bring himself to let go. Every time he tried to convince himself to unfold his arms, to lift his head, it was simply too much.

Instead, he kept his forehead pressed into the flat of Castorice's collarbone and tried his best to settle his trembling shoulders. It should've been easy. He was relieved that her curse was gone, to finally be able to embrace her

like they'd both always wanted, yes, but did he need to be so dramatic about it?

A few tears were understandable. This… This *stubbornness* of his tears demanding to be shed was a level of drama that was unnecessary.

And yet as much as he tried to stop himself he couldn't.

Now that he had started Phainon wasn't sure he *knew* how to stop.

It was as if in turning the faucet he had torn it free. Now the tears had started, he had little control over them. They poured out of him, grief catching in the curl of his ribs and squeezing his heart.

Even the sky had begun to weep alongside him. He didn't need to look up to know that storm clouds had begun cradling Amphoreus because he could feel Aquila's coreflames in his chest resonating with his tears. Rain began to fall alongside them and he could feel the pitter-patter of it falling in time with the drumbeat of his pulse.

"I'm sorry Cas," he murmured, when she began rubbing a hand up and down his arm.

"Don't apologise," Castorice murmured, in much the same tone. Teary. Kind. With just a smidge of sadness in her voice. "I've got you, Lord Phainon. I hope my embrace grants you a little bit of peace."

He hated to disappoint her but it was not peace that he found in her hold. His mind was roiling with previous memories and it was not until the rain began to shower in earnest, grief tearing itself free that he found anything somewhat close to peace.

As they remained holding one another, water running down his neck in channels, what he finally found in her hold was *silence.*

Not the typical silence that followed closely behind Death. As the torrent continued and the white noise began to wash away his thoughts, it became a silence no longer filled with melancholy, or grief, but rather the kind of

silence that was offered by temporary reprieve and the temporary halt of somber memories.

It would be a lie to say that he felt better but there *was* a degree of comfort that came from her touch being the only warm thing he could feel.

Phainon wasn't sure how to respond to her hope of peace. So, like with everything else, he moved them along and murmured, "You don't need to call me *Lord* Phainon, Castorice. You never had to be so formal with me."

Castorice's laugh was a small thing. Not as light as genuine laughter but tickled nonetheless. Perhaps she simply found it absurd that he was here, crying in her arms, face hidden away in the crook of her neck and worrying about the fact they were being too *formal* with one another.

"I know I didn't," she said, softly. "Old habits are just hard to change, sometimes."

Phainon swallowed back a sigh and finally, though he did not want to, pulled himself away.

As soon as he did, it was difficult not to feel guilty. The downpour had soaked them both. Castorice's bangs clung to her forehead. Her clothes were so saturated they clung to her body as if unsure what else to do with themselves.

"Sorry," he murmured again, gaze turning upwards to a sky coloured by multiple shades of grey. A shroud of heavy fog blocked the sky. Somewhere above, he could feel each cloud growing more swollen, pulling on the surrounding atmosphere's humidity to help form more teardrops and rain.

"Don't be," Castorice said, gently, reaching for his hand. Still warm. Still so very kind. "It's just a little bit of rain."

For a moment, his mind struggled to place the meaning behind the words.

Then he realised that Castorice knew the rain was his fault.

It shouldn’t have surprised him, really. Okhema’s previous storm, the one that leaked free from Aedes Elysiae, had also been his fault. At least this time Okhema only had to deal with a little bit of rain.

Or a lot of it. Already the grass around them was slippery with mud.

…Phainon had to figure out how to stop crying before he flooded the city. It felt as if all of the coreflames of Sky beneath his skin had bound themselves to his grief, to his tears, and were just as uncontrollable.

“Why don’t we head inside?” Castorice suggested. “If we stay outside, we’ll be sure to catch a cold.”

Castorice’s quarters were not too far from Cyrene’s.

They were both in the building with blue bunting, on the ground floor, though Castorice’s rooms were in the adjacent corridor and sat at the opposite end of the building.

Phainon wasn’t entirely sure why he followed her back to her own rooms rather than disappearing back to Cyrene’s side and the comfort of rest that could be found within. It was possible he didn’t want to wake her.

Or maybe he just didn’t want to make her cry again.

And Cyrene would, he knew, if she saw that *he* had been crying. Was crying. Couldn’t *stop* crying.

Wasn’t the realisation that one was having a mental breakdown supposed to *help*? All Phainon had managed thus far was tears and an unnatural alteration to the weather that held the very literal risk of drowning half the city if he didn’t manage to get his own emotional state back under control.

The room Castorice brought him into could only be described as *cosy.* Bundles of black wool and sewing needles had been left in a large basket on

the coffee table. Unfolded bundles of parchment had been left on the desk, beside an inkwell and an ornate feather quill.

As Castorice zipped past to collect towels for them both, Phainon's focus remained on the pen.

The feather had been dyed with lavender - messily done, if the white streaks running along the vanes were anything to go by. He'd experienced enough colour theory sessions from Aglaea over the cycles to know that objectively, the pen nib would've looked better in silver rather than its deep gold colouring, and yet, to him, it was beautiful in its imperfection.

His attention had moved on to various crocheted animals on Castorice's couch by the time she returned and pressed a bundle of fluffy towel and woolen clothing against his palms. Phainon lifted his gaze from a crocheted unicorn that resembled Little Ica to meet her eyes.

She'd taken the time to change out of her own soaked clothes. From deep lilac, she'd changed into a long indigo dress and a white cardigan. Her plaits were far messier from where she'd attempted to towel dry the strands to keep them from dripping water everywhere.

Castorice pointed towards the woolen fabric in his hands, her cheeks growing gold. "If you'd like, you can change into that and I'll hang up your clothes so they can dry."

"Alright," Phainon murmured.

With a faint smile, she pointed him towards the bathroom and left him to change. First, he unpeeled his current clothes, shivering as water continued trickling down his neck. Then, after towelling himself down, he unfolded the black clothing Castorice had passed him.

It was a woollen jumper. Soft, with somewhat messy stitchwork around the sleeves and at the neckline. Handmade. Baggy and yet not too loose as to invite any chills. It must've swamped her whenever she wore it - though none of his memories included this particular jumper as being part of her

wardrobe. Probably something she'd picked up within Era Nova then. It felt new, so that was probably it.

He wrung out his trousers as best he could, realised it was a losing task and decided he'd just have to deal with the dampness.

When he eventually left the bathroom behind, hair still clinging to his forehead, dripping water along the curve of his nose, Phainon was greeted with the scent of vanilla and warm milk. Castorice, standing by the stove in her little kitchen, turned to glance at him over her shoulder and said, "It fits you. Or, well, maybe a little big. I was worried I'd make it too small."

For a moment, his mind was static.

Then, he said, "Did you make this for *me?"*

Castorice's lips pulled up. "Of course I did."

It was difficult to do anything but stare.

Part of him wanted to ask *why,* to ask what he'd done to deserve her care but really, he already knew the answer. They were friends. They always had been. Even when he'd thrust Dawnmaker through her ribs, or torn the coreflame of Death from her chest with clawed hands, they'd always been *friends.*

That was why he felt so damn *guilty* towards all of his fellow heirs. That was why he was such a monster, deep down.

Because despite all his affection for them, despite the love he held for his friends and dearest companions, it hadn't ever been enough to make him hesitate before killing them.

"...Thank you," he murmured and lifted his sleeve to wipe away the tears that continued to fall.

"I was going to wait until I'd finished everyone's gift," Castorice continued, as he lowered his gaze, unable to keep looking at her. It felt like he was holding his breath until she finally turned back to the stove, at which point,

the building pressure in his chest began to ease. “But I don’t mind letting you receive yours now. I hope you don’t mind that it’s black - there’s not a lot of colour variety in wool at the moment. I was lucky to be able to find this much in black.”

“I like it,” Phainon said, and pulled on his sleeves until they fit comfortably in his palms. Twisting the fabric was grounding. Helped keep him present and not trapped in the thoughts of the cycles. “I’ll treasure it forever.”

Castorice let out a small laugh. Equal parts relief and warm happiness.

“I’m glad,” she said. Then, with a low hum, “On rainy days like this, I always feel better with a cup of hot chocolate with a little vanilla and a sprinkling of cinnamon. It helps warm me up. Would you like some?”

“Oh, no you don’t need to—” Something like panic rose in his chest. “After everything… I don’t need to eat or drink anymore. You don’t need to waste it on me.”

A moment of silence.

Then, Castorice said, “I don’t think it’s wasted on you if you’ll enjoy it. If it’ll make you feel happy, even a little, then it could never be a waste.”

Phainon twisted the fabric of his sleeves even more, pressing his lips into a thin line.

Part of him wanted to explain that it wasn’t worth it. That *he* wasn’t worth it. That she should be out sharing hot chocolate with everyone else, or spending time with the chimeras at the Garden like she’d been planning on doing. He’d hurt *everyone,* whether they remembered it or not, whether they *knew it* or not.

Another part of him that sounded a lot like his inner hero, like Stelle or Cyrene, murmured that it was just hot chocolate and that accepting a little bit of kindness, whether he deserved it or not, wasn’t the end of the world.

“What do you think?” Castorice prompted, as he descended into silence and half-anxious thoughts.

Phainon wiped at his eyes again - they remained as wet as the rain outdoors - and offered a tiny nod. “If you don’t think it’ll be a waste.”

“Never,” she said, firmly. “Now come claim a mug for yourself. And help me reach the cinnamon, will you? Lady Cipher keeps hiding it on the top shelf whenever she visits and it's always impossible to reach without climbing onto the counter.”

Chapter End Notes

- some ramblings on phainon's characterisation within ASU

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

cocoa time!!! i've been kinda excited for this one - you'll see why.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castorice had a whole collection of mugs hidden away in her kitchen cupboard.

Since none of them were plain, Phainon chose an old mug with painted chimeras that ran across its base and a chipped handle. It looked well used, well *loved.* Like an artefact in the life of the *Maiden of Death* that would require preservation within the new Era.

Part of him wanted to ask if these mugs had been collected within the one cycle he'd not been present for but Phainon couldn't find the courage to ask. Instead, he reached up to the top shelf for the stashed powdered cinnamon that had been pushed as far back as it could possibly be—which was surprisingly far considering these were *deep* cupboards—and allowed Castorice to shoo him to the sofa.

Her pillows were just as soft as Cyrene's were. Phainon sunk into couch cushions, leaned against the arm rest and rubbed at still wet eyes. It was starting to get ridiculous - biologically he should've stopped by now. And yet Phagousa's coreflames, keeping him from dehydration, seemed to be actively working against his efforts to stop.

As he sat, awaiting both his friend and the hot chocolate she was making, Phainon brought his teleslate out of his pocket and opened his messages. His chat with Stelle was still open from the previous evening - at some point following the end of their call, she had sent a message boo-ing him for falling asleep halfway through such a riveting tale of origami and fruit matching. Then half a quint later, she'd sent a follow up message wishing him restful dreams.

Pressing out of her messages, he was met with the same unopened messages that he'd been avoiding since the beginning of the Era Nova. He kept promising himself that he would read them later but honestly, Phainon wasn't sure when *later* would be. All he knew was that it continued to be *not now.*

The only message he opened was that of Cyrene's when his teleslate buzzed with her incoming text.

Cyrene

Hey! Woke up and you weren't here, is everything ok??

He could practically feel the worry oozing from the words. Which made sense - the last time she'd left him alone, not even a full twenty-four hours ago, reality had begun to unravel around him and he'd set about destroying his room until everything was stained in soot and coated in shattered glass. He was almost surprised she hadn't called him immediately or demanded he share his location.

...Alright, maybe she wouldn't have demanded his location and he was simply exaggerating the extent of her worry but he was still surprised she hadn't called. Perhaps because it was still early and she hadn't wanted to risk waking him up? At this point, his natural state of being was *asleep* so she might've expected that he wouldn't be awake. Yeah, that seemed like the likeliest reason.

Phainon

I'm with Castorice.

She's making hot chocolate.

Cyrene

Ah!!

Alright no worries then. I'll get some chores done. If you need anything let me know and i'll zoom on over!

Phainon

Will do.

Thank you, Cyrene.

Cyrene

Anytime!!

"Here you go."

Phainon lowered his teleslate as Castorice's shadow fell over him, gaze falling to the mug held in her outstretched hand. Wiping tears away with his sleeve one final time - really, why weren't they *stopping?* - he reached out and took the mug, holding it between his hands. The warmth of the ceramic brushed against his fingertips and burned his palms. A pleasant burn, the kind that left the skin tingling.

"Thank you," he murmured.

Castorice settled on the other side of the sofa, folding her legs up, leaning against the armrest. Her own mug— purple, with little ceramic butterfly wings for a handle— rested against her thigh.

In the absence of conversation, Phainon lifted his mug to his lips and inhaled the deep scent of cocoa. It was rich, accompanied by sweet vanilla and earthy cinnamon. He didn't even need to drink in order to taste the sweet spice on his tongue, the aroma caught on his tongue and lingered as if he'd taken a large gulp of it.

“You’ll have to let me know if I put too much cinnamon in,” Castorice said lightly, as he continued to breathe in wisps of hot cocoa instead of actually *drinking* it. “Lady Cipher always says I’m too stingy with how much I add.”

“Cipher really likes cinnamon, is all,” he murmured. “You could put in a whole heaped spoonful and she’d probably ask for more.”

“She would *not*,” Castorice laughed. “That would be far too much.”

Phainon shrugged halfheartedly. He was pretty sure that Cipher *had* done that before, actually, in at least a few thousand cycles. The first time he’d seen it, he’d been horrified. Like with everything else however, it had not taken long for the emotion to fade into expectancy.

He was starting to think of the cycles again.

…Phainon was so tired of thinking about them. He didn’t want to think of *anything.*

So instead of thinking, he tilted his mug against his lips and took a sip in an attempt to focus on other things.

Cinnamon hit his tongue first - the subtlest smokiness in the spices paired with a faint hint of citrus. Citrusy as it was, it must’ve been Aidonian-grown. The cinnamon grown within their greenhouses always carried a hint of citrus. Not entirely sweet, but with a faint bitterness that had thawed into something softer.

Then, the silkiness of the drink itself. Warmed milk caught against his tongue - not scalding, luckily he still had enough control over his coreflames to avoid *that* - and blanketed it with a soft caress of cocoa and vanilla. Phainon rolled the taste around his tongue, let it warm him, let it *linger.*

And as it lingered, he found himself wondering if this was what home tasted like for Castorice. Rich cocoa and the lingering touch of cinnamon across the tongue.

He should’ve known, after everything, but he didn’t.

Had he ever asked?

No. He hadn’t. Why hadn’t he*?*

“What do you think?” Castorice asked.

“You didn’t put in too much,” he murmured, as it dawned on him that he *couldn’t* ask. That he never would because he didn’t deserve to. He took another sip; the cocoa clung to his tastebuds, earthy and sweet. “Cinnamon, I mean.”

“I’m glad,” Castorice said and her eyes crinkled against the weight of her smile.

They drank in silence.

Phainon knew he should’ve been saying something. This was his friend - the quiet wasn’t meant to be suspended for quite this long. And yet, every time he tried to find a topic that was *safe*, he came up short.

The world wasn’t glitching around him, not with Castorice’s warmth by his side acting as a grounding agent, but his mind was still electrified, still fuzzy every time he tried to think about what could be said. What was safe and what was not. What conversations they had once shared that Castorice remembered and which ones hadn’t happened in the cycle *she* remembered.

When he finished his hot chocolate, swallowing it alongside rising anxiety, he leaned forwards and placed it onto her coffee table with a dull thud. He ran a finger across the chip in the handle and sighed.

“I’m sorry, Castorice,” he murmured, at last.

From the corner of his eye, he watched Castorice’s brows furrow. She opened her mouth - as if, on instinct, she’d been ready to say he didn’t have

anything to be sorry for - before forcefully pushing the words away. Though her hesitation was minute, it was an obvious thing.

She asked, “Why are you apologising?”

Well there was an entire list of things to apologise for but it was probably for the best not to get into all of that when he’d not prepared her for any of it. Apologising for killing her, or for lying to her, probably wasn’t best done when he was in her *home*. That was the sort of apology you gave when the other person had a means of escape.

“To have made you bring me here,” he said instead because that apology felt more pressing than the others. More appropriate for the situation. “I didn’t mean to steal you away from the chimeras or interrupt your time at the Garden.”

Castorice’s furrowed brows smoothed out.

“Oh,” she said, “you don’t need to worry about that. I can just go and see the chimeras tomorrow - right now, I’m *very* happy to have a cosy day inside with you.”

He probably should’ve felt reassured by that. In the past he would’ve been!

(In the past, he had not been… *this*. Broken. Cruel. Fighting against the destruction inside of him with every breath.)

“It feels like I haven’t seen you in a very long time,” Castorice continued. “And even if I had, I always have time for a friend.”

He wanted to say that he wasn’t just a friend but her enemy. That he was her executioner. That she was being too kind, too thoughtful, for someone like *him*. Phainon wasn’t sure whether telling her would be selfless or selfish, at this point. All he knew was that every time he tried to form the words they caught in his throat. The truth was too large to be spoken and the idea of breaching it even a little bit made him want to disappear from Amphoreus entirely.

Instead of saying any of this he simply shuffled closer on the sofa and, after double checking that she wasn't overwhelmed by his closeness, leaned his head on her shoulder.

"Alright," he said.

And then, bolstered by… he wasn't sure what exactly, perhaps her warmth, or just her acceptance, Phainon asked, "What will you do with the chimeras tomorrow?"

Castorice physically brightened. He could feel it in the way her shoulders shifted, could see it in the animated way in which she began speaking with her hands. In how she was clearly excited over being able to share her latest venture, this new hobby that she'd never been able to take part in while cursed.

She took him through her daily routine. Mornings at the Garden weren't exactly the busiest time - that was during the Parting hour, when chimeras returned to the garden with dusty coats of fur from a day of helping clear the rubble from Okhema, at which point bath time became a three-quint long process - but it was close. From preparing meals, to doing a daily check on each chimera to make sure they weren't straining themselves and were in good health, things were in perpetual motion. There were so *many* chimeras, after all.

"We have a lot of people volunteering," Castorice said, as he closed his eyes and focused on the calming lilt of her voice, "but even with everyone it's difficult. We're currently looking after all of the chimeras from the Grove's equivalent Garden so it's a little overcrowded."

He hummed. "Is it possible to make the Garden bigger?"

"They're considering it, but in terms of Okhema's restoration, it's not a high priority." She paused. "I've been thinking of adopting a couple chimeras myself and bringing them home so they can have a little more room but I'm not too sure that I'm ready to do that just yet."

Which made sense.

Even though she only held two cycles worth of memories that was enough for her to still have reservations. Her touch had brought death for so long that it wouldn’t have been strange if she thought the curse’s removal was only a temporary thing. And if it ever came back... well, she didn't need to say way she was hesitant.

…Maybe the Era Nova didn’t quite align in her head, either.

He let out a small sigh and said, “Keep thinking on it. Any chimera you would adopt would be lucky to have you.”

“Oh I don’t know about *lucky*,” Castorice said with a small laugh. “They might not feel that way when they realise I’ll be sewing lots of cute little outfits and hats for them to try on.”

He let out a half breath that was something close to amused but mostly sounded tired. “And sunglasses.”

“And sunglasses,” she agreed.

They continued like that. With Castorice, kind enough to carry the conversation, only requiring small comments and the occasional question to keep the room from falling back into silence.

It may not have been the perfect conversation but it was a start.

Topics flowed from chimera care, to the many crafting projects Castorice had begun - of the sweaters she was making for the heirs, she was currently working on three tinier sweaters for the Tribios triplets and was currently trying to figure out how to accommodate their wings into the pattern she was following.

Keeping things light, they danced through more topics. Castorice, alongside Cyrene and Hycaine, had made a pact to start a communal garden for all of

the Chrysos Heirs to enjoy after Okhema's rebuilding efforts had been completed.

“We’re not sure whether it’ll be at the Grove or here in Okhema just yet,” Castorice admitted. “But Hyacine’s going to grow medicinal herbs while Cyrene and I focus on planting a vegetable garden.”

She looked so *excited* for this future that something in Phainon’s chest began to ache.

And past that, deeper down, just embers in his chest, he could feel something like excitement *for her.* Phainon smiled. Or rather, he grimaced, but that was close enough to a smile for him.

They were halfway into another ramble about a meal that Castorice had tried making with herbs that Cipher had found— see: probably stolen but Castorice clearly didn’t want to admit that bit— when they were interrupted by a series of knocks.

The raps weren’t particularly loud, though they echoed through Castorice’s living room regardless.

She jumped. Begrudgingly, Phainon lifted his head from where his cheek had remained pressed against her shoulder for the past quint.

“Expecting someone?” He asked.

“I wasn’t,” Castorice said, standing. “I’ll be right back.”

From where he remained on the couch, it was impossible to see the front door as Castorice opened it. Not that it mattered, really, who her guest was. If her visitor needed her urgently, then he’d go back to Cyrene’s rooms and fold himself up on the couch with outerworld music playing on a loop. If her attention wasn’t needed for longer than a few minutes, then he’d simply prompt Castorice on her return to the sofa to continue telling him about the Dromas curry she had been talking about.

Simple.

He didn’t care about who her guest was.

Castorice unlocked her door with a click of its latch just as Phainon retrieved his teleslate, intent on searching for the songs Cyrene had shown him the previous night.

Then she said, “Lord Mydei. Did something happen?”

Like electricity, Phainon jolted, fumbling with his teleslate. It slipped free from his fingers, landing on stone flooring with an almost deafening thud.

Well then.

Maybe he cared a *little bit* about who Castorice’s guest was.

“Just checking up on you,” came Mydei’s deep timbre. “You weren’t at the Garden this morning. I thought you might be sick.”

Phainon didn’t exactly register standing but one moment, he was trapped in cushions and a sofa that was cosy enough that it could swallow a person entirely, the next he was standing, craning his neck in an attempt to see the doorway.

Nothing from this angle.

At the edge of his hearing, the rain outside seemed to increase in its intensity. Heavier than before. Before it had been harsh but now it sounded downright torrential.

"Ah,” Castorice said. It was easy to hear the smile in her voice, the fondness she held for their fellow heirs. “You don’t need to worry. I’m not sick. I have a guest over today so I pushed back my visit to tomorrow.”

Phainon wasn’t sure whether she was going to invite Mydei in. He wasn’t sure whether he wanted her to. Whether he wanted to see Mydei or not.

—Ones and zeroes echoed in his mind’s eye and suddenly he was in the ruins of Aedes Elysiae again, holding a body that dissipated into broken fragments of code—

And it didn’t matter whether he wanted to see him or not because his feet were already moving. Because *want* did not matter - he *needed* to see Mydei and confirm that he was real. Even if he was only a fragment from the cycles, even—

He turned the corner and there he was.

Mydeimos, drenched by the rain and with the same crease in his right brow that he always got whenever concern had sunk into his physique with the heaviness of stone. He was holding a flask in his hand— no doubt he’d made Castorice soup the moment he’d thought she might be unwell. Like the last time Phainon had seen him, his gauntlets remained missing from calloused hands.

The room flashed, flooded by white-gold light.

And then, before any of them could react, a deafening crack of thunder split through the room, like a tear, ripping open a fissure of pure *noise* into Castorice's home, displacing the previous soothing ambience it held. It was as loud as a final breath was within silence.

Past Castorice’s shoulder, he met Mydei’s gaze, eyes widening as a second flash of lightning descended over Okhema.

Castorice turned with such speed she almost tripped over her own feet, concern present in the bite of her lip, “Phainon—”

Phainon couldn’t tear his attention away to focus on her. He was stuck, staring at Mydei, struggling to tell whether this copy of him was real or a piece of code readying to delete itself like the version in Aedes Elysiae had been.

Ripples of ones and zeroes pressed against the back of his eyelids as he blinked and it felt, almost, like he couldn’t breathe. He tried - once, then twice, until on the third try he managed to inhale a gulp of air that was entirely too dry.

“Lo—” Castorice moved towards him, pressing two sets of fingers into his palm. *"Phainon."*

She was still warm.

(Code didn’t emulate warmth like this, he reminded himself.)

Phainon blinked. Once and then a second time. And then, finally, he managed to tear his gaze away, across to Castorice’s hands holding his and to the look of deep concern she aimed towards him.

“Sorry,” he murmured. “I was just—”

He didn’t know how to explain himself so he simply folded his fingers with hers and offered another grimace-smile her way and repeated, "Sorry."

Then, because he was aware that there were two sets of eyes focused on him now, watching with caution— or maybe what he saw was worry? — he met Mydei’s gaze once more and murmured, “It’s been a while, Mydei.”

Chapter End Notes

> need you all to know that most of my research for fics is mostly really irrelevant things. this chapter, I ended up spending an hour reading about cinnamon and the differences between ceylon, cassia, saigon and korintje varieties.

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

> i was very hype for this chapter. very excited. i've been very *!!!* while writing this one. hope you guys enjoy as much as i have!!

After the fight with Irontomb, after the Chrysos Heirs and their companions from beyond the stars had ushered in the Era Nova, it had been Mydei who pulled Phainon free from the scepter's core.

Stelle had pried open loose sheets of metal with her lance, Cyrene and March 7th had cooled the molten, bubbling metal and fried circuitry within each breached layer and the Astral Express's genius companions had stabilised the dying scepter's core to keep it from imploding and sending out an invitation for *another* Aeon's gaze upon Amphoreus.

Everyone had helped tear apart the remains of Irontomb to locate him but Mydei had been the one to breach the scepter's core first.

It had been Mydei's voice that murmured, *'Found you'*. It had been *Mydei's* fingers, sharp and melting, that tore him free from the wires. Who had pulled Phainon, half-conscious, into his arms and carried him out of the wreck, one layer at a time, unyielding and strong despite the blood pouring from a gash in his forehead and the burns spread across shaking fingers.

The first voice Phainon had heard outside of Lygus' and *Irontomb's* in a thousand years had been that of his equal. A low cadence filled with exhausted, trembling *relief*.

He didn't really remember much between waking and reaching the impromptu debrief on what had happened to bring them into the new Era. A thousand years of isolation and pain tended to make you groggy like that. But *that* had stuck: The tremble in Mydei's voice. The force of fingers digging into flesh to ensure Phainon remained held in place and would not

disappear. The way his head had rested against warm skin as they escaped the scepter and ascended to the ruined land at Dawncloud’s peak.

Mydei had been the one to carry Phainon into the Era Nova.

And how had Phainon repaid him in the days following? He’d spent every waking moment trying his damned best to avoid him.

And when his attempts had been rendered impossible he had thrown the man into a block of frozen time so that he could flee without the risk of pursuit.

Fleeing had been necessary. Phainon knew that. The risk of doing something irreversible, something fatal, had been narrowly avoided. Staying would’ve been a prerequisite to disaster. Running, on this occasion, hadn’t been spurred by cowardice but by the knowledge that his anger was too hot for any other person to withstand.

Objectively, he knew this

And yet, looking at Mydei now - at the way his brows furrowed, the way concern danced behind his pupils as they locked eyes, no anger present, only *worry,* - it was hard to feel anything but guilt. All he could hear was ‘*foundyoufoundyoufoundyou’* in that same tone, that same trembling exhaustion.

He didn’t want to think about how Mydei had said the words but there was an echo in his ears and he didn't know how to mute it. He wanted to. He wanted to stop it, to cut it out entirely, because that relief was the sort found only alongside affection. The sort of affection that came following the end of a timely wait.

…They had been equals.

Before.

During the cycles.

That had *meant* something. It had *always* meant something.

It hurt to linger on the reason why, though, so Phainon didn’t. Thinking about it would be too much of an admission. The weather was already out of control with his current thoughts, to delve into such ancient and fragile things…

Well. He didn’t want any other coreflames resonating with the emotions bubbling inside of his chest.

“Phainon,” Mydei said now, quietly. There was no relief in *this* word. Just concern. Just something bordering on… well, Phainon wasn’t too sure what it bordered on. He was more focused on the flare of lightning that spread through the room following the sound of *his* name from Mydei’s lips. “It has.”

Silence.

Phainon didn’t know what to say and it seemed, at this point, that neither Mydei nor Castorice knew what to say either. He probably should’ve said something, *anything*, should've convinced them all that he was alright. Maybe even blame the lightning and thunder on… *actual* weather fluctuations and not that of his own influence.

…Yeah, like they’d believe *that.*

They must've remained like that for at least half a minute, silent and unspeaking, before Mydei finally piped up once more. His attention shifted to Castorice as he said, “I just came to check you were alright. Since you are, I’ll let you both get back to your visit—”

A deafening roar of thunder flooded the room.

This time, Phainon didn’t catch the lightning coming in through the window. Instead, it spread across his vision as if his eyes were the source. Tinged with gold and flame, it was his vision - not the room - that was painted with light. Even after the initial flare, it remained, unwilling to fade from sight until he began physically shaking his head in an attempt to dislodge it.

When he lifted his head and looked between both his fellow heirs he found that they had returned to watching him.

Mydei’s gaze flicked from Phainon to the window. Quiet. Contemplative.

Hesitant, he said, “*Or,* I could come inside?”

Nothing. No thunder. No lightning. The room - and consequently Phainon’s vision - remained dimly lit.

Castorice squeezed his hand. She asked, “What would you prefer, Phainon?”

He wasn’t sure.

He wanted Mydei to stay while also wanting him to leave. His thoughts felt fuzzy from the thunder and the way light had caught in his eyes. It was difficult to tell what he wanted or what would be the best route to take - stay or go, what did it matter? He'd spent so long ignoring his own emotions that looking inwards was too difficult. Understanding his own emotions with any depth was impossible. It was already difficult enough figuring out the more superficial thoughts. Understanding his own wants? That was too much. He didn't *know.*

…Although maybe that was a lie. Maybe he *did*.

The storm had only worsened for one option, after all. And it hadn't been over the idea of Mydei *staying.*

Sighing, Phainon squeezed Castorice’s hand in return. The answer was clear, when taking the reactions of the weather into account. He asked, “Do you still have enough for hot chocolate?”

She nodded.

“Can you make enough for three?”

“Of course,” Castorice said. Her smile returned, as if her worry was just as temporary as the lightning outside had been and that there was no longer

any need to fret. “Come in, Lord Mydei. We’re having cocoa - you’ll need to come and pick out a mug.”

Phainon didn’t want to make his friends worry more than they already were so while Castorice went to the kitchen to make another batch of hot chocolate and Mydei went to the bathroom to dry off (and hopefully stop looking like a drenched chimera), he returned to the sofa and proceeded to hug one of the pillows close to his chest.

Another message from Cyrene had found itself to his teleslate, checking in. It was no doubt in response to the worsening storm. The idea of typing anything left him tired and ill-eased so he simply sent a few stickers that hopefully explained the situation well enough to show that he was not in need of rescue.

Now that he’d invited Mydei in he wasn’t entirely sure what to do.

If things continued how they had previously with Castorice then they would settle into a conversation where Phainon didn’t need to be an overly active participant. Castorice could continue telling him about her daily life in the new Era and if Mydei joined in with that then it would be fine.

Probably.

...Who was he kidding? It wouldn’t be fine.

It’d be the awkwardest thing in existence.

If they settled into the same conversation as they had previously then Castorice's shared stories would begin to feel lesser. Not for lack of interest but because their intent would have changed. Instead of sharing for the sake of friendship, the stories would become padding used to cover the wound of everything unspoken between him and Mydei. Phainon didn't *want* her stories to feel less important because of awkwardness. Because

they *weren't.* He didn’t want them to be offered in an attempt to rid the room of the lingering tension that *his* actions had brought.

Which meant that, really, what he needed to do before they settled into conversation as a trio was get rid of that tension. After that, he could go back to a more passive role.

Until that point however, that meant he had to talk.

To *Mydei.*

…

Phainon blinked away static and shoved his face into the pillow in his arms, letting out a long groan. Yeah. He would really rather do anything but open up, actually. The whole avoidance thing might not have been working wonders for his *apparently* poor mental health but at least it helped temporarily.

Okay. Maybe not temporarily. Momentarily. Same difference.

He didn’t *want* to talk.

And yet, hearing the door to Castorice’s bathroom click open, he knew that he was going to do it anyway.

Footsteps padded down the corridor and into the living space. Phainon could feel each step like a vibration against the soles of his feet— courtesy of Georios’ coreflames— and forced himself to look up from his pillow.

In the absence of Castorice’s warmth, without either Stelle or Cyrene around to soothe his mind with their presence, his surroundings were becoming distorted once more. Unreal. Less like reality and more like how videos on a teleslate feed tried to *simulate* reality.

Mydei glanced over momentarily before moving towards the kitchen. He said, “Cas—”

And then: A double-take. One moment he was mid-step and the next he had paused. He pivoted on his foot, turning back to Phainon. His brows furrowed, hair dripping rogue pieces of code onto the ground like water droplets. Footsteps changed trajectory as he approached the sofa.

“Are you crying?” Mydei asked as he stopped by the sofa’s arm. His voice was no louder than a whisper.

Phainon pressed his fingers to his cheeks and found that they were wet. Again. A quick look down showed that he’d left tear stains on the pillow in his arms. He set it down beside him and hoped it would dry soon. Honestly, he wasn’t sure what he was more surprised by: The fact his tears had returned or the knowledge that they had stopped for long enough that Mydei was only asking about them *now*.

He shrugged half-heartedly and said, “Yeah. I don’t really know how to make it stop.”

Mydei said, “I wouldn’t know.”

Ha. *Asshole.*

Despite himself, Phainon let out a wet laugh and wiped at his tears with the back of his hand. “Right. Princes don’t cry.”

“I didn’t mean it like that,” Mydei said and sat on the other end of the couch.

Yeah, Phainon knew that much. Knowing Mydei, the Kremnoan had simply meant that he didn’t stop himself from feeling things - that if he needed to cry then he would. Well, that was alright for him. He didn’t have 33 million cycles worth of hell rattling around in his head or have the need to disassociate to keep from drowning the entirety of Amphoreus.

“I know you didn’t,” Phainon sighed. It was easier to focus on the knitting needles sitting on Castorice’s table than to look Mydei in the eye, so he did, fingers curling in his lap. “I— I’ve been meaning to apologise. For that day. Eventually. I’ve just been…”

Doing bad? Sleeping the days away because the exhaustion had finally decided it wouldn't let him ignore it anymore?

He wasn't sure what to say.

“Apologise?”

Phainon chewed on his bottom lip. His fingers curled more until they were fists. “For… pausing you and the Professor and then leaving you both in that field.” He paused. Pressed his lips in a thin line. “And for what I said to you both.”

Well, alright, maybe mostly what he’d said to Mydei. *He* hadn’t actually done anything to deserve his ire. It was just… Phainon had been so *angry.* When Mydei hadn't taken his side over Anaxa's, he'd felt betrayed and then, when the prince had tried to calm he'd...

Well. He hadn’t wanted to stop.

And it had been easier to air his grievances, to take said anger out on the world and heirs around him, so he had. It probably made him a terrible person but considering all the murder and destruction that wasn’t exactly anything new.

“I didn’t…” He sighed again. The sound caught in his throat alongside a breathlessness brought on by his own guilty admission. “Well… I *did* mean to. But it wasn’t fair of me.”

“The fault is with us. Anaxagoras shouldn’t have been so forceful and I should’ve stepped in sooner than I did.” Mydei said. His voice sounded like syrup. Not in tone but in how the words stuck together as Phainon tried to process them. Difficult to parse. Even more difficult to swallow. “And on that account *I* am sorry.”

Nope. This wasn’t how it was supposed to go.

He forced his gaze up, meeting gold with blue. His eyes were wide, imploring. Perhaps desperate too, as emotion crashed against the insides of

his stomach with enough force to leave him nauseous. He said, “I trapped you both in time. For *days.”*

“Yes.”

“And I was cruel,” he continued. “What I said to you both—”

“Was not as cruel as you think it was,” Mydei interrupted. Phainon let out a noise of indignation and Mydei fixed him with a long stare. “Phainon, you called my immortality fake and then called me pathetic for dying. We have said harsher things to one another during spars.”

…Alright. Good to know that he had some sort of a filter even as the flames of his rage turned everything to dust.

Had he really not said anything more? There had been a *lot* of roiling thoughts and ranting in his head at the time. Phainon had been certain what he’d said was much worse than just that a few comments on immortality and death.

“Your actions did not come across as cruel,” Mydei continued. “Just cornered. And we were the ones who cornered you. That wasn’t fair of *us.”*

Phainon opened his mouth. Tasted blood on his tongue. Closed it again.

A quick glance down was enough to see that reality was fragmenting further around him. Though Mydei wasn’t *actually* bleeding out before him from the gaping wound in his chest - (he hoped so anyway) - Phainon sure could see gore and viscera as if it were truly present.

“Right,” he said and swallowed thickly.

(Titans, he was stupid for letting Mydei come in.

…How long did it take Castorice to make hot chocolate, again? Surely not this long. It felt like it’d been a quint. What was taking her so *long?)*

“And for what it’s worth,” Mydei continued, into the silence, after a brief - not nearly long enough - hesitation. “I’m sorry for dying. Even if it was

prophesied I did not want to leave you to bear everything alone."

'Don't be sorry', Phainon thought, guiltily and exhausted, fists digging into the flesh of his thighs with enough force to bruise. *'I'm the one who killed you.'*

A pause.

Mydei's lips parted in surprise and though his eyes did not widen, his pupils shook. Startled. Mydei was startled by something and staring at him like—

—like—

…Oh *no.*

No.

No. No— Titans, he didn't just say *that* out loud, did he?

"I—" Phainon jumped back, hip catching against the arm of the sofa with such power that it tore a hiss from his throat. A nervous laugh followed, bursting from trembling lips. As unwelcome as the words he'd *apparently* spoken aloud. No. Of all the things to actually admit to why this. Why *murder?* Why the *Flame Reaver?* "I mean—"

He was on his feet before he could think about moving. Lightning caught in his eyes and remained there. Phainon wasn't sure if the thunder in his ears was that of his pulse or the skies outside.

"I didn't say anything—" He gasped. "That was— I'm just— It wasn't—"

A hand caught his wrist like a brand. Phainon tried to yank it away but the hold was firm. As firm as the way Mydei said his name.

"Phainon," Mydei repeated, ignoring the way he was trying to take back words that should not have been said. "Phainon, look at me."

No, he couldn't do that.

Anything but that.

“*Phainon,”* Mydei repeated. “*Nikador above*, listen to me would you? Phainon, I *know* already. I *knew*. I always knew. You don’t— Stop panicking. I already knew.”

Chapter 19

Chapter Summary

if at first you don't succeed, try, try and try again.

Chapter Notes

oh I've been SO VERY hype for this chapter since I started writing it. trust me. trust the process. i hope you all enjoy!!! let me know what you think on this one!!

gumby drew an amazing piece of art from phainon's crash out from chapter 10, pls go take a look, it's *wonderful*

also we broke 5k kudos between last ch's update and this one? holy fuck you guys. thank you very much!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The truth dawned on him all at once.

Harsh and irrefutable, accompanied by a chill worse than that found in the Hyperborean snow plains, Phainon came to the realisation that he was well and truly *fucked.*

Avoidance wasn’t going to help him now. It couldn’t. Because Mydei *knew.*

He knew that Phainon had been his murderer. That he was the one who had cleaved through flesh with a sword as decayed as the rest of him, shattering his tenth thoracic vertebrae and leaving him in a pool of his own blood to die, slow and pained, choking on his final breath.

How?

And *how much* did he know?

How far did Mydei's knowledge go? Did he know only of his death within the 33,550,336th cycle, the one he could remember, or did he know about *all* of them? Had he counted each betrayal in every fragment of shattered bone, seen each death by Phainon's hand? Was he horrified by the sheer number of them, these countless ends that Phainon had issued him?

When Mydei looked at him, could he see how much blood had died into the cracks of his skin?

Phainon had tried to scrub himself free of the memories but these deeds could never be washed clean. Was it obvious? When the Kremnoan looked could he tell how even the hottest of his flames could not permanently burn away the memories?

It felt like he was drowning.

Not in water but in spiralling thoughts. In uncertainty.

Phainon tried to breathe and barely managed a gasp.

"No," he said, a strangled sound of distortion and static. His ears were ringing. A whine rose in his throat, rippling with desperation and pleas.

Not this.

He'd tell them how many cycles he'd passed through. He'd give them details about everything else he had suffered. About Lygus and his experiments. About Nanook and his swordsman and the war he had waged at the end of Amphoreus' code. Anything they wanted to know he would tell them.

Anything but *this.*

Mydei's fingers were still holding his wrist, pressing into the skin with an intensity of a bruise to prove how unwilling he was to let go. And Phainon knew he deserved it, deserved this show of hatred, of unmoving anger, yet he tried to yank free from the prince's hold regardless, vision burning, thoughts melting—

“No,” he rasped again, voice trembling.

He hadn’t meant to say it out loud. The thought hadn’t been one he wanted to share, so why had he? The why didn’t matter, he just needed to find a way to take them *back,* to undo it.

But how could he? Time didn’t work like that, he couldn’t—

Ice slithered down his spine and as the cold spread through him, so too did clarity.

Who was he to say that he couldn’t?

The people of Amphoreus, with the help of Orynyx’s power, could reverse the flow in time of broken objects. With a single coreflame you could - even in this new Amphoreus where time had linked itself to the rest of the observable universe - quicken or slow the rate of growth in plants. With thousands, he had managed to suspend time within a fragment of space.

…And that was only with thousands.

If he used more coreflames… if he used them *all*… would he be able to undo this? Would he be able to take back the words that had slipped from his lips? Take back the admission that had led Mydei to know the truth?

Phainon didn’t have the finesse of someone born to inherit Time’s coreflame, nor the skill to do so with the same ease and understanding, but that didn’t need to mean anything. Who needed finesse when one had brute power?

33 million coreflames of Time remained in his body. If he tried using them then maybe he could rewrite how it had gone. Instead of his instinctive refusal of Mydei’s apology, he could accept it. He could pretend things were fine between them, that he wasn’t a monster, that they wouldn’t all hate him after every monstrous act he had committed.

Ticking echoed in his ears.

“Phainon,” Mydei’s voice, around the moving clock in his ears. “Phainon. Listen to me, I promise—”

A laugh burst from his throat, drowning Mydei’s words out before they could register. He must’ve sounded crazed, like the stress of admission was too much but that was fine. Mydei wouldn’t remember. He’d redo this interaction and then he wouldn’t need to lose him. He wouldn’t have to lose any of them.

He looked up at Mydei, to his worry and dismay, and yanked his arm free.

“It’s okay,” he murmured. His voice sounded distant to his ears. “It’s fine.”

“Yes,” Mydei repeated, desperate. “It’s—”

“I just won’t say it next time.”

Mydei’s eyes widened. “What—”

Phainon took hold of thirty-three million coreflames of Time, took hold of the cosmic clock of *existence* and began pulling the hands *backwards.*

It was nothing like trying to control water. To pull at Time was nothing like dragging at a rippling tide, or picking away at loose threads of space. It was a slow drag, heavy in the way singular atoms were heavy - not in truth but in relativity. Seconds passed in reverse. Words flowed backwards.

The coreflames burning through his body flared. They *pulsed.* Dizzying with their intensity, they melded into one, into something limitless, power expanding doublefold, tenfold, over and over. And yet, the more he pushed anticlockwise on Time’s passage, the more his power intensified, the more it began to feel *wrong.*

Amphoreus strained against him. No, not just Amphoreus - the galaxy. The whole goddamned *universe*.

A burn settled in his chest. His heart was beating in reverse. Blood boiled in his veins as it moved in the wrong direction and as the world spun back on its axis, Phainon found himself unable to breathe.

Power cycled through him in a way antithetical to comprehensible existence.

His vision, rippling with gold, wasn’t able to track the backwards flow of time. His pulse heavy in his ears, wrong and distorted, couldn’t hear the world reversing itself. The only thing proving that things were going back was the reverse of sensation.

A hand shackled around him once more as if he’d never yanked himself free. Because he hadn’t.

Then, fingers lifted from his wrist entirely.

It was difficult to know how long his focus remained on the backwards flow. Could’ve been a second or a year - Time didn’t make sense when it was being physically altered. It stretched and expanded while simultaneously squishing together.

All Phainon knew for sure was that one moment he was pushing everything back and the next he had to let go of time entirely so that he could resume breathing.

Time settled back into motion as if it had never been altered. It did not burst, or run, it simply continued moving in tandem with its natural course. A steady walk towards tomorrow.

Phainon gasped. He swallowed down air like a man starved of it. Legs trembling, he barely managed to keep himself upright. Wavering, the world blurred around him as the burn continued to settle in his bones and electrified each nerve.

A hand caught his wrist like a brand.

It helped steady him, though Phainon knew that was not its intended purpose. He blinked away light and surprise and tried to yank his arm free from the hold. Again, it was firm. Just as firm as Mydei’s voice when he said his name.

Heaving in more air, he stilled.

“Phainon,” Mydei repeated. It hadn’t been possible to hear the concern last time, considering how messy his own thoughts had become, but hearing things a second time made it easier to pick out. It was low. Not quite frantic but definitely tinged with a worry that bordered on the edge of panic. “Phainon, look at me.”

…He hadn’t gone back far enough.

Phainon tore his gaze from the floor to his hands. Despite the burn of his body, the golden sheen to his vision, his flesh was still intact. No outward signs of any burn. His fingertips weren’t flaking away into ash and embers.

There wasn’t even any numbness that typically came from housing the coreflames. From using them.

(Something snarling in the back of his mind remembered being remade under Nanook’s gaze. The Aeon had done something to him. Made it so that his body could withstand the burn. What had They turned him *into?)*

“*Phainon,”* Mydei repeated. “*Nikador above*, listen to me would you? Phainon, I *know* already. I *knew.* I always knew. You don’t— Stop panicking. I already knew.”

The same phrase as before.

He hadn’t gone back far enough but that was alright. Phainon had proven that it could be done. Who truly expected things to work on the first try? They rarely did. That was what trying again was for. If at first you don’t succeed and all of that nonsense.

He could withstand a second attempt. His vision was bathed in gold but the flames hadn’t taken the sense entirely. His body wasn’t fuel for the flames, they had become fuel for *him*. This body, whatever it had been turned into, was clearly capable of withstanding the power usage - it might be uncomfortable but he was clearly capable of surviving it.

“Try again,” Phainon murmured and took a deep breath.

Time began to unfurl.

Mydei’s fingers lifted from his wrist.

His blood had reached a temperature where it no longer boiled but *burned.* His lungs were cracking under the weight of the pressure, of the vacuum created within the gaps of time.

Clearly, the universe did not enjoy being handled with such heavy hands.

…And yet, Phainon couldn’t bring himself to care. Existence could deal with a little bit of clumsy handling.

The more he dragged time back, the more it began to dig its heels into the cosmos and resist. A gasp caught in his throat that was unable to develop in fruition. The pressure upon his shoulders, the weight of reality, was immense. Phainon’s pulse thundered against his eardrums with an intensity near bursting.

The next time he let go of the coreflames, everything was ringing.

When time began to flow once more, Phainon’s legs crumpled.

His heart caught against his ribs like a vice. The muscle squeezed. It whimpered. The only reason he remained standing was because a hand wrapped around his wrist and held him in place.

“Phainon,” Mydei said. Repeated. Phainon hadn’t done anything more than bring them back to this same point in time. Seconds. Millions of coreflames and he could only manage a few seconds? No. He was better than that. If he boosted the coreflames with the power of the others… “Phainon, look at me.”

It was worth a try.

Phainon’s teeth gnashed, molars grinding.

“I can do better,” he gasped and tried again.

On his third attempt, Mydei did not catch him by the wrist but with both arms as his legs gave way beneath him entirely.

That was fine. He didn’t need to be able to stand. He just needed to go back far enough.

“Phainon—”

He just had to try again. If he powered himself with more coreflames then maybe it would work this time.

“Phainon, what—”

Something sharp dug into his head. A lance through the brain. The universe had grown teeth in response to his meddling and had begun biting back, pushing against him with each attempt.

Ha, what a joke. Clearly, the universe should’ve known better. He was used to a little pain. This was *nothing.*

“Phainon, is that—”

This time, Mydei’s voice was louder. Loud enough that Castorice, in the other room, could hear. Phainon heard footsteps padding into the room but it didn’t matter. He didn’t want to hear her worry.

He went back.

“Phainon, what are—”

Not good enough. He’d use more coreflames. All he needed to do was drag time back - he was not its prisoner anymore. Right now he was the one imprisoning *it.*

“Wait—”

Go back.

“—Is that—”

Try again.

“—Are you—”

He had to take the words *back.*

“—bleeding?”

Huh?

Phainon lifted a hand to his nose and sure enough, he was. Golden blood trickled from his nostrils, a smear of it across his lips, dripping from his chin.

“I’m fine,” he said, pushing weakly at hands that settled on his shoulders, supporting his body. “I can just—”

He reached for—

Agony sprang through his body. It wasn’t simply pain but something beyond that. Pain was physical. This was something beyond physicality, something beyond the bundle of nerves that begged for him to stop.

Intrinsic understanding flooded through him. It was not a consequence of using the coreflames themselves. The power he was using sat comfortably within his body but the ricochet of the world around him as he influenced it with their use had begun to tear at him in a way that not even *this* body could handle.

His jaw slammed shut. Too late to catch the cry that tore itself free.

On instinct, he dropped hold of the world around him.

Fingers caught hold of his chin and yanked his head up.

“Phainon,” Mydei said, voice harsh and frantic. His face was pale, pupils trembling as he met Phainon’s eyes. It wasn’t an expression that Phainon

had seen him wear often. Usually, Mydei held himself with more calm. He didn’t panic.

…Why was Mydei panicking?

“Whatever you’re doing,” Mydei said. “Stop it. You’re hurting yourself. You don’t need to, it’s alright.”

“It’s *not* alright,” Phainon gasped. Tears had begun to mix with his blood. “You were never supposed to *know*. I can’t undo it.”

“I always knew,” Mydei said, roughly. “I realised as I was dying. I’ll always know.”

“You *can’t*.” Phainon pulled himself back.

“Why not*?*”

They deserved to know. Realistically, he knew that. This wasn’t something centered just around him, it wasn’t wholly his own truth. They deserved to know who had killed them. The identity of the Flame Reaver. Denying them was cruel.

…But Phainon *was* cruel.

He’d hurt them so much and they deserved to know that. But if they knew then they wouldn’t stay by his side. And as much as he hated them for what they’d placed on his shoulders, as much as he couldn’t always look at them, as much as he didn’t deserve to remain beside them, he loved them so dearly that he didn't care. This cruelty was inconsequential if it meant that he didn't have to bear their hatred.

He wanted to remain by their side so badly and he couldn’t do that if they *knew.*

“Because you’ll *hate me* for all of it,” Phainon shouted. “I killed you. I killed *all of you*. So many times. I don’t— You’ll—”

One final time. He could try one final time. Irrelevant of the pain, irrelevant of everything. He'd use everything. Every coreflame. Every flicker of power to make everything go away. To undo it all.

Mydei stared.

Something caught in his expression. Past the panic. Past the worry and all of the concern.

Sadness.

Deep, unending.

"Hate you?" Mydei said. "Never. Phainon, you know that I l—"

Coreflames rose within him. Every single one.

He tore into time and ripped it open. Threw it into reverse and lashed out at every piece of pressure that existence threw at him. Undo it. He had to undo it, every word. Every admission.

It couldn't happen.

No. Phainon couldn't accept this. He could manage more than a few seconds. He *could.* He just needed to hold onto his breath a little longer. He just needed to deal with the agony, the pain, the suffering. He'd dealt with similar pain over billions of years so why couldn't he do *this*—

He held on until he needed to breathe and then, after that, he held on even longer. Held on until the suffering was too much, until his lungs deflated entirely, until there was no thought of being able to continue for even a moment more.

Time ricocheted.

The universe growled and crashed back into motion. Teeth bared. Daring him to try again for even a second longer. Exhaustion flooded through him with such force that his entire body sagged.

The coreflames, flickering in his body, wavered. Drained and unwilling to respond to the urge of his bones for more power.

Phainon opened his eyes and Mydei was staring.

His eyes were sad. Filled with a sorrow that ran deeper than any other than Phainon had seen him display in the past.

“Hate you?” He said, and something in Phainon’s eyes shuttered. There was no undoing this, was there? “Never. Phainon, you know that I—”

He stopped but this time it was not the backwards drag of time that cut him off.

It was coughing.

Phainon’s coughing. Wet and sickly, into trembling hands.

“*Stop,*” Mydei said, and pulled Phainon into his arms. Briefly, he could hear Castorice’s voice but her words weren’t sinking in. She must’ve been summoned by his shouting. Or maybe it had been before that, when the pain had torn a cry from his lips. “Stop using the coreflames. I don’t hate you. I could never. I told you my weakness for a reason. I always knew it would be you.”

…He must’ve been lying. He had to be.

The sins that he’d accumulated. They couldn’t be forgiven. He was a monster. If he couldn’t undo it then he’d never… They wouldn’t—

“You can’t know,” Phainon repeated. His voice was no louder than a whisper, depleted of all its strength. “If you know then you'll all *leave* and I’ll be left alone.” Something in him cracked. His voice. His mind. “I can’t go back to that again. I *can’t.*”

Silence.

Thickly, Mydei tightened his hold on him and said, “You won’t.”

Around him, a second set of arms wrapped around him. Warmth where previously there hadn’t been. It made the promise feel a little more real.

“Never,” Castorice agreed.

Phainon buried his head into Mydei’s shoulder, leaned into Castorice’s warmth and did not fight the sobs that tore free from the depths of his being.

Chapter End Notes

remember when stelle called phainon insane a couple chapters ago? yeah. well. she wasn't wrong. he's definitely insane.

▶ some notes on the turning back of time in this chapter

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

> after writing this chapter, and being asked on twt whether this fic has a happy ending, i have indeed updated my tags to claim that it does.
>
> this fic is all about healing and while there's definitely a lot of angst going on rn, it's not all pain for pains sake. we will reach a happy end eventually, i promise!! place your trust in me and the process. i'll get us there <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon was still sobbing when the pounding at Castorice’s door began.

It was a heavy sound. Not just in the way the sound reverberated through Castorice’s home but in the way it displaced the warmth and allowed the cold of reality to trickle down his spine. As his friend pulled away, he was left to Mydei’s embrace, coughing up coagulated blood from where it had set in his lungs.

“You’re okay,” Mydei murmured as Castorice’s footsteps padded away from them. One of his hands cradled the back of Phainon’s skull, keeping him close. Not that Phainon had the energy to pull away even if he’d wanted to. “I’ve got you.”

His tears had dried but his blood had not.

The flow had slowed from his nostrils but beads of gold still dripped sluggishly from his chin. Each cough brought up a spray of it. It was difficult to know what exactly he’d done to his body. His pain was absent - not in actuality, (Phainon knew it hadn’t simply disappeared), but because a lifetime of agony simply rendered him incapable of identifying anything that wasn’t pure agony.

“Hyacine’s gonna be mad at me,” he muttered.

Mydei didn’t lie to him. He simply agreed and said, “Yes. A little bit. But mostly she’ll be worried.”

Worried.

Titans, he didn’t want them to be *worried.*

He wanted to say that she didn’t need to be worried, that *none* of them needed to be worried, but he didn’t get the chance because as Castorice unlatched the door he heard Cyrene’s voice, loud and frantic, echoing from the outside corridor, “*Is he still here?”*

Phainon didn’t hear Castorice’s reply but he heard her general tone. Concern attempting to give way to calm.

“I’m coming in,” Cyrene said, footsteps thundering into the room. Something like a gasp caught in her throat as her cold followed her into the room, catching sight of him. While he didn’t want to lift his head from Mydei’s shoulder, Phainon did so anyway.

Her expression was nothing short of thunderous. She stalked closer, ice forming in patches on her skin, frost catching in the gaps beneath fingernails. Every breath came out foggy.

Cyrene took a split moment to assess the state that he was in - the blood, his tears, the weakness that had entered trembling bones - before dropping to her knees before him and placing both hands on his cheeks.

They burned with the force of a shiver. Phainon hissed from the discomfort and tried to pull back but she simply followed after him and did not let go. Instead of freeing him, she lifted his chin until there was no choice but to meet her gaze.

Lips trembling, voice high and *shrill*, Cyrene said, “Do you have *any* idea what you’ve just done? What you *could’ve* done?”

He frowned.

Because no he didn’t.

He didn’t even know what she was talking about.

“You could’ve torn the universe to *pieces,”* she continued. Ice spread in a patch across his cheek. It was so cold that even his own blood, hotter than could ever be described as ‘natural’, froze as well. Mydei’s hold of his body tightened. “Time isn’t meant to go backwards like that. It’s not a *wheel*; It’s like *paper* - if you so much as *touch* it in the wrong way it tears open and *everything* falls apart!”

“You *felt* that?” Phainon murmured.

“Of course I felt that!” She snapped. The force of her voice made him flinch back into Mydei’s chest. “You *can’t* undo time for Amphoreus like that. One wrong move and you desync us all from the rest of the universe. Amphoreus won’t *survive* that. It won’t.”

The cold was too much. He began attempting to peel Cyrene’s hands away, nails digging into icy fingers and trying to rip them away before the freeze settled into frostbite and he stopped being capable of breaking free at all.

“I wouldn’t have done that,” he said, roughly.

“Not intentionally,” Cyrene agreed, “but you almost did. You *could’ve.”*

“No,” Phainon repeated. His voice cracked in defense of himself. “I *couldn’t.* I kept it synced. It wouldn’t have. I’m not an *idiot,* Cyrene. I know — I know enough to understand that breaking a clock is stupid—”

“—Somehow I doubt *that*—”

“—I moved it all back *together!”* He could feel his frustration rising alongside his defensiveness. “But it doesn’t matter anyway because it didn’t work. I couldn’t *do it.* I didn’t manage to—Nothing came of it, okay? I’m not strong enough to— to *break* things like that.”

Cyrene dropped her hands from his cheeks. The sting of cold remained but at least now there was a chance for his skin to thaw.

Then, slowly, she said, “What do you mean you ‘moved it all back together?’”

“I didn’t isolate time or anything,” he said. “I just moved *all* of it back. Nothing would have unsynced itself, I didn’t—” His gaze flicked from her, to where Castorice stood behind them both, picking at her nails in an attempt to keep her panic from showing, to Mydei’s sad eyes and thin pressed lips. “—didn’t do anything that would hurt Amphoreus.”

“Only something that would hurt yourself,” Mydei muttered.

Phainon flinched away from *that* comment as well.

Because that hadn’t been the intention. It wasn’t like he’d known that trying to reverse everything would leave him coughing up blood, body weak and unresponsive. Getting hurt hadn’t been *intentional*. It had just been the consequence of trying.

“Phainon,” Cyrene said, brows threading together. “Did you just turn back time, *multiple times,* for the entirety of the *cosmos?”*

“It didn’t work,” he bit out. “I couldn’t do it. I got— the most I ever managed was a minute. It didn’t *work.* They still *know*.”

“Know what?” Cyrene asked.

Mydei’s voice was a quiet thing in his ear. “About the Flame Reaver.”

For a moment there was nothing but silence. Cyrene continued staring. Castorice tried to look at him - clearly found it too hard - and proceeded to stare at the floor instead.

Then, disbelief began to trickle into Cyrene’s eyes.

“All of this—” She waved her hands up and down Phainon’s body, voice shaking, “—because you wanted to avoid having a *conversation*?”

“That’s not what this was.” He said, though it was obvious to everyone present that he was lying.

“No, it absolutely *is,*” Cyrene continued. Her exasperation leaked free, like the beginning trickles in a broken dam, the calm before the flood. “Do you even know how many things out there would’ve *noticed* you breaking the laws of *time?* The universe is already looking at Amphoreus enough and you’re adding more eyes onto us because you can’t handle talking to your *friends?”*

The words sliced into him like a knife.

“That’s not fair—”

“—It’s the *truth!”* Cyrene cried. “All of these secrets are killing you and you’re *letting them.* Because you, what? You don’t trust that they’d cope with the truth of what happened? This isn’t healthy, Phainon. Can’t you *see that?”*

Of course he could see.

It wasn’t like he was blind to it. He’d said it before to the trailblazer, hadn’t he? He wasn’t doing well - he’d confirmed that with Stelle. *Yesterday*. He knew. How couldn’t he know?

The fact was just that he didn’t *want* to talk about it. He didn’t want to tear things open and suffer more pain when the world already hurt enough. Hurting his friends more wasn’t going to help. It was going to leave him isolated and alone and he *couldn’t* handle that.

It wasn’t about being able to handle a conversation, it was about being unable to survive the aftermath.

They might not currently hate him for the truth of the Flame Reaver but that was just *right now.* Their deaths probably hadn’t sunk in yet. That was all. When it did, when the truth settled in…

“Look,” Cyrene continued, when his silence had stretched for too long. “I understand, alright. It’s hard. It’s—”

Frustration bubbled into anger. Into that same rage that had flooded him before in the field with the professor and Mydei. Into the same fury that had led to the destruction of Aedes Elysiae.

“No, Cyrene,” he snapped, trying to pry Mydei’s hands from his waist so that he could stand. “You *don’t* understand.”

It was such an easy shift in emotion - her ice had carved the warmth from him and now all he felt was cold.

“You only had to *watch,”* he continued. He batted at Mydei’s arms, unable to loosen them but the man wasn’t letting go. The grip didn’t tighten but it wasn’t easing either. “You think that reading about everything that happened equates to understanding how it felt? I had to *live* through everything you read. Every summary. Every scene. Every *chapter.* Over and over and *over and over and over.* How could you *ever* understand that?”

Cyrene reared back as if his words were a slap. He could see her frustration give way to something deeper: To ripples of pain rising from beneath the surface.

She said, “That’s not fair. It wasn’t easy for me either, you know. I didn’t have a choice—”

“I *wish* I hadn’t had a choice!” Phainon’s voice broke into a dry laugh. Or perhaps it was another sob. Whatever it was, it was accompanied with a spray of blood. “You didn’t have a choice on whether to keep going but I *did*. You didn’t have to choose but I *did.* Keep *suffering,* Phainon. Forgo rest for another cycle, *Deliverer*. It’s only a little *pain*, Khaslana! Every single time I *breathed* I had to keep consciously making the same choice. And you think you could *ever* understand that?”

“Well, not entirely but—”

“You told me that it would be a romantic story, Cyrene.” He spat. “But it wasn’t. You *lied.* Where was the romance in all of this? It only ever *hurt.* As you were reading about the cycles, I had to suffer them. It wasn’t

romantic, it was a *fucking tragedy* and it was *your* idea that *put me into them.*”

Cyrene no longer looked like she’d been slapped.

She looked like he’d stabbed right into her chest with Dawnmaker. Eyes blown wide, pain trembling through her body accompanied with the kind of twitch that came from a heavy bleed.

Phainon wanted to feel bad about it but he didn’t. He would, later. But currently all he felt was a thrum of satisfaction that came with hurting someone as deeply as *he* hurt.

“You chose it too, you know.” Cyrene said. Her voice came out small. “There was no other way.”

“*And?”* He snapped, and tried once more to struggle free from Mydei’s hold. Still, nothing. He was utterly trapped. “That’s supposed to make me *feel* better? There was no other way so it doesn’t *matter?”*

“That’s not what I mean! You’re twisting my words!”

He was.

He just didn’t care.

Rational thought wasn’t part of his thinking process anymore. Rationality didn’t matter. He just wanted her to leave him alone. He wanted her to stop *pushing.* He’d been perfectly happy when they’d scarcely talked about everything he'd experienced, when she’d been on *his* side.

“I don’t *care* what you mean.”

Cyrene wiped tears from her eyes, expression growing as frigid as his own. Her brows furrowed and he watched, in real time, as she steeled herself. Pushed her shoulders back and prepared to bite back.

“No,” she said, with growing realisation. “You *don’t* care, do you? You know, *Khaslana,* you were always awful to me whenever you got angry.

Always have been. And yet you never learn from it! Taking things out on me isn't going to make you feel better - I'm just trying to *help."*

His voice settled into a snarl. "I don't *want* your help."

He felt wild. Rabid. Like something trapped in a cage, trying to lash out and break free. She'd pushed him into a corner under the guise of help and now she was trying to make him back down?

Phainon hated her. He truly did.

(It wasn't fair how deeply he could love someone while also despising them. He wanted to carve that care out of his chest but he couldn't. Even after 33 million cycles it still clung to him. He couldn't *stop* caring. That was the problem).

"No, of course not," Cyrene said, coldly. "You don't want *anyone's* help! You'd rather run yourself into the ground! Pretend everything's fine as if you're not consistently questioning reality or destroying everything around you!"

A snarl caught in his throat. No words. Just pure, animalistic *rage*. It flashed across his vision - a deep burn of gold that settled in his eyes and remained there.

And yet, unflinching, Cyrene continued. "What comes next Khaslana? Going to demolish another building because you're a little *angry?* Going to freeze me in time because I'm pushing you a little too much?"

His jaw clenched. Eyes narrowed into a sharp glare.

"Oh, you thought we didn't know about that one?" She asked, "About the fact you tore a building in two because of some argument you were having with absolutely *no one?"*

Heat was flaring in his chest; The increased temperature made Mydei hiss and loosen his arms.

Phainon took the opening, wrestled free and stood to face her eye to eye.

Or at least, he tried to.

He'd barely managed to rise when his legs collapsed beneath him. His breath rattled in his lungs with such intensity that he wouldn't have been surprised if all his blood had collected inside of them. The room was beginning to grow a light shade of grey, blurring at the edges. The world was spinning.

"Shut up," he snarled.

"Or, you know what? How about you just set off to some *other* farming village and spend days destroying it. Why don't you do *that*?" Cyrene snapped. "It's such a *normal* thing for people who are completely *fine* to do!"

"Shut up!"

"You know, I should've listened to Stelle when she told me it was stupid trying to entertain you with all of this!" Frost prowled the floorboards around her, stalking, circling around Phainon as if he were something to be preyed upon. A clash of fire and ice. "I should've never agreed to keep everything about the cycles secret. This whole time I've just been reinforcing your avoidance. The delusion that things will just work out eventually. I'm not doing it anymore."

Phainon's glower burned even brighter. He said, *"What?"*

Cyrene didn't answer. She'd already turned her attention from him to the others in the room. With her chin lifted, she now focused on Castorice, on Mydei. She said, "Do you want to know how many cycles it *really* was?"

Neither Castorice nor Mydei said a word.

"Don't you dare."

She didn't pay him any mind.

Cyrene simply opened her mouth—

(Phainon tried to gather all of the coreflames in an attempt to— to do something, *anything.* To freeze her, to open an infinity gate and throw her elsewhere, to figure out a way to make her *stop*— but each one was exhausted. Each flame was an ember of what it usually was, worn from the push against time and the universe.)

—turned her gaze back on to him—

"Don't," he pleaded, wild and yet so, *so* desperate.

—and said, "*Thirty-three million, five hundred and fifty thousand, three hundred and thirty-six."*

For a moment: Nothing.

Just a buzzing in his ears as her voice echoed against his ear drums. As the world spun. As everything blurred, monochrome and lifeless, around him.

Then the words registered and Phainon choked on the bitter taste of his own anger.

Somehow, he managed to push himself up to his feet.

His body didn't feel like it was truly his. It was moving but it didn't feel like he was the one puppeteering it. When he howled with fury everything felt like it was bordering on distortion.

The only real thing was the wrath that ran through him. The fire running through his chest, that monstrous thing living beneath his skin, the *destruction* singing in his veins.

It didn't feel real when he lunged at Cyrene.

It didn't feel real when Mydei caught him around the waist and pulled him back. Or when Castorice tried to usher Cyrene from the room.

It didn't feel *real* as he fought to break free from Mydei's hold. When his energy began waning once more and his body sagged in place, unable to keep fighting.

The world began to grow more and more grey, everything began spinning like a kaleidoscope, and all Phainon could feel as unconsciousness greeted him was *rage.*

End: Act 1

Chapter End Notes

y'all thought we were further than act 1? we are not.

might take a break from asu for a week or two just to recuperate and update a few of my other neglected fics, but we'll see where my muse takes me!! ofc, if this fic whispers ideas into my ears and i get all the inspiration then we'll just continue as we have been. but if it takes a few weeks for ch21 to be released, please don't panic!

as always - thank you all for reading asu, i hope you enjoyed!!

Chapter 21: Intermission A: Stelle

Chapter Notes

> y'all went fucking feral in the comments section at the end of act 1!! i'm glad you all enjoyed it and thanks for waiting while i took my lil break. happy christmas to those who celebrate it! and hope you all have a happy new year!
>
> i'm excited to open act 2 in the new year. until next time, please enjoy this intermission chapter!

Considering how the simulated universe was currently breaking around her, code stuck inside of some sort of self-perpetuating bug, Stelle probably should've been worried. Or anything on the wrong side of nonplussed.

And yet she was not even *plussed*.

The simulated universe was stuck in a ripple of repeating code or whatever and instead of being worried or dismayed, she was one very, *very* happy trailblazer.

After all, the best thing about testing Herta's simulated universe wasn't the fact that she got to learn more about the Aeons or test her might in battle. (Though of course, the battles did scratch an itch at the back of her brain in all the best ways). It wasn't even the rewards that Herta dished out following each run in an attempt to have instant gratification bring Stelle back another time.

No, none of that.

The best bit about testing the system, with its advanced coding and intrinsic detailing on a cosmic scale, was the fact that sometimes, on occasion, despite everyone's best efforts, the system broke in such fantastic ways that it left her grinning wildly for *days.*

Considering how many genius society members worked on the project it was a very rare thing to witness.

But oh boy, *oh mama,* whenever the simulated universe broke? Literal *shivers* ran down her spine and Stelle felt herself ascending to some heavenly plane.

Perhaps that was why, at first, the break was so utterly satisfying.

It was an unfolding thing. At first glance, it even seemed to be a simple break. The kind of error that was intentional, entered by Stephen Lloyd in the hopes of making the entire game more *fun.* Another negative curio perhaps, or maybe, if highlighted under Stelle's gleeful eye: a positive one.

Because when Stelle had taken her trusty baseball bat to the Xianzhou vase in the game's current domain, the vase had simply… pieced itself back together again a few seconds later.

Perfect! Ten out of ten!

If this was intentional then she'd order room service - er, whatever equivalent delivery service existed on Stephen's planet (wherever that was) - and send the man several litres of watermelon parfait.

This meant that she could destroy the thing a *second time.* In her books this was a complete *score.* It was basically like winning the lottery except kind of sadder and with a whole lot more chance for kintsugi. She'd get double the credits, a little closer to buying some higher star blessing the next time she reached the store, and then go on her merry way into the next domain.

You know, the whole *shebang.*

Stelle lifted her trusty bat and swung a second time.

Eh. It wasn't as good a hit as her first. Probably wouldn't have made it to second base even with her skill as a baseballer. Kind of disappointing, actually. The shatter had been more muted - not too many shards left

behind. It was kind of like both she *and* the vase simply didn't have the energy to go full pelt in the whole destruction process.

Oh well! There would always be the next one.

Stelle shrugged and rolled out her shoulder. There was no point taking any of this too seriously.

Then she blinked. And the vase was back to being in one piece again. And maybe it should've been strange but wasn't there a whole saying about how good things came in threes? Clearly this was a sign from some higher being - or, probably just four geniuses - that she should try again.

So she did.

It was a hit that truly resembled her role as the galactic baseballer. From the ease of the hit to the swing of her arms. A thing of pure asymmetry accumulating in the most spectacular smash of varnished pottery. The hit sent a ricochet along her bones and shards scattering across the floor in the way that only a truly *delightful* smack could. The smash sounded damn near *angelic.*

It wasn't just a hit.

It was a whole fucking homerun.

"And that, ladies and gentlemen," Stelle said, voice practically dripping with self satisfaction as she swooped her arms into a majestic bow, "is how it's done."

Silence.

It was nice to see that even the smartest minds across the cosmos knew to take a moment to bask in the truly amazing things that life offered. She felt like a cat that had successfully swiped a glass off of the counter.

Then she blinked.

And the vase was back in one piece.

Alright… so maybe now even *she* was thinking about how that was a little weird. Usually the geniuses put a limit on this kind of thing if it were intentional. And if it wasn't, then they'd have fixed the error by now.

…Maybe breaking the vase a fourth time would help?

Stelle raised her bat and went for a second homerun. It was less impressive the second time though still a thing of art. But that was fine. Now she could be doubly sure that the geniuses had seen her act of awesomeness.

She blinked.

The vase was back. *Together.*

"*...Huh."*

Maybe the geniuses were distracted by something else? If they weren't fixing the problem then they must've been. Maybe one of them had found the Genius equivalent of a really cool bug and were currently busy pointing it out to the others. Like… oh, she wasn't sure. Something even smaller than an atom. Or whatever smart people found more interesting that the tests they'd *asked her to carry out for them.*

Ahem.

No, yeah, Stelle was totally cool. She was chill. If anything, she could keep farming credits like this until they got back. Might as well make the most out of the break. Maybe it was cheating the system, but was it *really,* when the system was letting her do this in the first place?

She broke another.

Then, because the broken pieces merged back into one full thing all over again, she did it again. Though this time, instead of using her bat, she simply stomped her whole foot through the middle as if the thing were made of cardboard and—

And it wasn't *broken.* It was in *one piece.*

“Ughhh…” She was getting bored, now. “Well, this was fun an’ all, but I was promised an adventure domain and Mama’s ready to swing at a couple of trotters so…”

She turned—

—and she was looking at the same reconstituted vase.

“Whoa,” Stelle murmured, eyes widening like dinner plates. “That’s trippy as fuck.”

It was becoming pretty clear that whatever *this* was, it was more than a simple break in the ones. It wasn’t just a little error in the zeroes. Stelle broke the vase a couple more times, as if shattering the damn thing an even twelve times would fix the issue, tried (and failed) to run from the vase at least five times and then started yelling at thin air in an attempt to get the genius’ to notice her plight.

When they didn’t, she checked her credits. She must’ve been *loaded* after all of this, right? It might’ve been a looping hell of broken vase that wasn’t freeing her but at least she was getting paid for her efforts.

…

…Or she fucking *wasn’t??*

After all the broken vases she should’ve had a whole lot more than 262 credits, right? She’d shattered so many! She was stuck in a perpetual loop of code that wasn’t letting her go. She deserved monetary payment for how much this actually *sucked.*

Was she getting a minimal amount of credits? Was she even getting any at *all?*

This time, when she broke the stupid thing again, she kept her gaze on the little bar to the side of her vision that displayed her credit count. Net gain of 54 credits. Yeah, that was more like it. Maybe this was just a small error applied to the rest of the systems issues.

The stupid thing reformed itself.

And before her eyes, Stelle watched the credits she'd gained disappear as if they'd never been accumulated in the first place. Back down to 262.

"What the actual fuck." She breathed. "These geniuses are trying to short change me!"

Rather embarrassingly, it took her three more broken vases to realise that she was caught in a time loop. Which sucked way more than being perpetually broke. Stelle didn't *want* to be in a timeloop. She had first hand knowledge that being in one fried your brain and made your thoughts all gooey and nonsense-like!!

No thank you, Sir.

She'd been all too happy leaving the time shenanigans to her friends on Amphoreus. She hadn't signed up for this. No terms and conditions had been signed. No waivers. No disclaimers. None of it!

Absolutely. The. Fuck. Not.

It felt like she'd been stuck in this loop for *forever* by the time Herta's avatar appeared and her voice echoed in her ears.

"We're ending the test here for today," Herta said. Her avatar was frowning. Stelle hadn't even realised it could *do that.* "We're pulling you out."

Ten minutes later, Stelle was sat in the world's best spinny chair watching as the geniuses talked about temporal distortions of Aeonic proportions over the world's most holographic Teams call.

Surprisingly, she'd yet to be kicked out. She'd kind of expected to be waved to the door and sent on her merry way.

Instead, one of Herta's puppets had pressed surprisingly firm hands on her shoulders until she'd plopped herself down on her current chair and began spinning. She'd been spinning for long enough now that she was beginning to feel a deep sense of vertigo. The dizziness was almost as insane as the time loop.

Or, er, well it *wasn't* but that was fine.

"We're not just talking about a single *photon*, people," Herta said, her lips pulled thin. "Rewinding the quantum state of a few photons is child's play. Anyone could do that. What we just experienced was the rewinding of multiple pockets of space."

"Query," Screwllum said, from beside her, "multiple pockets of space indicates this phenomenon was centralised to set areas of the cosmos. Compiling current synchrotron radiation reports from the network will allow for defined locations to be sourced."

"Stephen says he's already looking into them," Herta said. "According to the reports—"

Yeah. It was all a lot of technobabble that kind of went over Stelle's head. She didn't even know what *synchrotron radiation* meant. They were trying to source the time loops and stuff, right? That was all she needed to know right now.

She'd ask Herta for the simple version when they were all done geeking out over this entire Time thing.

For now, she was going to catch up on her sweet, *sweet* screentime. Silly memes and texting friends from across the cosmos sounded much better than trying to make sense of all the sciency stuff.

She was just about to put on Guinaifen's latest stream when an incoming message caught her attention.

Cas~

33,550,336???

Oh wow. Consider Stelle impressed. She'd really not thought her precious partner capable of taking the first step into telling the truth. If anything, she was expecting to have to tell everyone the truth herself when the Astral Express returned to Amphoreus.

Galactic BB

oh wowza

phai-boy told you guys already??

The response was not immediate. Which probably should've made her feel a sense of foreboding but well, she'd just gotten herself out of a different foreboding situation so it didn't really register.

Cas~

Um. Well…

Not quite.

Another pause. Stelle continued watching the three dots of doom jump in synchronised waves as Castorice continued typing. Yeah, something had *definitely* happened while she was gone.

Cas~

It was Cyrene who told us. (Us meaning Mydei and I.)

I thought you'd be able to confirm the number since we weren't sure how truthful she was being at the time.

Galactic BB

phainon didn't confirm it?

Cas~

Uh.

No.

He did not.

Galactic BB

figures

man's too fragile to admit that number right now

i told him he was a silly bean for not telling but you know how it is amiright?

…just make sure to give him all the hugs

babygirl needs hugs and love

maybe a boop on the nose too for being so silly

silly bean gonna bean. u kno??

Cas~

I don’t think he wants hugs and affection right now but I’ll keep that in mind.

Galactic BB

that’s a load of shit

my boi always wants hugs!! he’s like the supreme lover of hugs

man was absolutely a koala in another life

Cas~

I don’t know what a koala is but do they ever get so enraged they try to attack their fellow koalas?

Stelle paused.

Frowned.

And stared at the screen.

She was seeing the words but they didn’t make any plausible sense. Phainon was crazy as fuck, yes, but not in the way of outwardly attacking his friends.

…

Okay, so he *had* killed them millions of times but that was within the cycles. He wasn’t the type to get so openly angry that he’s start attacking people outside of the need for deliverance. And even if he *were* the type that was the kind of thing that people scaled up to! It didn’t just *happen.*

Stelle had literally spent her afternoon talking to him.

He’d not been fine but he wasn’t losing his mind with anger. He’d been disassociating pretty badly, but he’d been hanging in there. Arguably, he’d

even made progress!! He'd realised things were shit and that he was living the life of a meme. How could things have gotten so fucked in such little time? It hadn’t even been a *day.*

Galactic BB

Tell me everything that happened.

Twenty minutes later, Stelle clicked her phone onto standby and looked up at the geniuses. They were still going at it except now their technobabble felt far more relevant to her specifically than it had before.

And more urgent too.

“—Not many powers capable of reversing time for the entire *cosmos*. With such a lack of technique the sheer *power* required was—”

“Uh,” Stelle said. “Herta? Screwllum?”

Herta waved a hand in her direction, dismissive.

Not one to be dissuaded by this, Stelle tried again. She said, “I actually have an update on all of this that might help?”

Screwllum turned to her first. He’d always been the most lenient of the geniuses. Always ready to hear out the words of those who hadn’t quite ascended to the levels of genius. To indulge Stelle whenever she spoke up.

If only because her partner had turned, Herta did too. She said, “Oh this had better be worth it. Yes, little one?”

“Okay,” Stelle said. And told herself to get straight to the point. (She didn't). “So, I maybe have good news for you. But… well, maybe it’s the type of good news that very quickly morphs into bad news? Depends on how deeply you think about it actually. You could make rabbit holes out of

this kind of news. It’s kind of cosmically fucked, if you think too closely about it—”

Herta scowled. “Out with it. The adults are talking.”

“I know who did the whole messing with time thing.” Stelle said. “Do you remember Phainon?”

“That delivery boy who merged with Irontomb. You think he did this?”

“Um, I mean, he *did* do it.” Stelle licked her lips. Her throat suddenly felt very parched. “Uh. So he kept all the coreflames, in the end, and I guess he’s strong enough to rewind time? And he’s like... *batshit* on the insanity meter so he’s also crazy enough to actually try to do it? So, yeah.”

Herta narrowed her eyes.

Then she said, “How *interesting*.”

Chapter 22

Chapter Summary

Act 2, start.

Chapter Notes

Happy New Year!! unless i've accidentally clicked the 'upload' button by accident prior to it turning midnight in my timezone like i'd intended, then here i am, opening 2026 with ASU's second act!!

i know the holiday season can get busy and the likes, so if you've missed the update for the intermission chapter (ch21), please go back and read that one first!!

either way, welcome to ASU Act 2!! lets have fun with this one, shall we?

▶ Some TWs for the chapter's opening scene.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Are you aware of fatalism, *Lord Khaslana?"*

Burning ash clung to the back of Phainon's throat but through the grit and debris he managed to bare his teeth and snarl. The intellitron did not pay any mind to the warning nor to the glob of blood and soot that was spat at his feet as he approached, footsteps clacking against the silence.

Lygus, ever the type to enjoy the sound of his own voice, did not require any answer to continue speaking.

"As it is unlikely that you remember everything that you were once taught in the Grove of Epiphany," he said, "let me refresh you on the topic."

Another snarl. This one was wilder than the last. Driven by the act of Lygus kneeling before him and hauling Phainon into his arms. Phainon tried to shove him away but he was currently one arm down, bleeding out, and trembling in the aftermath of having had an Aeon's gaze focused on him for what had felt like an eternity.

Blood gushed from the stump of his right arm. It ran in rivers down his back.

Phainon had minutes at most before he bled to death and it was becoming apparent that those final moments were going to be stuck listening to fucking *Lygus* of all people.

"It is," Lygus continued, as he began to walk, "at its core, the philosophy that every action, every event, that has taken place within either the past or future is a fixed *inevitability.* What has passed cannot be altered and what will pass cannot be changed."

Phainon kept kicking, trying to break free.

Unaffected, Lygus simply continued to move. His steps were measured and even, as if Phainon's attacks did not so much as scratch the outermost casing of his body.

"This system of determinism is not purely contained within the branch of cause and effect, where one choice influences that which proceeds it but works to the understanding that no matter *what* action is taken within the present, the future cannot be changed."

"What the fuck are you even *talking* about?" Phainon spat.

Lygus tilted his head down.

Though there was little expression to be seen on such an inorganic face, the cheer in his voice was downright *giddy.*

"Ah," he said, "so you *are* listening."

Phainon wanted to melt him. To tear into him entirely. He'd decapitated this parasite 33 million times but it had never been enough to temper his fury. He didn't just want to kill him, to destroy him, he wanted to erase every single atom of his existence from the universe.

"Well, far be it for me to keep you from understanding," he continued. "Let me offer you further insight on this philosophy. Hm... Since the great *Imperator* enjoys it so much, let me expand on this concept using chess as my example."

Footsteps crunched against gravel.

"The set up of the board - the past - can never be altered. Within each game, every piece must always start from their fixed point. The pawns will always be placed on the second and seventh rows. The rooks and bishops have their set places on the first and eighth. Just like the set-up, the outcome of the game - the future - also remains the same: No matter what moves one makes, the game will always come to an end."

They were heading somewhere. Moving with *purpose.*

"Of course, you might ask what happens if you simply decide not to move the pieces."

…*Where* were they going?

"A game of chess cannot be won or lost if it does not proceed. This changes the outcome does it not? The game cannot *end* if you do not even begin."

Wait. No.

Phainon *knew* this path. An uphill climb through mountains that loomed over Okhema like the curl of a closed fist.

"If you remove the game entirely, does that not… *negate* the entirety of this fated end?"

It wasn't the rise of dawncloud but the route still led to the same place.

“And yet, by not starting, that eventuality has already come to pass.”

The Dawn Device.

“The game ends because you do not play.”

The scepter’s core.

“The game ends because you *do* play.”

Lygus was bringing him to the scepter’s core.

“Your actions, however resistant, cannot rework the outcome.”

Where they were going suddenly felt more daunting than it had before.

Phainon should’ve questioned it more from the very beginning. What use would Lygus have had for his corpse unless he was going to *use* it in some way? He kicked out with what little strength remained in his chest, burned as hot as the coreflames would allow him in this dying form of his and *screamed*.

No one heard him.

How could they? They were all dead.

The only person who could hear him was *Lygus,* who continued speaking as if Phainon’s efforts were meaningless, as if his shouting was nothing more than a futile whisper.

“These cycles… this eternal recurrence that we have been living within these past millennia… why Khaslana, they’re much the same as that game of chess.” He didn’t even raise his voice to speak over the shouting. He spoke with the casual certainty of a being that had *won*. “Our starting point remains fixed and your efforts within each attempted cycle - while a fickle yet *admirable* determination - has done nothing to hinder Irontomb’s completion. Our end point remains the same.”

He could see it now.

The Dawn Device.

Space wasn’t operating in the way that it typically did. Each step warped reality, bringing them closer to the scepter. They weren’t approaching by foot. Not really. Lygus was using his permissions as Amphoreus’ administrator to speed their travels into something that *felt* incomprehensible.

“This was always the destined end to our game,” Lygus said, as he stepped through rippling *nothingness* and came to a stop before the scepter. “It could never be avoided.”

The ascent into the scepter was only possible through the tear of code. Lygus, in control of the system as he was, lowered the firewall without so much as blinking and tore open a hole so that they could pass through.

He did it so easily that the breath in Phainon’s lungs shuddered out of him.

He had attempted to break through this firewall over 33 million times and not once had he ever so much as made a dent. And yet, here Lygus was, lowering it without even an afterthought.

Amphoreus…

It really was too cruel.

The inside of the scepter was a distortion of ones, zeroes, wiring and dim, red lighting. The closer they got to the centre, the more the wires bulged and writhed. Something both alive and mechanical. Undulations spread through each tube like a pulse.

…So this was Irontomb.

“I truly must thank you,” Lygus said, when they reached what must have been Irontomb’s innermost core and he set Phainon down upon a throne of cables. “Your cycles, designed to stop a lord ravager, have served to develop the rage of yours that will fuel it.”

Something pierced into his shoulder blades - through the open wounds where his wings had once been. A scream tore through Phainon's throat.

"The coreflames that you have collected for so long, in an attempt to keep Irontomb from gaining strength, will now become the power source of its beating heart."

More pain. Veins of copper and iron scraped against skin, tearing him open. No; It wasn't tearing him open. It was *latching on*.

This was not an attempt to eradicate. It was an attempt at assimilation.

"With this," Lygus said, "not even our *guests* from the Astral Express will __"

"Do you ever *stop fucking talking?"*

"Yes, there are the flames of hatred that have been stoked over 33 million cycles." Lygus' voice sounded damn near serene as laughter crackled from his vocal box. "Oh Khaslana, you have been an *excellent* player in our little game."

Something burst through skin and grabbed hold of his spinal cord. Phainon's body fell limp, unresponsive, as whatever had broken through infected his nerves and cut off every connection.

"But this checkmate of mine was always *inevitable*."

Phainon woke in much the same manner that one got hit by a rampaging dromas: Suddenly and with very little understanding of the moments that preluded it.

His body ached with such ferocity that, for a split moment while his waking mind remained foggy and unclear, he could entertain the idea that he actually *had* been hit by such a creature.

Then he registered the wires.

It was a sudden realisation of sensation. Alongside the inhale of a half-formed gasp, his nerves picked up on his entanglement.

Wires ran along his chest, they shackled his wrists and ankles. One ran along the curve of both ears and pressed against his nostrils. Into the crook of his elbow and into the veins on the back of his hands *and*—

And this couldn’t be Irontomb.

He’d been ripped out, hadn’t he? And yet as his eyes flashed open, there was a shimmer of red across his vision and through rippling code he could see wires pulsing, he was *inside of the machine.* His pulse mimicked that of the cables, his nerves firing alongside internal sparks and moving cogs. Helpless. *Again*.

Had he ever truly left? Had everything just been another cruel game designed by Irontomb to make him give up on Amphoreus? To stop fighting, to—

The sound of strings met his ears. Synthetic strings. Not the kind that could be found in Amphoreus, but the kind that had been streamed previously on one's teleslate after connecting to the datastream of the wider galaxy.

No, this was real.

He wasn’t inside of Irontomb because Irontomb had been defeated. He’d helped the Trailblazer fight against it from within the scepter’s core, taking small allowances of rogue code to manifest an avatar of himself that could fight back alongside his companions. That had *happened*. He wasn’t trapped inside of the Scepter anymore.

The glitching code faded alongside the dawning realisation. Reality returned. And Phainon found, in its place, a rather lacklustre ceiling painted off-white, peeling at the edges with patches of broken, spalled concrete.

…He was still entangled, though.

Something venomous clawed its way out of his throat. Not a snarl nor a growl but something filled with disdain and disgust. The sound reverberated through his body; Fingers twitched. His stomach clenched.

Ah.

Entangled, yes, but clearly able to move to *some* extent. It wasn't necessarily the wires that were holding him down but the fact that his own limbs felt like the bones inside had been swapped with lead.

Fuelled with his own rage and the stubbornness that had lasted him billions of years, Phainon did not let the heaviness of his body keep him frozen in place. Even as the ache burned, even as the weight of his joints pulled against muscles, he fought to lift himself up.

He managed. Partially. His torso aching as he lifted himself up on shaky arms.

He didn't quite manage to sit up but that was because his legs weren't solely weighed down by his own aching bones. There was an external weight pinning them in place too.

Phainon paused.

Just for a moment. Just while the truth of the external weight pinning him in place registered. Just as the truth of where he *was* settled in his mind.

He was in the hospital. Or, at least, the pop-up hospital that Hyacine had been running from the halls of a repurposed school building since the beginning of the Era Nova. At his bedside, sat on one of the stupidly small chairs designed for children, and looking just as stupid as Phainon had, was Mydei.

Except, he wasn't currently sitting. He was slumped over the side of Phainon's bed, using both the curve of his own arms and Phainon's legs as a pillow. Snoring. His braid fell across his face, messy and loose.

…Any other time, Phainon would find it cute. Would've let him sleep.

But he *needed* these wires *off of him* so he reached behind his head for his pillow and hurled it at Mydei's head with as much force as his tired bones could muster.

Part of him was surprised that Mydei didn't see it coming. That his hand didn't reach up and catch it midair.

(He shouldn't have been, considering Mydei was *sleeping*, but he was.)

Instead, the pillow careened into the prince's temple with a heavy thud.

Mydei didn't spring up onto his feet the way that he had during the cycles,whenever Phainon had woken him in a similar manner but he did jolt back into consciousness quite suddenly.

The prince of Kremnos - or was he technically the king? Phainon wasn't too sure which title they were operating off within the Era Nova considering it was also influenced by a cycle that he'd never existed within - unfolded his arms and claimed the pillow in his hands. He raised his arm as if, for a split second, he had considered hurling it back at the person who had rudely awoken him.

Then, the cogs of his brain kicked into gear and, seemingly realising whose pillow this must've been and the perpetrator behind his sudden awakening, Mydei placed it gently on the bed beside him and lifted his head. Wide eyes settled onto Phainon, bleary with sleep.

"You're awake," Mydei said.

"Yeah, no *shit*," Phainon said, struggling to sit up now that Mydei was no longer trapping his legs in place. His voice was rough and scratchy from disuse. How long had he been asleep this time, he wondered, before deciding that actually, he *really* didn't care.

"How do you fe—*What* are you doing?"

What he was doing was detangling himself. Pulling himself free. He'd wrapped his fingers around one of the wires on the back of his hand and

yanked. Past some initial resistance, it came free with little difficulty, accompanied with an ooze of dark gold blood.

He didn't have a moment to reach for the wire on his wrist - this one was clipped on to something stuck against skin, some sort of monitoring… *thing*, not something that had pierced the skin like the first - when Mydei's hands clamped around his wrist, holding it in place and pressed the edge of his blanket against the bleed.

"*Stop—*"

"Don't pull those out," Mydei scolded.

Phainon narrowed his eyes and snarled. "I'm not staying wired up, Mydei. Let *go*. I need them *off.*"

He wasn't sure whether it was a testament to Mydei's patience or his stupidity but the prince did not let go. His hold remained firm.

"You can't just pull them out without *hurting* yourself," Mydei said.

"*Off, Mydeimos,*" Phainon snapped. "Get them *the fuck off of me—*"

"I will," Mydei said, and clearly it was both patience *and* stupidity that currently drove him fuelled him. "We'll get them off. But at least do it safely. Let me help you. Let *Hyacine* get rid of the cannulas so you don't bleed out everywhere."

Phainon grit his teeth and glowered.

He wanted to fight back and kick out but that would only leave him entangled for even longer. It wouldn't free him from everything like he needed to be. So even though his heart was beating rapidly and the beginnings of a brawl was collecting in the gaps between his nerves, he held still and nodded.

Once. Reluctantly.

"*Quickly,*" he said, tone biting.

To be fair to him Mydei *did* act fast. He unclipped wires from sticky tags on his wrists, from his chest and beneath his clavicle. Even from above his ankles. As he did so, a machine he hadn't noticed began whining like a flatline. It was a high and tinny sound. Instantly grating. The kind that left the ears ringing.

Phainon let out a hiss at the sound. "Shut it up."

"No," Mydei said.

"It's too *loud."*

"Exactly. This way, someone will hear and I won't need to leave you to find Hyacine."

When he'd finished removing those wires - and subsequently peeled away the tags from his skin - Mydei helped prop Phainon up against the bed more comfortably. Afterwards, his hands hesitated at either side of his ears, hovering over the wires of his nasal cannula.

"Hyacine said this one helps you breathe more easily," Mydei said.

"My lungs are working fine," Phainon's brow twitched. Yes, his lungs felt like they'd been scraped raw with gravel but that wasn't any different from the rest of him. "*Take. It. Off."*

"Stubborn man," Mydei sighed, but removed it anyway.

With everything else removed, all that remained were the two lines that fed into his body. One piercing through the veins on the back of his other hand. Another burrowing into the crook of his elbow.

"I'll message Hyacine," Mydei said, when Phainon's fingers began twitching again with the need to rip himself free. He could feel them moving inside of him. Pulsating. "Just— Wait. A little bit."

And yet, because Mydei had told him to, Phainon waited.

He waited until Mydei retrieved his own teleslate from a counter beside his bed - ah, *that* was what was streaming the music from beyond Amphoreus - and began typing.

No. It was too similar to the time trapped in Irontomb. He couldn't handle it.

He reached for the line on the back of his hand—

"Hks," Mydei snapped and grabbed hold of his hand before he could begin yanking himself free. "What did I *just* say?"

Phainon's voice trembled with the force of the fire in his chest. He said, "I don't care, I don't *care,* get them *out, get them out—"*

They continued like that. Phainon's voice repeating the same words, a mixture of frantic need and broiling anger.

Mydei half on the bed, holding onto Phainon's wrists, unflinching, *unyielding.* Repeating that Hyacine would *be here soon* and that he was on Phainon's side but unwilling to allow *'being on his side'* to be read as *'entertaining your self-destructive tendencies.'*

It must've taken no more than two minutes for Hyacine to come rushing into the room, little Ica accompanying after her, and yet it felt like an age.

She was already pulling on gloves as she passed through the doorway.

He could *feel* something festering under his skin from the wires. From Irontomb. From— From something, he just didn't know *what*. Get them out. Get it *out.*

"I'm here, I'm here," she said, somewhat frantically. "Phainon, De said you wanted your cannulas taken out. I'll do it now. Can you both *please* stop fighting?"

Mydei gave him a look that very clearly read as, *'Well? Your call, Khaslana.'*

Phainon let out a heavy, rattling breath and slumped back against the wall. The wall suddenly seemed the most interesting thing in the world, with its peeling paint and singular crack running through the concrete.

“Whatever,” he breathed and swallowed down the poison that was burning the inside of his throat.

Chapter End Notes

- a quick ramble about ASU acts

Chapter 23

Chapter Notes

> *ahem ahem* i guess my brain truly made me take that break huh? anyway. but!! i'm back! not sure whether i'll be able to do weekly updates for a bit since life has gotten busy and stressful but we'll see what i can manage! please be patient with me!!
>
> thank you to everyone who left comments, you all make my day so much brighter!!
>
> ▶ TWs for those who need it. PLEASE heed the TWs!!

Though the back of his hands were bruised in shimmering gold - one far more deeply than the other - and the crook of his elbow was splotchy with additional tints of viridian green, Phainon felt considerably better once the cannulas were *out* and his body was freed from the writhing plastics of medical whatever-the-fuckery.

His anger was still present, of course. And he stared at the ceiling with gritted teeth, jaw stiff in the way that gears became after grinding their way into a jam, determined to ignore the pair of Chrysos Heirs that remained by his bedside.

But he *was* calmer.

Whatever the hell *calmer* meant when one’s rage was an unending, lethal thing.

It wasn’t going anywhere. That much was a certainty that couldn’t be denied. As Phainon stared at flecks of old paint on the ceiling he felt it sizzling inside of his chest, a prowling thing. Like the predator it was, it stalked through his blood and bubbled beneath the surface. Ready to rise at any moment, it had been unleashed by the cycles, unshackled by Cyrene’s *betrayal,* and now waited for the perfect moment to strike. Within it, the

rage was patient in much the same way that a hammer was patient before it struck the nail.

Phainon tried to wrangle it. Tried to collar the feeling and muzzle the wildness inside of him. But the more he tried to push it away until later, the more he tried to bargain that he would deal with the emotion *eventually,* the more it pushed back against him.

His brow twitched with every failed attempt at suppression.

The fury refused to be silenced. Within each heartbeat he could feel it murmuring to him, *'When will 'later' come, Khaslana? You cannot keep pretending that your feelings do not exist.'* It was a soft murmur, a gentle croon, where the feeling should've been sharp. Inviting in much the same way that a thunderstorm was in the beginning when accompanied by the sound of pitter-pattering rain against sealed windows.

Phainon inhaled sharply and bit his tongue.

He had to.

If he did not hold it in place between his canines, if he did not catch it between half-gritted teeth, then he'd respond to the impossible caress of words that his anger was providing him. He would respond and then…

Another thing not to think about. There could not be a *'then'*. There could not be any release of anger, there was only *later*. There was only the hold of air within his lungs until they began to burn. And then, once the burn caught: An exhale. A long thing that dragged deep even after he'd depleted all the breath within, leaving him light-headed and the world off-grey.

His guests allowed him time to collect himself. How *thoughtful* of them. How *kind* of them to wait until his panicked breathing shifted through anger and into a more steady, rasping rhythm. How *courteous* of them to remain, to wait and *watch* in silence as he went through the process of clenching and unclenching his fists around clumps of blanket in an attempt to work through the restless energy burning him up from the inside.

Calm.

…He could be calm.

And then Hyacine murmured, “I really do think that oxygen would help with your breathing. The nasal cannula—”

And really, it had been a lie to ever believe that he was capable of calmness. Steady breathing wasn’t the counterbalance to flames - oxygen only ever *fanned* them. Wasn’t that the basics of fire safety or something? Stupid. Ridiculous.

All of this was *ridiculous.*

What was the point of this? Of *any* of it?

Phainon’s glare settled onto her with the suddenness of a gunshot. He growled, *“No wires.”*

Hyacine jolted under the weight of his stare. Her lips pressed together in a thin line and Phainon had to tear his gaze away and up, back up to the flaking ceiling - what a joke of a hospital this was, makeshift or not, why was it falling *apart?* - before he could read too much into her concern.

Another breath. Deeper this time. It dragged in much the way one inhaled smoke from a cigarette except he wasn’t trying to swallow down nicotine, he was trying to settle the rising venom in his chest before it started bubbling from his lips.

Beside him, a heavy weight settled on the bed by his legs. His blankets drooped beneath the weight as Little Ica’s wings drooped along the curve of her back and the pegasus plunked herself against his waist, letting out small nickers. Instinctually, he cast his gaze down to her. Small, beaded eyes looked up at him. Ica blinked, slow and thoughtful, before tilting her head so that it rested against his thigh.

Phainon scowled but when he lifted his hand it was to run his fingers along her mane and not to push her away.

He continued to breathe. In, out. Mouth closed. Calm. Be *calm.*

“Alright,” Hyacine said, into the growing silence. “What if it was a mask?”

“No.” His voice was rough as gravel. It caught in his throat like decaying sandpaper. “Just drop it.”

“Okay,” Hyacine said and dropped it.

Again: Silence.

The budding quiet grew around them, bulging and uncomfortable and Phainon did his best not to pay it any mind. He tried to focus on the soft strands of Ica’s mane, doing his best to ignore the hovering figures by his bedside. It wasn’t easy. It was almost as hard as the cycles themselves - to temper himself, to stay his tongue and contain his own emotions. The more he tried to calm himself, the more it began to feel like the world was rebelling against him.

It started with a matted mane. With red staining Ica’s body— not real, *not real,* he knew it wasn’t and yet it had been, once, a thousand times, a million— and the feel of stickiness against his fingers accompanied by the scent of copper. He could even taste it on his tongue.

Heh.

The blood on his fingers wasn’t real but the taste in his mouth was. The bite of his tongue was firmer than expected. Teeth sliced through and yeah, he really couldn’t do it. Couldn’t clear his mind and deal with the way they were looming over him. Managing half a minute was his limit - then the stares and the emotion and *all of it* became too much and he simply couldn’t stand it any more.

Couldn’t control the poison inside of him and the anger that kept pushing *back* with more and more force every time he tried to rid himself of it.

There were tears in his eyes.

Not from sadness. Not caused by grief. They were raw and enraged and burning like the rest of him.

Phainon swallowed blood from his bleeding tongue and through the gaps in snarling teeth, said, “What is it?”

“Um. Well. Are you— Uh. How are you feeling?” He scraped an upward trail until his gaze was focused on Hyacine. She winced back from the fire directed at her as if to ensure that she wouldn’t need to treat her own burns. Or, probably, she simply wasn’t used to bearing the onslaught of anger. It wasn’t like she’d ever been the target of his rage. Only ever his sword.

“Oh, well thanks for *asking,”* he sniped. “I’m downright *peachy,* Hyacinthia.”

Hyacine took a half step backwards - was that fear in her eyes? Or just sadness? - her cheeks pinkening. Her mouth opened and closed, once, twice, as if she was trying to figure out what she could say to make everything *better,* before eventually, flustered, she simply blurted out, “I didn’t know about the wires.”

It didn’t settle him but the admission - or perhaps it wasn’t her words at all, simply the fact that she looked so distressed to have done something that caused him pain - did… *something.*

Phainon wasn’t necessarily sure what exactly that ‘something’ *was*.

He didn’t feel different. He was still angry, still wanted to burn. But that ‘something’ was enough to realise that taking his ire out on Hyacine wasn’t necessarily *fair.*

(What, so it was only okay to be angry at someone if it was fair to *them?* That didn’t sound very fair to *him,* either.)

((Titans, his mind felt too frazzled to begin unpacking all of *that* with any real depth. That was simply another thing he would have to unpack *later.*))

Either way, Hyacine was right.

She hadn’t known.

It didn’t erase the fact that he was furious about it, or that he’d been hurt by her actions, but at least he knew that the pain hadn’t been purposeful. That was something, right?

…Well, it kind of had to be, didn’t it?

“Right,” he said. And before she could say anything else, before she tried even further to magically make things *better,* he added, “Hyacine, you should leave now.”

Hyacine’s frown was an immediate thing. But beside it, there was confusion. Wholeheartedly confused and somewhat lost. “Leave?”

“Yeah,” His voice was a mixture of hollowness and deep, frostbitten hatred. Too strong to be anything but cold. “Leave.”

“But—”

Phainon lifted his hand from Ica’s mane. Blood was drying in the cracks of his skin. He knew it wasn’t real, that it *couldn’t* be, but the realisation didn’t make it disappear. If anything, it made the sensation more sickening. “Ica will go with you.”

“But I need to—”

“Get *out*, Hyacinthia,” he snapped, unable to stop himself. “How many times do I need to say it? Get out and leave me the fuck *alone*. Are my words that hard to comprehend? Do your ears not work? You’re a doctor, shouldn’t you be able to fucking *listen?*”

She flinched with every word. And Phainon knew— he *knew*— that he was going to regret them later, when the dust settled. Regret the rise to his voice, that cruel satisfaction of seeing someone hurt in much the same way as *he* hurt. And yet, the knowledge of eventual regret wasn’t enough to make him stop. It wasn’t enough to press pause. To swallow his words and fall into that awkward silence once more.

Lygus had coded him to *hate* and it felt like that was all that he was. It wasn't just that he hated, it was that, at his core, that was all he'd ever be. Hatred. A being made up of it. Some twisted approximation of a person unable to do anything other than hurt and snarl and burn all of the bridges he'd spent a literal *eternity* building and demolishing, over and over and *over.*

And Phainon knew, he did, that if she didn't leave now, that he was just going to keep going. Hyacine had always been sensitive, she was too easily hurt even despite all of her resilience, so she had to go before… before he really *did* say something in this state of Hate that would make her leave him entirely. Right now, as they were, he'd be able to apologise and it would— it wouldn't be *fine* but she'd forgive him, probably. But if she didn't leave then he'd keep picking away at her like a festering wound. And it would get worse, the rot would sink in, the decay of their whole friendship gone with all his regret mushrooming across the bones of what ifs and 'what-could-have-beens', and Hyacine would never forgive him - deserved or not - and he'd be alone. Again. And Phainon really *couldn't* be alone, not again, not ever. It'd be too close to life inside of Irontomb, to life within the *cycles,* it'd be the manifestation of every single bad thought imagined across a millenia of bad thoughts and he wanted to be fine, he wanted to be better, but they'd stuck *wires* into his *fucking body,* so he wasn't, how could he ever be? And it was too much to keep it all locked inside, he was going to explode from all these feelings, he couldn't push it down, couldn't contain all of this hate, this Destruction— Nanook had done something, THEY'd *done something* and he didn't know what, just that he was Wrong, he'd never be right again— so he reached for the pillow he'd previously thrown at Mydei's head, buried his face into it and *screamed.*

And *screamed.*

Even muffled by fabric it was a loud and guttural thing.

It trembled.

His scream trembled. Just like *he* trembled. And when, exactly, had he started shaking? Had he woken in such a state and simply not noticed? Or had it kicked in alongside the decision to hold off for even a little longer

alongside the agreement to Mydei that he could wait. He could wait, he would, he was so *used* to *waiting*—

Was this feeling in his chest simply rage? Or was the shudder beneath his skin that of rising terror?

Was the pulse thudding against his ears that of his own, or that of a machine?

Phainon couldn’t stop shaking. He couldn’t. Why couldn’t he stop shaking?

He didn’t understand. He *didn’t*. Was he really that scared of a few stupid wires? He’d survived, hadn’t he? And wasn’t survival the aim, wasn’t that the most he’d ever expected? To just get *through it*, to make it out the other end? What was there to be scared of after everything was over? There wasn’t anything. So he wasn’t.

He *wasn’t.*

He wasn’t scared. He was just angry. He’d always been angry, that was his *thing* wasn’t it? He bore a world’s worth of hate. He’d never been the Worldbearer of the *future*, but the Worldbearer of a world’s rage, he held a fury that was worthy of a *Lord Ravager,* so this couldn’t be fear, it couldn’t. Just hate.

Just—

He tried to breathe, shuddered, and let out another scream into the pillow. The fabric was wet with spittle and tears and he couldn’t breathe properly because it was over but it *wasn’t*, he wasn’t *out*, he was still *there* and the emotions were still *there* and after everything, *everything*—

He couldn't say when exactly it happened but eventually his thoughts entered into incoherency. They ceased making sense. Cognition shifted from coherency into a mesh of half-formed concepts, into too bright lights and tears burning against his eyes, air burning in deflated lungs.

Phainon’s heart raced and he was gasping, gulping in air around the sounds that his rage— his *fear*— were pulling free from his throat and one moment he was thinking too much and then, like a puppet cut from its strings: *Nothing*.

Nothing at all.

It was hard to tell when consciousness returned. It was, by no means, an instant thing. And Phainon was too exhausted to even begin unpacking when, exactly, he’d fallen into a weak substitution of calm.

His heart was no longer racing and yet his chest ached from the onslaught of it. His body was no longer actively shaking but the fine motor control of his limbs felt slippery, like they’d been replaced with soggy parchment that was beginning to dissolve.

Some things he did register.

The dip of the mattress beside him. The way that, after everything, he’d ended up half slumped against a too tense, unmoving body. The gentle breaths that he’d been encouraged to mirror and had now synced his breathing to.

“Mydeimos,” he breathed, eventually, unsure whether he was relieved or upset by the Kremnoan’s extended presence.

“Phainon,” Mydei replied. Voice low, not quite bleeding with gentleness but with a warmth that spoke of relief without any of the typical pity that accompanied consternation.

This was probably the point where Phainon should’ve thanked him. Most people probably would’ve, right? For helping him through whatever emotional outburst he’d just had, for staying even when he had a myriad of reasons to leave. But even though he was no longer screaming, no longer

ruled by whatever primal version of himself had taken control for long enough to leave him in a state of pure, unadulterated… *whatever*, the anger wasn't gone completely.

So instead of saying 'thank you' or anything that would've left him even remotely vulnerable, what Phainon said was, "Later, I'm going to punch you in your stupid fucking face. And you're never going to stop me from pulling those things out *ever* again."

Mydei huffed.

And then he said, "If you must."

Chapter 24

Chapter Notes

> i want to set a loose goal to myself to finish act 2 by august. let's see if that works!!
>
> hi guys, welcome me back! i started writing using ellipsus and that's definitely helped. mainly because now whenever i write i'm not blinded by the nuclear white screen that was google docs.
>
> thank you to everyone who left comments on previous chapters!! i read them all recently and love and appreciate every one! i haven't been too good at responding to them but i'm hoping to get back on top of that again soon!
>
> cro did such lovely art of phainon in the infirmary last chapter. take a look at this!!! whenever i look at it again, i get so overwhelmingly happy!!
>
> as always, thanks for your patience in waiting for the new chapter! i hope you enjoy!

After he had regained enough emotional stability to quit panicking and prop himself up against his pillow —and had, subsequently, gathered enough energy to move without having to wage war against his own lead-lined limbs —Phainon punched Mydei and shoved the prince from the bed.

Mydei, for the most part, looked more exasperated than hurt.

Which was even more infuriating, actually, because Phainon was pretty sure that Mydei had seen the punch coming and intentionally decided *not* to dodge. It wasn't like the punch had been particularly fast moving or anything. He *should* have dodged.

"You're not supposed to sit still and just let people punch you in the face," he had huffed in offense as he shoved Mydei from the bed and maybe *that*

was the reason for the exasperation. Maybe it was one of those *'I can't win, can I?'* annoyances.

(Well no, *fuck you Mydeimos, you can't win.*

And neither could Phainon. His knuckles were burning and his chest was starting to feel tight again. He was supposed to feel bad about it but honestly there was just a part of him that wanted to do it again. Only this time he'd throw the punch properly with his full strength, throwing all of his weight into it. The sentiment only succeeded in making him feel *worse.* Because he didn't actually *want* to hurt Mydei, he was pretty sure he'd rather die than truly hurt him. He just wanted to punch something that looked a whole lot like the prince of Kremnos.)

"Next time I'll be sure to move," Mydei said, dryly.

Since he was now standing, Mydei made his way to the tail of the bed where a table had been haphazardly pushed out of the way. It had probably been moved during the commotion when Mydei had been struggling against him during his attempt to keep the wires *inside* of him but Phainon hadn't noticed that it had existed. Other things on the mind and all that. Hadn't even heard it move - though that, he was pretty sure, could be blamed solely on the wheels. The table was bare. It housed a jug of water and a glass. Mydei filled the glass, returned to Phainon's side and held it out.

Expectantly.

Staring at it made something in his stomach twist. Discomfort stabbed at his temples and, for a split second, he was back to staring at that stupid bowl again. The one from the mess hall, the one that he'd spent what felt like an age staring at as he realised that he didn't know himself anymore. That maybe he never had. Because if he had understood before, then it wouldn't be so damned difficult to understand the shape of his own thoughts and who he had become *now.* He could feel such spiralling thoughts returning as he stared at the jug and the faint cracks of its handle.

Phainon blinked. He shook the thoughts away.

Crockery was clearly the enemy here.

"You should drink something," Mydei prompted and moved the glass a little closer for him to take.

Absolutely not.

With the kind of hostility found only in raging gods and petulant toddlers, Phainon smacked the glass from Mydei's hand and waited for the resulting shatter. At first, he felt smug, knowing that he'd successfully avoided the returning spiral from the mess hall. And then, *irritation*.

The glass had not shattered.

Mydei raised his eyebrow, crouched to retrieve the cup and held it up to be inspected. There wasn't even a single crack.

"Phainon," Mydei said, in lieu of Phainon's scowl. "This is plastic."

Asshole.

"I don't *want* it."

If his refusal bothered Mydei, it didn't show on his face. He simply shrugged, refilled the glass and took a sip. Only then, as Phainon watched him warily, did he place in on the counter directly beside him.

It shouldn't have made him wary. And yet Phainon was a feral cat with its hackles raised. He barely stopped himself from batting it to the ground *again*, like a housecat with a grudge, after reminding himself that he could do so *after* more pressing matters had been dealt with.

Matters like dealing with Mydei's continued presence and figuring out what the fuck was up with *that.*

"Why are you still here?" He asked, when the Kremnoan did not instantly read his mind and offer him an immediate explanation. "Are you meant to be my keeper now or something?"

If they'd decided to set up surveillance of their crazy ex-Deliverer, he was really going to lose his temper. More than he already had.

"It's not like that."

Like he could just believe the words. It was hard to believe anything when it made too much sense for his fellow Chrysos Heirs to set up a rotation to watch him 24/7. They'd probably decided that he was 'too volatile' and had written out an entire plan on how to deal with him. Cyrene had probably been the instigator. She had already betrayed his trust once so why wouldn't she do it again? Why wouldn't she set Mydei upon him like a watch dog?

Something as bitter as almonds caught in the back of his throat. Phainon's scowl deepened. His nails dug deep into his palms. "Sure it isn't."

Mydei sat down on his undersized children's chair and said, "You said you didn't want to be alone. So I'm staying. There's no ulterior motive here."

Scoffing, Phainon turned his head.

He knew it wasn't a lie. He knew because he'd spent millions of years standing beside Mydei learning every nuance and lilt of his tone. He'd catalogued every indication of a lie or mistruth being uttered. For example, whenever Mydeimos lied he stopped blinking as often. His behaviour shifted into that of a lion watching its prey, waiting to see if said prey had caught sight of the predator whilst it attempted to blend in. When he lied, his words quickened. Not to such a degree that anyone would notice, but enough to be noticeable when you *knew* what to look for.

It may not have been a lie but that did not mean that the whole gesture did not *reek* of pity. Was this placation? Calm the person who had killed him and destroyed Amphoreus 33 million times to ensure he didn't add one final number to the tally?

"That was before I remembered how fucking annoying you are."

A dry laugh rumbled from Mydei's chest. "Hah. Sure."

Phainon whirled on him. "What's *that* supposed to mean?"

"It means that if you really want me to leave then you should just say that." Mydei crossed his arms. "But until you say those specific words, I'm staying."

Phainon wanted to say the words so badly that they ached inside of his chest. They ached, and dropped deep into his stomach, burning with such force that he wouldn't have been surprised if they brought him physical indigestion. Because he *did* want Mydei to leave him alone. Probably.

Or, well, not want. He didn't *want* to be alone but that was what he did best. It was the state he had lived in for the longest, the thing he was most used to and the longer Mydei stayed in this room with him, the more at risk he was of being caught in the middle of whatever explosion was currently leaking out from him.

Like with Hyacine, he wanted the prince gone before he could fuck it all up. Arguably, it should've all been ruined already - Mydei knew about the cycles, he knew about the *murders.* Maybe not the truth that there had been 33 million of them but he'd certainly be able to deduce that the number was high. And the longer Mydei stayed the longer…

He needed to figure something out to make him leave. Something other than saying he wanted the man gone. Because he didn't. And he wasn't sure he'd be able to say the words convincingly. Even as angry as he was.

Maybe Mydei could see something in his expression because he straightened and said, "You don't need to force me to leave because you aren't currently calm. You don't need to temper yourself at all. Your anger is nothing I cannot withstand."

Ha, tell that to all the times he'd cleaved Dawnmaker through Mydei's tenth thoracic vertebrae. He'd not been able to withstand it *then.*

No. He'd just *died.*

"I will not leave you alone simply because you are showing sides of yourself that I have not seen," Mydei continued, deaf to Phainon's inner monologue.

It was a nice thought even if it were completely false. Or well, misguided. Once again he knew the words were true: He knew when the Kremnoan was lying. Still, that didn't mean that Mydei wasn't capable of being wholeheartedly delusional.

Maybe he was giving in too easily.

Later, he would blame his easily collapsing determination on the post-panic attack exhaustion muddying his already pretty muddied mind into displaying acquiescence. Until later though, he simply reminded himself that being angry didn't mean he *always* had to push people away. Sometimes even the monster inside of him could be still. Even if poison *was* still dripping from his mouth.

"You'll regret it," Phainon said. And then, glowering. "Maybe I'll punch you again. Did you think I wouldn't?"

Mydei smirked. "I've recently been informed to dodge any more incoming punches so I reckon I'll be fine."

"I hate you."

"No," Mydei said, "I don't think you do."

Ha.

He wasn't going to dive into all of *that* because else they would be here all day. And while he didn't want to be alone that didn't mean he wanted to start *talking* to other people. Instead, he cast his gaze around and looked for literally anything that could stall their current conversation before it could continue.

Mydei's teleslate on the countertop echoing songs far too peppy and energetic for a hospital was his saving grace.

"I didn't expect you to like Penaconian *pop* music," he said, dryly.

Mydei followed his gaze to the teleslate. He said, "I don't particularly. Is that what this is? Penaconian pop?"

"Yeah. You didn't know?"

"It's not playing for me." Mydei shook his head and nodded in Phainon's direction. "It's for you. Cyrene mentioned that you'd been listening to new music and that it seemed calming. So I asked the trailblazer to send me a playlist of songs you might enjoy and she sent me this. You should call her, she's been worried."

It was a nice sentiment. Or it would've been if Mydei hadn't brought up Cyrene. Maybe if he hadn't, Phainon would've had some semblance of positivity to know that Mydeimos was trying to be accommodating and had reached out to their dear friend Stelle for things he might enjoy.

Instead, all that remained was a bitterness at the back of his throat.

He really shouldn't be thinking of Cyrene. It wasn't wise when the mere thought of her left him choking on his own hatred as if it were smoke. She'd said she was on his side and then, instead of believing in him, she'd broken his trust and ruined *everything*.

Telling their fellow heirs how many cycles it had been was cruel. Unnecessary.

He'd wanted to hurt her for it.

If Phainon were being entirely honest there was a small part of himself that still wanted to. That wanted to melt away all her cruelty and *coldness* and reshape her until she was the version of herself that lived in the furthest depths of his memory.

But he couldn't. And he wasn't willing to *say* any of that, so instead he stared at his blanket - noting with vague disinterest that it was *smoking* - and said, "Where is Cyrene anyway?"

Mydei eyed the smoking blanket warily. "I don't know. I've been here since you passed out. She hasn't come by."

Phainon scoffed. *Of course she hadn't.* It was so like Cyrene to write herself out of the narrative whenever the story got too difficult for her to handle. She'd outed all his secrets and then bowed a curtain call, leaving *him* to deal with the aftermath. Again.

"We thought you might prefer some space after what happened," Mydei explained. "After what happened. But if you'd rather she be here, then I'll —"

"No."

"No?"

Phainon shook his head so forcefully it left his ears ringing. "I don't want to see her." He scowled and batted at a rogue flame that burst into existence around a now blackening strip of blue fabric until it went out. "I don't even want to *think* about her."

"Alright." Mydei said. "Do you want me to distract you or do you want me to leave?"

"Can't being quiet be an option?"

"It can. If you want."

He was pretty sure that this was Mydei's attempt at being accommodating but it just felt like condescension. Though *any* attempts at accommodating him were probably going to come across as condescending at this point. His anger was quite efficient at morphing every action’s intent into something unforgiveable.

Phianon sighed.

"Just tell me what the distraction is."

Mydei did not, in fact, tell him what the distraction was. Instead, he untangled his legs from his cosmically small chair and made his way to one of the cupboards at the edge of the room. Or more specifically, to the countertop beneath it where, now that he was actually looking, Phainon spotted a package wrapped in brown parcel paper.

"This is for you," Mydei said and dropped it into Phainon's lap.

Phainon stared at it as if it contained a bomb.

It didn't. Not unless bombs had stopped being heavy, bulky things. The package was medium-sized but light. Not as light as a feather, but around the same weight as the blanket cloaking his legs. The paper was smooth with no rough edges and when he pressed on it the parcel was *soft.*

"What is this?" He asked.

"A gift."

Yeah, well that didn't answer *anything.* Phainon scowled, despite himself.

"From Lady Aglaea," Mydei continued. "She asked Castorice to deliver it when she visited last."

Something like reluctance built inside of him. Or maybe not reluctance but distaste. Aglaea had sent him a gift without showing up herself, well, *that* was fine. He didn't need her to visit. But it was probably clothes. Clothing. Which meant she was probably trying to remind him that even in the Era Nova he needed to play a role and that he should pull himself together already.

"What is it?" He murmured.

Mydei shrugged. "Open it and find out."

He didn't want to open it.

He was going to open it anyway.

The paper shredded with little fanfare and he was greeted with a bundle of material that, when unfolded, revealled itself as a coat. It wasn't fitted. Not in the same way that his previous coat had been though it had likely been altered to fit his specific body measurements. Nor was it as thick as the coat she had previously issued him.

What it was, was a yellow coat. Not a light cream or a deep gold. It was the colour of sunshine. The body was so shockingly bright that it seemed as if Aglaea had plucking rays of sun from the sky and used it as thread. It's soft lining was purple. And not just *any* shade of purple. But rather his favourite shade of lilac.

The purple wouldn't be seen once he was wearing it but it was clearly a blend of what had once been his favourite pair of colours.

Something in Phainon's chest tightened and he was pretty sure that somewhere outside of himself the world was rumbling.

Alright. So Aglaea wasn't telling him that Okhema still needed him as the Deliverer. That was... He wasn't sure whether that was good or downright humiliating. What was this then? A gift to show that she no longer held a need for him in her future plans?

"Did she leave a note?" The words were punched from his throat with such force that it left him winded. He looked through the scraps of shredded paper and found nothing. Checked the outside pockets and came up short. No scrawl. No note. *Nothing.*

It was as if the coat itself was the only message Aglaea had intended to send him.

"…Phainon?"

He forced himself to roll onto his side, away from the prince. Closing his eyes, he hugged his new coat in his arms and did his best attempt to clear his mind. To keep from thinking. His voice was muffled when he said, "I'm tired, Mydeimos. Let me sleep."

Mydei didn't say anything else.

The coat must've been some sort of talisman. This time, when he drifted off, he managed to avoid any thought of Irontomb or Lygus. Instead, it was just Aglaea, sitting in her workshop with a pin pressed between her lips and cloth the colour of sunshine spilling across her hands.

He hadn't realised he missed her, Phainon thought, and slept.

Chapter 25

Chapter Notes

> had a lot of fun writing this one. i locked in and wrote most of this in one sitting which is kind of wild to me!! hope you all enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Two days after waking up from his very sudden, tantrum-fuelled coma Phainon called the trailblazer.

More specifically, it took two days for his call to be answered. Not that he was trying particularly hard to contact her. When his first attempt at calling - using the word 'attempt' was extremely loose, considering he wasn't even the one controlling the teleslate - got him sent through to voice mail, he'd simply deemed the entire thing a waste of time and proceeded to bury his head into his pillow until Mydei sighed and gave up.

The next day when Phainon used his own teleslate to call, Stelle picked up on the first ring as if she'd been waiting for him.

He tried not to think of all the negative reasons she might have been waiting and instead fiddled with the sleeves of his new coat from where it had become a permanent fixture in his lap. Mydei had likely mentioned the reason for his call the day before and she'd known they would try to get into contact again. That was all.

It was a video call; Stelle only ever answered video calls. She'd once explained that it was necessary if she was going to take screenshots of all her friends and add them into March 7th's photograph collection. Apparently, she even had a secret video call photo album or whatever that she kept hidden behind the fake Sparkle bomb she kept on her sofa.

(Or at least, Phainon *thought* the Sparkle bomb was fake. He also remembered something about fireworks? Or that the dolls had been *hiding*

bombs? He couldn't remember and he also *did not care enough* to ask for clarification.)

The screen flicked to life and from Stelle's side of the galaxy Phainon was greeted by the Trailblazer's forehead and a single lock of grey hair falling across skin that he was pretty sure had gone unbrushed since the Astral Express had left Amphoreus.

"Heeeeeeey buddy!" Stelle said. "How's it hanging Sunshine?"

Phainon stared at her forehead for approximately three and a half seconds before closing his eyes and letting out an extremely long-winded sigh. He said, "I thought I was babygirl. Why am I now *Sunshine?"*

"Why?" He heard muffled movement and when he checked moments later, Stelle had moved back from the camera just enough to also see her eyes and the bridge of her nose. He resisted the urge to sigh again. Even when she wasn't physically present it felt like she wasn't abiding by the rules of *personal space.* "Well because you light up my world, partner. 10 out of 10 stars. Wait— no. You're the OG sun. Sunshine premium."

Usually when she lost him to her rambling, Phainon simply smiled politely and nodded. He would tell himself that he didn't really need to know and that if he really wanted to know then eventually the World Wound Web would explain it all for him. But right now, all he really felt was irked by the fact that in all the time he'd known these guests from beyond the stars, he had only understood about half of what Stelle had ever said. It shouldn't have been so difficult to understand whatever the fuck it was she was talking about. *And yet.*

"Right," he said, unimpressed.

"Oof," Stelle said with a wince. "Tough crowd. No being silly with the silly bean, gotcha. Okay Phai-boy, if you're more in the mood for seriousness instead of some lighthearted teasing then that's fine too. I can *totally* be serious, you know I—"

…*This* was the true Deliverer of Amphoreus? *Really?*

He cut her off. "Mydei said you were worried and I should call to check in."

Stelle shuffled back from the screen and he could finally see her in full. The first word that came to mind while looking at her was *frazzled.* She looked a few steps closer to the raccoon photos she'd shown him in the past that accompanied messages of *'#me'* or *'#raccoongoals'.* Heavy bags had collected under her eyes; She looked like it'd been a while since she'd slept through the night in full.

Alright, maybe he didn't like seeing a *worried* trailblazer. She didn't look suited to worry. It made *him* concerned.

"I *have* been worried! You haven't checked in with me in so long I was starting to get all jittery like some poor bride jilted at the alter!"

Phainon's gaze lifted past his teleslate to Mydei who was currently stood at the nearby counter removing pomegranate seeds from segments of cut fruit and placing them in a small container. Sensing the sudden attention directed his way, Mydei turned and gestured towards the seeds.

Phainon shook his head — food was still as much the enemy as crockery — and asked, "How long was I unconscious for?"

"Eight days."

Turning back to where Stelle was trapped in his screen, Phainon said, "It's not even been two weeks."

"I was still worried! But that's not what's important right now. Are you like… okay?" Phainon's eye twitched; He was really beginning to hate being asked that question. "Okay. Clearly you're *not* but like... I heard about what happened and I guess I wanted to check in on how much fire there is in the room right now?"

He had to resist the urge to sigh. The past few days hadn't done much to temper the anger in his chest and as such, the fire that Stelle was referencing was very much *still burning.* It was honestly surprising how his

mind hadn't crumbled away entirely with how much it clung to his blood. At least it helped him sleep - being angry was exhausting.

"A lot," Phainon said and watched Stelle wince again.

"Yeeeeah," she said. "I kind of figured it would be after talking with Cas and Cyrene, they both—"

He cut her off again. "I don't want to hear anything about Cyrene for now. She's—" The edge of his teleslate sizzled. He forced a deep breath in and out. "I'm *trying* to be calmer but if we talk about *her* then I won't be."

Stelle blinked. "That's actually really emotionally aware of you."

Phainon scowled.

"I mean it in a good way!" Stelle continued, flapping her hands in front of the screen as if the action offered further clarity - (it *didn't*) - before he could even ask what the hell *that* was supposed to mean. "Just— We'll talk about something else. Mydei's with you, right? What did you think of the playlist I sent him for you?"

"It was…" New. Unfamiliar. A relief after lifetimes of the *same fucking thing* grinding against his eardrums. "…Alright."

"Only alright? Was it too peppy for you? I heard you liked Robin's music so I was going along with that vibe but maybe you need something a little more grunge. Or more punk rock?"

Phainon had literally no idea what she meant by either of those things so he simply nodded his head aimlessly and resisted the growing urge to hang up on her.

"Sounds great," he said.

"We can listen to it in person when we're back!" She said it like a promise, as if she were expecting it to be soon and for Phianon's mind to still be a functional thing instead of an even more decayed mess than it already was. "Oh! I'll get both March and Dan Heng to make you a playlist too. We'll

have a sing-a-long session and all that jazz. Or just a Lo-Fi hangout depending on what you're feeling. It'll be so fun!"

It didn't necessarily sound fun. It sounded like it'd be more of a bother than anything. Knowing Stelle, she'd probably turn the music on too loud and be obnoxious about literally *everything* while he suffered through the experience of pulling her away from every single trash can she could feast her eyes upon. The idea sounded like a *chore.*

The bitterness was clawing its way into his bloodstream again and Phainon closed his eyes so that Stelle wouldn't be able to catch it swarming him. Hopefully, the call wouldn't pick up on the way his already poor mood was starting to plummet further.

No. He told himself. *No. Stop it.*

There was literally *no* reason to be frustrated with the Trailblazer of all people. No reason for his flames to target her. After everything he really *was* grateful for all of the aid she and the Astral Express had brought. She'd delivered them into the Era Nova, for titan's sake! She was the *true hero* of Amphoreus. She was!

He was so endlessly grateful for that and not even a little bitter about it because there was *no point in being bitter.*

But… when she acted so carefree and thoughtless…

…Well, it felt a *little* insulting to realise that *she* had managed what *he* could not.

"Yeah, I'll tell them to make the best playlist," Stelle continued, oblivious to his inner monologue. "It'll give us all something to do during our warps. They're always so boring."

Phainon peeked an eye open. "You're heading back so soon?"

"Yeah! We set off a few days ago, actually. We've got to make a few stops for the geniuses because they want to pick some stuff up but we should be

back in a couple of weeks!"

Phainon blinked. Once. Then twice.

Then, he lifted a hand to the bridge of his nose and pinched the skin as hard as he could. He could see Mydei in his peripheral vision watching him closely, weighing up whether he needed to keep him from hurting himself but the ruling was evidently *no need*.

"I thought you were busy at the space station?"

"Sure was! But then you did your timey-wimey magic and shit changed. Which— that was super rude of you by the way, I got trapped in the simulated universe breaking vases for *forever.* It sucked!"

Something rough caught in Phainon's throat. "I didn't realise people would notice."

Stelle's brows pinched together in thought. She said, "I don't think many people did. Oh, but Herta and Screwllum *definitely* noticed. They were trying to do set calculations to see how much distance the time loop covered but so far they've not been able to find the edge of that space. That's *wild.* Who knew you were so strong. Herta really wants to speak with you. She and Screwllum are coming back with us so they can say hi. It's why we're coming back sooner!"

Phainon frowned. "Remind me who Herta is?"

"She's one of the Genius's that helped us fight against Irontomb." The name was familiar so he'd expected that Herta would've been one of the Expresses allies. They'd delivered the remains of the Scepter to her too, if he was remembering correctly. But he'd wanted a different context. Stelle had specifically mentioned her own relationship with this genius during the cycles and he couldn't clearly remember what she had told him about her. Something about being an assistant? He wasn't sure. "I guess you never actually met her during the cycle we experienced with you, she and Screwllum only really showed up after the Flame Rea—Well. They only showed up at the very end, anyway! Cyre—"

Stelle paused, realising that she had neared a landmine. She cleared her throat.

"Anyway! They're the ones I do tests for in the Simulated Universe."

…Ah.

Something dropped inside of his brain. It clattered into the silence and sounded like clarity. Phainon moved his new coat from where it sat in his lap and placed it on the counter beside him as his expression flattened. He could feel the warning shocks of something close to calm but *not* bubbling inside of him. They were like harmonic tremors acting as a signal. Though for what, he wasn't entirely sure.

"Herta wants to talk to me?" He repeated. "Why?"

Stelle shrugged. "Oh. Well, I reckon she's just a little interested in what you can do. Or, er— okay, maybe she's a *lot* interested in you. And the fact that apparently you're enough of a bamf to turn back time for a huge amount of space."

Didn't the Geniuses follow the Erudition? They were all scientists following Nous, right?

And Nous was the Aeon that Lygus had wanted dead. Nous was his…

…Failed creation?

His lips pressed together and Phainon's forehead crinkled with such force that the lines left in his wake were downright cavernous.

"Your *scientist* friend is interested in me?"

Stelle waved the comment away with a hand. "Well, I'd hardly call Herta a friend but—" She glanced at him from the corner of her eye and froze. Her lips opened and closed, as if realising what she had just said, as if suddenly understanding that his sudden calm was not actually calmness at all but an impending eruption of emotion. She stuttered, "No! I mean— I mean *yes.* But. In like, a *totally* and completely *ethical* way, really, so—"

His expression soured. He could feel flame burning against his vision and was vaguely aware that the rising burn of coreflame must've dyed his irises with gold.

"Your *scientist* friend," he breathed, "who makes you *run simulations* over and over inside of a *coded universe*—"

Stelle winced. "That's really not—"

"—finds *me* and my abilities *interesting* enough to pause her other research and come to *Amphoreus*." He felt something crack inside of his lungs and realised that it had been caused by a dramatic increase in the temperature of the air surrounding him. "She wants to study me, doesn't she?"

"No! I mean, not really. Maybe a little." Stelle lifted her hands in surrender. "That's 100% not what I meant though. You know that's not what I meant! She'd never *force* you, it's totally all up to you!"

She was bringing a scientist back with her to Amphoreus and that was— that was *bad*. He couldn't do that again. *Be* studied. Be inspected and analysed for every error within his code, to be bugged and debugged and copied and deleted and, and—

"This was always the destined end to our game. It could never be avoided."

—No.

"Tell your *Genius Herta,"* Phainon hissed, "that I would rather slit my own throat— no, better yet, *permanently delete my code from the system, again* — then have her be even *remotely* interested in me."

"Partner—"

Phainon didn't snarl at the teleslate in his hand but that was not out of restraint. It was because one moment it was a teleslate and the next it was nothing more than scrapped junk. His fist closed with such force that the device crunched and buckled beneath his strength, a mess of concaved metal parts and cracked glass.

His lips curled. His chest heaved from the onslaught of destruction pooling in his lungs like smoke and— and speaking of smoke, he was pretty sure that he was burning. Again. And bleeding. *Again.* His hand dripping gold, gold, gold, and his code rippling in such a way that he could tell that it was infected with *something,* some sort of virus. Some—some sort of remnant of Irontomb, probably, or a fail safe installed into him by Lygus just waiting for the right trigger.

"Ph—non!"

Mydei's voice felt too far away for him to focus on.

He knew, objectively, that losing his temper here was a risk. With each passing day he could feel the steady return of energy into the coreflames, the rising heat, the blazing power. And he knew, he did, that being angry in this state had led him to destroy so much. Even within the Era Nova. He'd ruined Aedes Elysiae. His room. He'd burned bridges with Cyrene, even if it *had* been her fault.

And yet, he couldn't calm himself.

There was something echoing in his ears like a siren call and it made him want nothing more than to break things. To melt the scraps of metal in his hand, to burn down this stupid *fucking hospital and all the wires inside of it,* to just give in to all of his anger and rage and—

He couldn't stop it. It wasn't just about whether he wanted to or not. He— Phainon wasn't sure he physically *could*.

A rattle echoed on his lips. It sounded like Destruction. Enticing. He snarled again and launched the fragments of his teleslate at the wall.

"P—" Something grabbed hold of his shoulders and jerked him forwards. The movement was so sudden it made his thoughts shake. "*Phainon!"*

…Wait. What was he—

Phainon blinked and there was Mydei, nails digging into his shoulders with such pressure that the force left him breathless.

"Calm down," Mydei said, and he looked… Phainon wasn't sure if it was fear or worry in his eyes but there was something primal there. "Copy my breathing. In. And out."

"Why?"

Why should he?

"Just do it," Mydei repeated. "With me. Inhale."

Phainon inhaled.

"Good. Now, exhale. As much as you can."

And exhaled.

"Yes. Just like that. You're doing great."

And continued to do nothing but breathe until finally Mydei nodded his head, uncurled his fingers and let go.

A shudder wracked its way down Phainon's spine at the sudden absence of pain. Without it to ground him, he could feel the pressure of rage weighing down on him again and he… he needed to be anywhere that wasn't *here.* Not in this room, not in this goddamned hospital, maybe not, even, in *Okhema.*

"Mydei," he breathed and it sounded more like a high pitched whine, a plea. "I need— Fresh air. Something. *Anything.* Just— Just get me out of here." His voice caught in his throat and cracked. "I don't want to be here anymore. *Please.*"

Mydei's lips thinned.

He reached for Phainon's blanket only to hesitate as its the edges crumbled into ash and stained his fingertips. Then, he cast his attention sideways,

grabbed hold of yellow fabric and thrust Phainon's new coat into his arms. "Can you walk?"

That was a question he really didn't know the answer to. He'd find a way. Whether he had to use the coreflames or simply drag himself across the ground with shaking limbs he would find a way.

"Of course you can't," Mydei muttered before Phainon could speak. It sounded more like he was speaking to himself. Nodding to the coat, he said, "Put that on. I'll carry you."

Chapter End Notes

> for those of you who have a lil bit of trouble reading the zalgo text: *This was always the destined end to our game. It could never be avoided.*

Chapter 26

Chapter Notes

> we're about halfway through act 2 with this chapter!! i'm quite excited for it. (I wasn't lying when I said this one is the shortest of the acts!!)
>
> hope you're all enjoying the fic. thank you for all of the comments, i love reading and rereading them even if i don't always manage to respond to them!

Mydei did not carry him out of Okhema but they did end up at the city's border.

As if falling back into routines they had once shared, Mydei abandoned the streets in favour of the Okheman rooftops. The buildings at the city's edge were more stable, if not a little dusty from where the wind had swept debris and silt onto flat walkways and into empty gutters. As such, they were able to traverse the roofs with few worries that the surrounding structures would collapse from the smallest shift in weight.

Phainon burrowed as deeply into his coat as he could. In part because the sudden drop in temperature from his smouldering hospital room to the outdoors was enough to leave him shivering and also because he didn't want anyone in the streets below looking up and seeing him in his current state. He didn't want to learn how the civilians of Okhema would react to the sight of his snarling lips or the cut of his glare.

In an attempt to hide from anyone who did glance up he pressed his forehead into the curve of Mydei's shoulder.

"Is the river okay?"

"Huh?"

Mydei's hold of him tightened. It was difficult to know whether it was in response to the dry crack in Phainon's voice or just coincidence. Probably

coincidence. If it were because of him, Mydei wouldn't hold on. He'd have let go.

"I know a place that overlooks the river," Mydei said. "But I don't want to go there if you don't want to."

Phainon was pretty sure that he knew the place that Mydei was thinking of. By the riverside - or rather, on the streets *above it* - there was a small alcove built into the side of a building nestled in thick ropes of overgrown ivy. In some of the cycles they'd cleared the ivy and reinforced the rotting walls. Then they had used the building as a temporary outpost when travelling back into the city after missions. It had always helped to have a place to rest when they'd been too exhausted to make the trek all the way home to the Marmoreal Palace.

They hadn't repurposed it in his final cycle. Hadn't in the last hundred or so. It was probably still abandoned.

Which made it the perfect place to go to avoid people.

"Phainon?"

"I don't care," he said, the words scraping from his throat. Phainon frowned - that made it sound like he *did* care, at least a little bit. Which he *didn't*. He added, "It's fine. The river's fine."

Mydei's chin brushed against his hair as he nodded. "Then we'll go there."

Phainon didn't respond. He was doing his best to keep from thinking too much.

(His best, of course, was not good enough. It never had been.

And so his thoughts spiralled.)

So… The Astral Express was returning sooner than he'd expected they would. Which was a good thing. Or *would* have been a good thing if their return didn't include an agreement to act as personal chauffeurs to two geniuses. One of whom was interested in *him.* And perhaps wanted to use

him as a subject in one of her experiments. The idea made his skin crawl. He could feel copper sparks brushing across the bruises of his still healing arms. Even just the thought of Herta's *interest* sent a rippling wave of revulsion down his spine.

Except… he didn't know for certain that Herta wanted to study him. Not really. Stelle had only said that the woman was interested in the act he had accomplished against time and now wanted to speak with him.

But still…

…And it wasn't as if he didn't trust the Astral Express. He did. Chrysos Heirs withstanding, the Express crew were the group he trusted most. Even if he'd only conversed with two of their current members. He knew their temperament enough to know they held no malice. The Nameless were benevolent. They had saved Amphoreus. They had saved *him.* Knowing this, it was impossible to truly believe that they'd suddenly flipped personalities and were now trying to ruin his life, readying to throw him back inside of the very machine they'd helped to pry him out of.

He trusted the Express. And if the Astral Express trusted these geniuses, stating that their visit to Amphoreus would not cause any hindrance to their healing planet, then logically he knew that was probably true. They wouldn't bring any harm. There likely wouldn't be any more experiments.

If anything, meeting Herta would include a brief conversation that he'd be able to easily escape by saying *'I'd rather not talk about anything actually, thanks,'* without being pushed past his limits.

And really, how self-centered was the belief that they were visiting Amphoreus solely to come and study *him*? Herta probably wasn't visiting Amphoreus out of interest for *him.* She and the other one were likely only visiting because they had helped to*save* it and wanted to see the planet they'd made such efforts for. Speaking with Phainon was likely an afterthought to their trip.

But *still.*

It didn't matter that he didn't believe it. Or that it wasn't necessarily rational. The idea had seeped into his thoughts and now, no matter how much he wanted to shake them away, they were *there*. Phainon knew that it was a long shot. He knew that the probability was infinitesimal. But the truth was that the probability was not zero and so his heart stuttered and his stomach churned and his mind set itself ablaze to protect itself from the influx of fear and icy dread that tried to choke him.

He'd spent eons waiting for the smallest of chances to occur and eventually it had. It made it difficult to trust that *this* small chance would not find a way to manifest itself as well.

"We're here," Mydei said, effectively dragging him away from the spiral that had left him breathing in rapid gasps. Phainon jerked as he was lowered onto ivy wrapped tiles and cast his gaze on his surroundings.

He'd been correct. Mydei had brought them to the little alcove, though instead of tucking them within the stone alcove they sat at the roof's edge, overlooking the river. It was glimmering a rich cerulean. Water rippled from the fish swimming below the river's surface but from this far away it was impossible to define them as anything more than shadowed specks.

Not knowing what to do with himself, Phainon began picking at the ivy, ripping pieces free. The vines withered and crumbled into ash across his palms.

Mydei sat beside him in silence, legs hanging over the edge of the roof, leaning back on his hands as he half-shut his eyes and tilted his chin towards the sun.

It wasn't an expectant quiet that greeted them and yet Phainon still snapped, "I don't want to talk about it."

"Then don't," Mydei said.

Phainon ripped a bundle of ivy free from where it had started to thread itself in knots around a loose tile in the roof. Pulling the ivy free made it crack in half. His brows furrowed.

"I'm *never* going to want to talk about it," he continued.

He wasn't sure where his defensiveness had sprung from. Or why he was even speaking. It wasn't like he'd been asked any questions and yet he was speaking regardless.

"That's alright," Mydei said.

Phainon risked a glance from the corner of his eye. The prince was still basking in the sunshine as if he were a lazy chimera. There was little visible tension in his body. (Alright, that was a lie, Phainon could see remnants of it in Mydei's shoulders where the Kremnoan was actively keeping himself from showing his worry.)

The words rose from him like smoke.

"It's just—" He squeezed his hands around the cracked tile from before. Ignored the way it crumbled into dust from the onslaught of his powers. "Is everyone really that fucking *stupid? Really?* After everything that Amphoreus has been through, did they really think that we'd all be fine with welcoming more geniuses into Amphoreus as if their first society member hadn't caused so much suffering? Amphoreus hardly needs more people *studying* it right now. It needs—"

He paused. He didn't know what Amphoreus needed. He wasn't entirely sure he was even talking *about* Amphoreus.

"Not fucking *that.*" He ranted. "It doesn't need *that.*"

Mydei opened an eye. It flicked to Phainon before settling on the patch of ivy between them both. "First society member? You mean the Theoros?"

Despite himself, Phainon flinched away from the title. The cold dread it instilled made him angrier. It was *only* a title. The fact that a single word could force a physical reaction from him made him want to break something. A lot of somethings.

"*He* studied Amphoreus," Phainon said, the words pitched high and bubbling forth before he could really think. "He was *always* watching it. Amphoreus couldn't do anything without him marking it down in his logs. Couldn't do a *goddamned* thing without him noting the external variables. Without him lamenting another wasted cycle."

Mydei's eyes opened. They settled on Phainon and remained on him. Not studying him but listening. Waiting.

"He— That was how they always ended. With *him.* With his smug voice and those lifeless fucking eyes. '*Another attempt. Another failure. If history only ever repeats itself, won't you finally end this game?'* It never stopped. He never shut up." At this, he turned to Mydei, his heart rattling against his ribcage, his eyes wide. "Mydei, he *never shut up."*

"Phainon…"

"And it's— See, even if you killed him, no matter *how* you killed him, *Lygus* was always there when everything reset. Waiting. *Watching.* We weren't people. We were just subjects. Code. We were just bugs in a machine that didn't work the way he wanted us to. We were just butterflies and he— he pinned me to the board. He watched me *writhe*."

Mydei reached a hand out towards him. Hesitated. Phainon turned his head and ripped more ivy from its roots. He tore slabs of tile free and burned fingerprints into the slate.

"Can you imagine if some animation in your teleslate kept fighting against you? That's all we were to him. All *I* was." Phainon gasped. A laugh caught in his throat and died there. The corpse of it rotted in his lungs and obstructed his incoming breaths. "Wouldn't I catch your interest? Wasn't I *fascinating?"*

Tears blurred the world. Phainon felt a tremble catch his shoulders.

"And we— we finally got *rid* of him after… after fucking forever. And now, *now,* the Astral Express are bringing more of his group *here."* He lifted his hands and hid his face away. "And they're going to do it again. Because

that's just how scientists are. And I thought I— that *Amphoreus*— was finally free from all of their eyes but I'm not. We're *not*."

A hand took hold of his wrist and before Phainon could really process it, he was pulled into Mydei's arms.

"That's not going to happen," Mydei said. He could feel the rumble of the words vibrating across the prince's chest.

Heat caught in his blood. Phainon's cheeks were burning under rising indignance. "You can't promise that. You can't."

"I will promise it," Mydei said, evenly. "If the Nameless are bringing those Geniuses into Okhema then we'll just make sure that we are not here when they arrive. We'll take supplies to Castrum Kremnos. Or have Lady Tribbie open a gate for us to Styxia. They won't be able to study you even if they wanted to."

"No." He shook his head with the force one would expect to see in a concussion victim. His brain rattled. "Not Kremnos. I can't— not with you. I can't be in Kremnos with you. Not again."

"Styxia then," Mydei declared. "We'll go to Styxia. If we asked, I'm sure Castorice would show us around."

"Really?"

"Yes. We'll find out the estimated arrival date of the Express and leave before they arrive."

The idea of it was… Frankly it was intoxicating. It included all the fantasy of running away without the subsequent consequences. And maybe the distance would help. He had spent millions of years within Styxia, yes, but nowhere near as many as he had within Okhema. The world had never ended in *Styxia.* Maybe his blood would cool when surrounded by shoreline and endless sea.

Phainon couldn't believe he was actually *considering* it.

"Won't it still be empty?" He asked.

"I don't know," Mydei said. "Maybe it will be. Would you not want to go if it is?"

He shook his head. "I don't care either way."

"Neither would I. I don't think anyone we would bring with us would mind either. What do you think? Would going help?"

Would it?

It would certainly lessen the paranoia that the geniuses had brought into existence but it wasn't as if they were solving some sort of historical issue. That worry was a relatively new thing. Or rather, the *genius* aspect to it was. Running away to avoid a single conversation felt like a disproportionate reaction.

But since when did he care so much about a disproportionate reaction of all things? The cycles had made him act irrationally many times. He couldn't count the number of overreactions or *under-reactions* he'd enacted during his time trapped within them. Did it really matter? He didn't think it did.

All that really mattered was whether he wanted to go or not.

Phainon took a deep breath. In and out. Then, he pulled himself free from Mydei's arms and met the man's golden gaze with his own.

"Alright," Phainon said. His voice wavered with uncertainty even as he nodded his head. "I don't know if it'd help but… alright. Let's do it."

Mydei's lips lifted into a small, relieved smile. "I'll sort out the details. You'll need to focus on getting your strength back for the trip. Can you do that?"

"Yeah," Phainon said. And it didn't feel an altogether impossible task. Or, at least, it'd be far easier than bearing the fate of Amphoreus upon his shoulders. "I can do that."

Chapter 27

Chapter Notes

> as always, thank you to everyone for reading and leaving comments!! i'm always super happy to read through them!! also, at some point recently we broke 7k kudos which is WILD to me?? y'all are crazy. i'm endlessly glad you're all enjoying this fic and my deep-dive into exploring phainon's character.
>
> please enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Your pegasus is *broken."*

The words may have been thrown towards Hyacine as she opened the door into his room but Phainon was staring at Little Ica who had claimed his lap as a pillow and had been turning her pudgy chin up in offence at his offering of a honey-soaked wafer. For the last fifteen minutes the little creature had been ignoring the sugary treat as if it had been poisoned.

Obviously it had not.

Little Ica had *watched* him open the packet that had once housed it. She knew that the food had not been tampered with since Phainon's hands had lifted it out of the packaging. And yet every time he held the wafer out for her, growing increasingly worried *and* irritated with each passing minute, Ica's beady eyes rolled and she would let out an exasperated nicker.

"She's not broken," Hyacine said in lieu of any greeting.

"Something's clearly wrong with her," Phainon said. He lifted the sweet up so that she could see, clearly, what it was that they were dealing with. Hyacine raised an eyebrow but otherwise looked far less worried than he would've expected for such a dire situation. "Little Ica *never* turns down food. Little glutton."

"While that *may* be true—"

"It is. That thing has a problem."

"—there's nothing wrong with Ica. She just doesn't want to take your food."

Phainon narrowed his eyes at Ica. "What's wrong my food?"

Little Ica met his gaze and let out a stern '*doot'*. She had clearly learned the tone from Hyacine - It was the tone she used on particularly troublesome patients.

"I think she'd much rather you eat it yourself," Hyacine said.

He scowled and dropped the wafer back into its packet. When even the poster girl for the fucking *Voracity* refused food from you, it really put things into perspective.

"I'm not going to have it," he said and fixed his most unimpressed look onto the pegasus. Ica blinked. Unaffected. "It's just going to be thrown out."

She still did not take it.

Phainon sighed and, in a fit of righteous indignance, lifted the pegasus from his lap. Then he dropped her onto an abandoned blanket at the far end of his mattress. All very quick. All with very little fanfare.

Letting out a loud whinny, Ica's little eyes filled with betrayal. She whirled her head around to Hyacine - who lifted her into her arms - and burrowed her face into the crook of the healer's elbow until all that could be seen was mane and the edge of her horn. Hyacine patted her mane reassuringly.

"It's not like you to waste food," She said.

Phainon's eyes narrowed and something in his chest fizzled. He was surprised that it wasn't an empty cavity filled only with ashes at this point with how familiar the feeling was becoming. "I'm *not.* I already told you all that I don't need to eat—"

"Oh," Hyacine lifted her chin to look at him. Her eyes widened. "Oh. No. *No.* That wasn't aimed at you. I was talking to Ica."

Phainon scoffed and turned his head. "Sure."

"No, really," Hyacine continued, "it was meant for Ica. You already explained—"

"I *know,"* he huffed. It wasn't like he was blind to the fact that he was being defensive and taking the words out of context. Phainon was *very* aware of the fact that he was being irrational. It was just that the added awareness didn't exactly help to settle him; If anything, it only served to irritate him further. Despite knowing it was the truth, his brain still had difficulty *believing* it. "I'm just being an asshole. I know you didn't mean it like that."

"Oh. Alright then." Hyacine said.

They fell into what he could only describe as awkward silence until Ica let out a small huff. Then, Hyacine said, "Where's Mydei?"

Phainon jerked a thumb towards the hall. "He's talking Styxia details with Castorice. They were being loud so I kicked them out."

Or… Well, alright, it was less that they were being loud and more that they were talking at all.

He'd woken a little wound up. Again. Lifting his mood back into something sunny was clearly going to be a long-term goal and not an immediate one because most mornings Phainon woke with the overwhelming urge to yell at the sun for daring to wake him. Today he was having a little more difficulty shaking the agitation off.

So when Castorice and Mydei had started talking about the logistics of their upcoming trip and where they could buy adequate camping supplies in a city still struggling to its feet, it had become very apparent that he needed them to get out before he lost his temper.

"Alright," Hyacine said.

He turned back to her. Currently, hesitation bled from each part of her body - from the tighter hold of Ica to the bite of his lip. It had been a permanent fixture in the week and a half since he'd woken from his impromptu coma. Phainon may have apologised for snapping at her upon first waking in the hospital - and for the subsequent times it had happened since - but things with Hyacine had been tense ever since. Or maybe tense wasn't the right word.

Awkward.

Things had been *awkward.*

It was mostly his fault, he knew that. It was hard to interact with the human equivalent of a pipe bomb. It typically led to a whole lot of worry about when he would next explode. Hyacine wasn't used to being on the receiving end of an anger like this. Especially not *his*. She wasn't like Mydei, who was used to the burn of war and bloodshed. Nor was she like Castorice, who had dealt with the ire of those she had been forced to execute as the Maiden of Death.

She was just… well, *Hyacine.*

As a healer, she was used to different types of anger. Bitterness stemming from chronic conditions. The indignance that came from grief? Part of her training included offering a welcome ear to any who needed it.

But this? This all consuming rage that made him shut everyone out, that made him want to tear things to pieces and made him a stranger in his own thoughts?

Hyacine was a doctor, not a psychologist. As much as she tried to understand the emotions simmering inside of him, it was a difficult thing to comprehend in the span of ten days. It was an even harder task trying to figure out a way to help without making everything worse. Hence the awkwardness that had slithered its way into the space between them.

She tried her best to pretend that it wasn't there but it was. And Phainon was too tired to pretend that it wasn't.

A lot of the time he was too tired to even pretend that he wasn't an asshole.

"Are you feeling up to doing some exercises?"

He didn't but Phainon also didn't want to be here when the Astral Express returned so he wasn't willing not to. Instead, he dipped his head in a small nod and let Hyacine take the lead, guiding him through the routine of exercises that she'd put together to help strengthen his muscles and bring him back to something resembling good health.

It was easy to get lost in thought throughout the exercises - and safer too, if wanting to keep his temper in check - so Phainon fell quiet and let himself think.

In the ten days since Mydei had promised that they would leave Okhema for a break, Phainon had taken some time to figure out what exactly it was that he had done to his body by handling time so heavily.

Some things were obvious. By depleting the coreflames he had invited in the cold - his internal temperature had plummeted and hypothermia had sunk in. Cyrene's ice hadn't exactly helped either but that was neither here not there. Hyacine had - in the moments where she was acting more doctor than friend - warned him against depleting the coreflames' energy to such a degree again.

But hypothermia hadn't been the biggest issue.

The biggest issue had been the internal bleeding.

It was difficult to know in full what had caused the backlash with his shoddy understanding of his own powers but time had definitely lashed back. Or rather, it had been the balance of the universe pushing back against him? He'd gone against the flow of existence and whatever kept existence in check had swatted him aside like a bug that was causing more damage than it was worth.

Apparently he was lucky to be alive. The force would've killed most outright but there was something in his golden blood that had kept him

alive.

So it seemed he was less of a bug and more of a cockroach.

Castorice, having updated the Astral Express on the situation prior to his waking, had mentioned during one of her visits that the Nameless, Welt, had theorised that it was highly possible that the Equilibrium had caught hold of his meddling and caused his injuries Themself. Apparently time was one of those things They were especially particular about.

Hopefully the theory wasn't based in truth. Phainon was already fed up with the Aeons he'd already encountered.

And regardless, he doubted he'd have encountered another one so soon after the others.

Didn't most of the universe go their entire life chasing Aeons only to avoid their notice? Surely he wouldn't be *that* unlucky to cross paths with another.

"Yes," Hyacine said, cutting through his thoughts. "That's great. Should we try doing a circuit of the ward?"

Phainon huffed but nodded. "Sure."

Walking was a slow task.

Most things were. Though the coreflames grew stronger with each passing second, the rest of his body still prioritised healing the damage that should've killed him. His body ached and when he walked it trembled with such intensity that Hyacine forced him several times to slide to the floor with his shoulders pressed against the wall until he finally caught his breath.

It was frustrating not having full control over his body. Having it fight against him.

(He was used to it but that didn't make it any less irritating.)

Even if Hyacine took great lengths to remind him that he was healing at an unprecedented speed. To be two weeks into recovery post-coma and already

capable of walking on his own two feet was a greater feat than he seemed to think it was. Most people with injuries like him took far longer to walk and, when they did, they didn't manage circuits around the ward. They managed a few *steps* with the aid of parallel bars.

Oh. And he was still growing the fucking wings. That didn't help with the healing either. It just made the process of healing even more excruciatingly slow.

Today they managed two circuits and a half before Hyacine put her foot down and forced Phainon into a wheelchair. They passed Mydei and Castorice planning as she wheeled him back to his room and, when Mydei offered they come back to keep him company, Phainon glared until the Kremnoan acquiesced and promised that they would come back when finished. Apparently, they would be finished within the quint.

Back in his room - and wasn't it a shame that he was starting to associate this hospital room as being *his?* - he muttered, "I could've managed three."

"Healing isn't a race," Hyacine replied, helping him back into bed. She reached over to the radio that one of the triplets had left for him, tuned in to some intergalactic broadcast from a nearby star system, and clicked it on. "We only started these circuits a few days ago. You're making good progress."

Phainon grunted, dropped onto his pillow and pulled his blanket over his head.

"I'll let you get some rest," Hyacine said and left him to his news broadcast.

He waited until her footsteps - and Ica's whinnying - echoed into nothingness, then pulled the blanket down from his face and altered his pillow so he could comfortably sit upright. Eyes half closed, he tilted his head back against the pillow and let himself be calmed by a mix of news broadcast and music.

'Hevelius-197's Diamidiata space station, which has seen further expansion following sale to the IPC, will be switching its intergalactic travel

restrictions across to the galactic standard from 19th May, 0200 IGST. The Diamidiata space station is responsible for transporting billions of people across Hevelius-197 and, in recent years, has begun to offer intergalactic star transport travel packages. We're here with—'

"Hey Delivery Boy."

Phainon's nose scrunched and he opened his eyes just enough to glower.

"Don't call me that," he snarled.

It was the first time he had seen Cipher within the Era Nova and though he knew he should greet her with some degree of welcome, she'd chosen the worst time to appear from nowhere. Stood in the doorway of his hospital room, her tail swishing in slow, unhurried flicks, she looked nonchalant in a way that only *she* truly ever managed to be.

She was utterly unaffected by his glare and weaved her way inside towards the cabinet at the far end of the room without a second glance his way. There, she reached for the bag Mydei had brought for his extended stay by Phainon's side. Not even a minute had passed and she was already rifling through Mydei's things as if there would be something of interest inside.

"But you *are* the deliverer, aren't you?" She drawled and lifted a necklace from the bag. Appraising it, she hummed. "It's what I've always called you. Delivery boy. It suits you."

Phainon's teeth ground with such ferocity that he was pretty sure that he could taste bone. "I am *not* the Deliverer."

"Oho, look at you getting all riled up." Cipher said. "Let me guess, Gray Mystery is? Sure. She *delivered*. But she's not exactly our Deliverer, is she?"

"Did you come here just to aggravate me and steal Mydei's things?" Phainon spat.

Cipher raised a brow. "And if I did?"

The blanket in his lap caught fire.

Cipher's tail twitched. Raising her hands in surrender she said, "Easy, easy, you're taking me too seriously. I *actually* came bearing gifts."

Sighing, Phainon batted at the flames until they died. "…Why does everyone keep trying to *give me things?"*

It seemed a trend at this point. His memoria blanket from Cyrene - currently folded and tucked away out of sight because seeing it reminded him of how angry he still was at her. The sweater Castorice had made him. The coat from Aglaea. His new radio from the triplets.

Even Anaxa - *Anaxa* - had send him a droma plushie alongside a note promising that he would not attempt to push Phainon like he had again.

(Mydei had asked him if he was going to name the little plushie to which he had answered that he was not five and thus, would not be. At which point the Kremnoan had smirked and dubbed his plushie *'The Fierce Beast of Kremnos: Kokopo the Fourth'*.

Phainon had let him know *very* quickly that Mydei could fuck off because it was not his dromas to name and that '*Kokopo the Fourth'* was just as stupid a name as '*Kokopo the Third.')*

"Who cares why? Getting free stuff is *always* the best, don't you think?"

Unimpressed, he simply looked at her and remained quiet. Once a thief, always a thief.

Like with everything else within Amphoreus, Cipher did not change.

"Anyway, you absolutely want my gift. Trust me. Hold out your hands." When he didn't do so immediately, Cipher clicked her tongue at him and pointed at them. "Go on pretty boy, hold them out."

Phainon raised a brow. "*Pretty boy?"*

"If delivery boy's off the table then we'll settle for this. Unless you want to be flame boy instead? Though that doesn't have the vibe that I'm really going for. It's pretty boy or bust, I'm 'fraid."

Rolling his eyes, Phainon cupped his hands and held them out. It was better than dignifying her with any response to his new nickname.

Pocketing Mydei's necklace - really, he wasn't surprised - Cipher grinned and sauntered forwards. With a swish of her wrist and a small burst of smoke, multiple pieces of cool rock clacked into his palms. When the smoke dissipated and he looked down, his body stiffened.

In his hands were multiple fragments of golden rock. Old pieces of a mosaic that he couldn't bare to see in one piece. His temperature rose at the sight, instinctual and blazing.

"Are you *mocking* me?" He asked, voice scraped raw.

"Mm?"

"This isn't a *present,"* Phainon snapped. He jerked his chin towards the pieces of a puzzle that had once been Kephale. "Do you think it's funny to give me this?"

Cipher blinked at him. Once. Then a second time. Before, she'd been grinning but now she was simply watching him without much expression on her face.

"I don't think it's funny at all," she said.

"Then—" His indignance did not fizzle out but it gave way, momentarily, to confusion. She had to have been mocking him. Clearly, she'd seen him that night at Kephale plaza. He'd thought that she was a hallucination but considering how Cyrene had known about his destruction of Okhema's infrastructure, she'd clearly been the real deal. Had it been coincidence that she had seen or had she been *following* him? "What is *this?"*

"The pieces of that old mural." Cipher lifted her arms and stretched, arching her back as she did so. Her bones cracked."It was pretty boring going around and searching for pieces of Kephale but here's the fruits of my labor. Pretty sure this is everything. You wanted to destroy this, right?"

He could feel his cheeks burning. A mixture of defensiveness and rage. "I— No. Maybe. What's it to you?"

"Well, I don't exactly like that old thing either." She shrugged. "I did all the work in keeping the Sky Father's lights on for seven hundred years and everyone goes around thanking *him* for it? Personally, I think *this* cat deserves her own mural instead. Out with the old, in with the *mew.*"

"What?"

"I'm saying that if you want to burn it or whatever then you should go right ahead. Or, I guess if you don't want to then I'll just go throw them in the sea or something. I know *all* the best places."

For a moment, he just stared at her.

Then Phainon tilted his chin down and stared at the gold painted pieces of rock in his hands.

He curled his fingers around them and took a deep breath as they started to crumble into ash. Then he said, "I really hate that stupid fucking mural. I have for— for *forever."*

Cipher hummed. "It must feel good to destroy it."

It was probably awful of him to agree. To admit that he felt good about destroying pieces of Amphoreus' history and that the thrum of destruction caught in his chest each time he broke something to such a degree that it felt *satisfying* in a way that nothing else did. It was one of those things that he'd expected to keep hidden and locked away for the rest of his life. The kind of admission that showed how truly rotten he'd become after everything. He really ought to keep it a secret.

But he nodded anyway.

His fellow Chrysos Heirs already knew that he was an awful person. There was no reason to try and hide it from them.

"Well then," Cipher said. "If it feels good, then how about we go break some things?"

Chapter End Notes

> in case you were wondering, IGST stands for *'Intergalactic Standard Time'*. sometimes I just wanna throw random worldbuilding into fics and thus, i gave in to that urge completely. i don't have to kill ALL my darlings. just a few of them.
>
> ~~"i don't have to kill ALL my darlings. just a few of them." - i can see khaslana saying this at least once for the irony. poor guy~~

Chapter 28

Chapter Notes

> I really didn't mean to take so long between last chapter update and this one!! But I got pretty unwell with a chest infection and then, while trying to recover from *that* I moved house. And we only got internet back yesterday so like, here we are.
>
> I've been excited for this chapter and the next one is going to be a lot of fun for me too. We're definitely not too many chapters off reaching the end of Act 2! Hopefully I'll be able to update a little more frequently and complete in the next month or two!!
>
> Thanks again to everyone for reading and leaving comments. I appreciate them all! I hope you continue to enjoy the fic as we continue!! <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon really shouldn't have been as tempted by Cipher's offer as he was.

But the fact was this: The idea of indulging in destruction was so enticing that he was nodding before he could even think of the possible repercussions. He had no idea what Cipher even meant by *'breaking some things'*. For all he knew, she could have been meaning for them to demolish Kephale's statue at Dawncloud.

And really? The shameful truth was that if she *had* meant that, he wasn't sure whether he would've denied the offer. If anything, the idea was all the more inviting than simple property damage. It almost made him want to agree to her offer *more*.

The right thing to do in such a situation would be to ask for more details. To learn what exactly Cipher was asking of him and then report to Mydei and Castorice if said offer be handed to him by a poor influence. The *right* thing would be to sit and wait and have her pitch things to them as a trio. To not

be drawn in by the words of a person actively poking at the worst parts of him and telling him that it was time to *indulge.*

But Phainon hadn't been doing the 'right' thing recently, just the impulsive, and so instead of doing any of that he pointed to the wheelchair that Hyacine had been carting him around in recently and said, "I can't walk too far."

Cipher waved the worry away with a hand. "I'll get us where we need to go. Don't you worry your tired little legs."

A frown furrowed his brows but there was no point in arguing. He *was* tired.

"All I need is for you to be standing." Her smile sharpened. "You know how my coin works."

He sure did.

All too well. In early cycles, he'd raced her with a coin of his own. (Or, really, it had been re-homed to his pockets from the Ciphera of a previous life). In later ones, he'd used Cipher's own coin to chase her down and rip free the trickery coreflame from her chest.

At this point he was more of an expert on using the coin of whimsy than even Trickery was.

"Yeah," he muttered and began struggling to his feet in an attempt to hide his rising bitterness. "I know how it works."

Standing was difficult. With his strength as depleted as it was, his circuit through the hospital bay had taken most of his energy. It was hard to pull himself up onto both feet, his legs unresponsive and his arms so, *so* tired, but between the support of his bedside cabinet and the lowered rails of his hospital bed he managed. Didn't even collapse. Which was nice.

And throughout it all Cipher simply waited. There was no offer to help him to his feet. She did not watch him with worried eyes or start chewing on her

lip in an effort to stave off rising anxiety. She simply watched and waited.

Something unfurled in his chest at the realisation that she wasn't asking if he needed help. That she wasn't *going* to ask.

Cipher waited until he was stable on his legs, at which point she pointed to his radio and said, "Breaking things is always more fun with a soundtrack. We're bringing this."

Not a question but a demand.

Phainon hadn't realised how tense his shoulders were until they began to relax. He huffed, "Yeah, whatever, I don't care."

With a snap of her fingers the radio disappeared into a void of nothingness. The sound emitted by it remained - the broadcast had since moved on to a speculative report on the death of several star systems beyond *Hevelius-197* - but the radio was nowhere to be seen. An interesting move on Trickery's behalf. Simultaneously, Cipher was both tricking and solidifying his grasp of reality, keeping his senses rooted in reality while ridding them of the need to physically bring his radio with them to do so.

How interesting trickery could be. He hadn't used the coreflame as much as the others. When his strength returned, he'd need to search to see what its limitations were. Not to the same extent as with Orynyx's coreflames to turn back time - he had clearly learned his lesson and continued to learn it, even after all these weeks. Trickery's foundation was in fooling reality, after all. Use too much and reality bends in a way that couldn't be predicted. It had the potential to cause a lot more trouble than turning back time. If one tricked reality successfully with enough power, the applications were limitless.

"Oh! I think I can hear footsteps." Cipher drew him from his thoughts, cheerful and lighthearted. "We best be off before your little prince and our princess homebody come and ruin all of our fun."

She said that but she hadn't immediately whisked them away with the coin of whimsy. Instead, Cipher's gaze settled onto him, awaiting his final

verdict. Waiting for a more explicit *'yes, let's go make shit decisions'*. One last opportunity for him to turn her down if he so desired it.

…Phainon really did not want to spend the rest of the day in bed struggling to keep his temper in check. If he had to, then he would be liable to snap and that wouldn't be good for anyone.

And really, he wanted to break things. He did.

"I can hear them too," Phainon said, slowly. "Throw the coin."

Cipher took hold of him and threw the coin.

The world blurred like something out of a kaleidoscopic fever dream. The edges of buildings concaved, the world squished together and reality seemed to blend into itself like a bundle of ink forming a Rorschach blot. The trickery coreflame always made his vision swim whenever it was used in this way - a little like using one of the Trailblaze's waypoints but accompanied by all the added lag of a world struggling to catch up.

Travelling this way used to make him nauseous.

As the cycles had gone on though, much like everything else, Phainon got used to it. Now, all he felt as they moved was a bout of dizziness. And even that was more a symptom of his body's current weakness than that of the trickery coreflame itself.

"Looking a little pale, pretty boy," Cipher sang, and snatched the coin from the air.

The world solidified. It felt a little like gravity and motion was snapping at their heels, richocheting back into place like the return of a rubber band that had been pulled taut before being let go. Phainon stumbled back on shaky legs, remaining on his feet only because Cipher was holding him up. Bright colours still danced at the back of his eyelids in the aftermath of their movement.

…Alright, maybe the coin still affected him when he wasn't at his best. If he wasn't sustaining himself off of the coreflames and was in the habit of eating, Phainon was pretty sure he'd have thrown up all over Cipher's boots.

"Waypoints are better," he groaned.

"Waypoints are *boooring,"* Cipher said. "And so much slower. They're inconvenient. Chasing gold is so much better."

…She said it like the coin of whimsy was made of gold. It was not.

Phainon huffed out a sigh. As the dizziness began to fade he turned to take in his surroundings and tried to figure out what exactly it was that they were here to destroy.

They had moved outside of Okhema. Having travelled past the western entrance to the city, they now stood within a field that had been decimated during the fight with Irontomb. Fire - *his* flames - had razed the earth and left it inhospitable to any signs of life. There would be no more farming in this spot. Not for a long time.

Since it was no longer a place for growth, it had been repurposed as a waste site.

While not containing the entirety of the rubble and debris from Okhema's streets, the scorched field housed a large percentage of it. Piles of broken roof tiles had been tossed alongside half broken pottery. Crumbling pillars had been rolled into place beside scraps of fabric and snapped children's toys. Anything that had been deemed *'too broken'* had been brought to this place and left to be dealt with at a later time.

Phainon's gaze locked on to a half-burnt droma plushie, stuffing pushing free from the gap in its body like spilled organs. His lips pulled into a grimace.

"Everything here is already broken," he said, blankly, as Cipher let him go and stepped out of his personal space. "You said we were going to break things but they're already broken."

When he looked over his shoulder to her, Cipher's brow quirked. "Is that a problem?"

He… wasn't sure.

If he was thinking about it properly, there was a certain satisfaction that came from breaking something that was in one piece versus something that was in multiple. It was going too far to say that it was more *interesting* but there was a certain amusement to be found in watching something go from being perfectly *intact* to *decimated.*

…You just didn't care about damaged things as much. Damaged housewares got thrown away. Damaged buildings got demolished. Damaged people—

Phainon cleared his throat. "I don't know."

"Well, think about it this way," Cipher said, "that mural was in pieces but it still felt pretty fucking good to destroy it even further, right?"

Right.

Yes. That had felt *good* even if the mural had already been ruled unable to be repaired.

"Yeah," he agreed.

"So, what's the difference?" Cipher asked.

When she put it that way, he supposed that there wasn't one. Not really. His expectations were being subverted but they were still being met. In some ways erasing ruined things could be seen as therapeutic. No more eye-sores. Only that which was functional would remain.

It didn't quite scratch that itch at the depths of his core but that was alright. Delving into such primal parts of himself probably wasn't the best idea anyway. The last time he'd gotten truly lost in that primal side of himself he'd destroyed Aedes Elysiae. He didn't want to do something like that again.

"For the sake of right now," he said, "I suppose there isn't one."

A smirk curled Cipher's lips. "Perfect."

Casting his gaze back to the field, Phainon found that he wasn't entirely sure how to start. If he wanted to be efficient then he could simply tear open space and let everything be consumed within a black hole. But that also seemed too impersonal for something like this. Too *quick.* It wasn't destruction so much as it was erasure.

"Oh, let me guess what *that* look means," Cipher said, stalking closer. She pressed a fist to her lips, as if deep in thought, before grinning toothily. "There's no point if it's not fun, right? That's what you're thinking?"

He wasn't justifying that with an answer. Phainon simply waited for her to continue.

"Not indulging me, huh? Oh, you're no fun." She sighed. "Okay, fine. No foreplay wanted in this little situation, I've got it. Here - you'll want to use this."

And with a click of her fingers and a burst of technicolor sparks, her outstretched hand went from holding nothing to holding a bat.

Phainon blinked.

Yep. That was definitely a bat.

It was a glossy shade of obsidian lined with swirling gold curves. The handle was indented with carvings, a series of chimera faces and kitten paws.

"It's not *quite* Grey Mystery's one," Cipher said, as she held it out. "Trust me, I *tried* nabbing it, but that girl's got some sort of anti-theft magic going on via path space that means she's able to re-summon it no matter how many times I relocate it into my pockets. I'm not going to lie - I reckon it's rude of her. She should just let me take it. Here. Take it."

Hesitant, Phainon reached for the weapon. Compared to Dawnmaker it was weightless. Even weak as he currently was it felt like he was holding air.

"It's a trickery exclusive," Cipher said. "What do you think?"

As a weapon, it didn't suit him. Beating things to death via blunt force trauma hadn't ever held much appeal. He was much more suited to a blade. Hacking and slicing.

Holding something that didn't suit him as far as weaponry went however… it was probably for the best.

He glanced at the hilt again and said, "…The chimeras are cute."

"Our pretty boy has good taste," Cipher said and scooped down to retrieve a sorry excuse for a jug that was missing it's handle. It also had a long crack running from spout to base. "Here. Aim for a home-run, alright?"

Phainon did not know what a home-run was but when Cipher tossed the jug into the air he assumed it meant that she wanted him to swing.

So he did.

The jug exploded. Shards rained onto dirt like a hailstorm. A thin coat of dust lingered by the bat, much slower in its fall to the earth.

"Good?" Cipher asked.

Phainon nodded. "Good."

"Again?" Cipher asked, lifting another nod with a warped lip that had half melted in the blaze. He lifted his bat in anticipation. "Time to let loose. I've got a whole pile of these bad boys for us to get through."

The last time Phainon fully let loose, he lost an arm, two wings and fought God. It was not necessarily the best idea for him to do that again. Letting loose only a little would have to do.

It was easy to distract himself with broken ceramics. Jugs and plates shattered in a way that brought satisfaction no matter how heavy hitting the swing. It was almost understandable why Stelle always went around swinging her own bat. Phainon could get used to using one.

…Thinking of Stelle, he really did have to call her back on his teleslate soon. He'd been avoiding her messages ever since she'd told him of the Geniuses and while he wasn't willing to tell her about his upcoming trip to Styxia, he didn't want to ignore her completely. She was Amphoreus' saviour. *His* saviour.

"Hey, pretty boy," Cipher said, when their current pile of crockery had been dwindled into dust and shards too small to shatter further with the swing of a bat. "Do you… *like* Amphoreus?"

Huh?

His surprise must've slipped free because Cipher tilted her head and said, "Indulge me a little before we start on the glassware. Do you?"

Phainon's hold of the bat tightened. Voice flat, he said, "I went through everything for Amphoreus. I love it."

Loved it.

Cipher wagged a finger, clicking her tongue. "Nuh-uh. That's not answering what I was asked."

"…Amphoreus is my home."

"But," she said, forcefully. "Do you *like* it?"

Why was she asking?

Why?

The words were torn from his throat as if she'd reached inside of him and scraped them free with her claws. Voice raw, Phainon grit out, "…No."

And then, because he had already started and the admission couldn't be taken back: "No. I don't. I *hate* it here. It's— It's hell. I thought the Era Nova was supposed to be *better* but I still hate it here."

Something akin to shame started to climb up each notch of his larynx, as if trying to tear itself free from the depths of his rotting soul. He should've liked Amphoreus, shouldn't he? Should've loved the coastline and the people and the very *earth* that he'd spent so many years protecting.

But he didn't.

Sometimes, thinking of Amphoreus made his skin crawl. While others celebrated the planet's emergence alongside the wider galaxy all Phainon felt was nauseous. They had sacrificed everything time and time again, and that was great for everyone *else*. All *he* felt was a net loss. After everything, the end result didn't really feel worth it.

Cipher nodded as if she'd been expecting the words.

"Too many shitty memories?" She asked.

The shame was taking up too much space in his mouth to speak so instead, Phainon dipped his head in a small nod. His hair fell over his eyes and though he knew Cipher was still watching him, it offered a degree of separation from the conversation that lessened the roiling sickness that had begun coalescing in his stomach.

"Thought so," Cipher said. "I get like that with Okhema. A little distance always helps."

"That's part of why we're going to Styxia," Phainon said, slowly.

"But that's not really getting distance, is it?" she asked. Her voice shifted into something more contemplative. It felt strange to hear the tone, compared to her typical mischievous drawl. "It gets you away from Okhema but you've probably got shitty memories all over the planet. Is going to Styxia going to help?"

His brows furrowed. "Well it's not like anywhere else is going to be any better. Styxia is— it's better than being here."

"Oh wow, a minimal passing grade." The return to a drawl was more sarcastic than mischievous. Pointed. As if waiting for him to get the point. "Just what I've always wanted. A pile of shit that's just a tiny bit better than the shit I'm already stuck with."

His jaw clenched. His fingernails dug into the bat with enough force that he heard the wood splinter. "Don't."

Raising her hands in surrender, Cipher said, "Okay, okay. All I'm trying to say is that if you need distance from *Amphoreus,* why aren't you *leaving*?"

The question was simple and yet it made his thoughts quieten.

He'd never considered leaving Amphoreus before. In part because there was always a need for the Eternal Recurrence to continue that required his ongoing presence. But even without the weight of the cycles on his shoulders, the space beyond the sky wasn't meant for Amphoreans. They were just code, after all.

…They might not be coded people anymore. But it still wasn't possible.

It wasn't.

"I can't just *leave* Amphoreus."

Cipher scrunched her brows to almost comical proportions. It made it difficult to take her seriously. Perhaps that was purposeful though - instead of getting angry and lashing out, he was bordering more on dismissive. "Why not?"

"Amphoreus needs me."

"*Amphoreus* can survive long enough for you to take a trip."

"It's my home—"

"—That you don't even *like.* And either way, people leave home all the time. I did. *You* did. This time it'll even be here when you want to come back."

Phainon heaved a sigh from his nose. Air whistled from his nostrils like a warning flare.

"Maybe if I had wings, I'd be able to just *leave* but I *don't* have wings. The only way off this planet right now is via the Astral Express and that's *not* going to happen. Styxia is the best option I've got."

One of Cipher's ears twitched. Then, they both perked up. Her tail followed suit as a grin transformed her lips. It was the sort of look that she had before stealing an expensive gemstone or some ancient relic promised to sell for extortionate amounts.

"You've got it all wrong pretty boy," she said. "You've got all those Trickery coreflames inside you. With enough belief, travel past the skies will be a *breeze.* You just need a decent base to build your trick from."

She paused. Whether to gauge his interest or for dramatic effect, it was difficult to say. He waited, not sure whether he *was* interested or not. Phainon was certainly *sceptical*, at least.

"Lucky for you," Cipher finally said, which made him think that the pause really *was* for dramatic effect after all. "I've got the perfect idea for your base." She lifted the coin of Whimsy. "You don't need to commit but there's no reason not to check it out, right?"

"What's the idea?"

"You were partially right when you said the Nameless were the only ones who could get you off Amphoreus right now." Cipher said, rolling the coin between her fingers. "Grey mystery got here in one of those train cars, right? We just need to go back to the crash site and use it."

Chapter End Notes

I have a LOT of fun thinking about all the different ways I can play with the coreflames. Let it be known that EVERY single one will get it's moment to shine in this fic, one way or another. I *will* find a way.

End Notes

twitter, if you want ramblings, fic pitches and the likes.

Works inspired by this one

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!